

# Phil 304 Nietzsche: Further Down the Rabbit Hole

*Numbered Transcript*

PHIL 304 • Dr. Jordan B. Peterson

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## Lecture 1: Wrestling with Nietzsche

**At a glance** — Peterson wrestles with Nietzsche, going deeper into Beyond Good and Evil.

- 1.1 So this is Nietzsche, into the depths of good and evil. I provide an introduction to Beyond Good and Evil, which is the philosopher's most famous book. This is Further Down the Rabbit Hole, you might say, and it's also designed as a standalone course—although the other course adds some additional context and some initial analysis. We're going to delve as deeply as we possibly can over the course of these eight lectures into the structure of this revolutionary book, which I found personally extremely illuminating. Why? Because Nietzsche asked very profound questions.
- 1.2 How would you characterize a profound question? There's a school of academic inquiry that's devoted to assessing the quality and impact of scientific research. The criteria they use for judging impact is essentially citation. So citation is the use of a published work or conference presentation, sometimes a personal communication, as a reference in another published work. And the theory is that the broader the citation distribution, the more impact the work.
- 1.3 You could think about that as a hierarchy: the more impact an idea has, the more fundamental the idea. The broader range of other ideas it affects, and the farther down it is the presumption hierarchy—that's a bit of a harder concept. A foundational idea is an idea that many other ideas depend on.
- 1.4 Part of the reason that people very much dislike having their foundational ideas challenged is because much of the perceptual structure that they use to simplify the world is demolished if the foundational principles are violated. That's why there's a joke: when children are playing a ball game and someone gets upset and decides to take their ball and go home. The ball is a fundamental presupposition of the game. The game doesn't continue without the ball. There are minor violations of rules that you could manifest and the game could continue, but bringing the ball home pretty much ends it.
- 1.5 Your thought—more than your thought—the integrity of your perception is dependent on a hierarchy of presuppositions that you hold as unquestioned. They're like game rules, except it's multitude of games with rules all the way down— increasing disruption attendant on challenge to the most fundamental ideas.
- 1.6 An easy analog to that is a marriage contract. So one of the fundamental elements of a marriage contract, insofar as it's even vaguely traditional, is sexual fidelity. Now, the presumption of sexual fidelity stabilizes your perceptions of your wife or your husband. It helps you bind them comprehensibly so that you can make certain assumptions about the nature of your relationship—past relationship, present, and future. If that presumption is violated, then all of that's up for grabs, and maybe even more.

- 1.7 So for example, if you contractually arranged a marriage with someone, and then 10 years into it, you found out that they had betrayed you repeatedly back into the past, not only is the past and the present and the future of your relationship thrown into question at every level, including that of memory, but your presumption about who you are and how you understand people—or even who people are— also shakes.
- 1.8 Nietzsche was a profound thinker because he went to the bottom of things and shook them up. And that was very useful for me in laying the groundwork for my investigations, my thought, because he helped me identify what was foundational. Now, I read Nietzsche a long time ago. I started reading it when I was 17, something like that. It was very hard on me because having your fundamental presuppositions challenged is very hard on you. That's why Nietzsche said he philosophized with a hammer. But doing that voluntarily forces you to become conscious, explicitly conscious, of things that you might not otherwise understand. And the trouble that emerges in consequence of that prepares you to engage in all sorts of challenging intellectual exercises that you might otherwise avoid.
- 1.9 As I've got older—and we'll delve into this a lot during this lecture series— I've also understood that Nietzsche was stunningly wrong about many things—as was Freud. But there are thinkers who are—Ernest Becker is like this, too. He wrote a great book called *The Denial of Death*, which attempted to bring closure to Freudian psychoanalysis. It's a brilliant book, but fundamentally it's wrong. But in some ways, it's tricky.
- 1.10 There are very useful ways of being wrong. There are very interesting ways of being wrong. There are profound and shallow ways of being wrong. And so someone can lead an investigation and get an awful long ways and draw conclusions that are, in the final analysis, imperfect, that are still useful as you progress towards a more solid and profound understanding.
- 1.11 So we'll outline what Nietzsche accomplished in *Beyond Good and Evil*, published in 1886, and we'll also discuss at least my opinion—I don't know if it's an opinion exactly—my conclusions.
- 1.12 An opinion is something casual. A conclusion is something you come to after sifting evidence for hours—or thousands of hours—with respect, and attempting to find not only the error, but what's useful, and then attempting to replace it with something that has all the advantages of what you're criticizing, plus something more. It's a painstaking exercise, separating the wheat from the chaff.
- 1.13 One of the problems with a shallow approach to past scholarship is that the devil is never given his due. My experience with casual readers, casual thinkers, casual academics or corrupt academics—and there's plenty of those corrupt intellects—is that they read to find a statement that violates their presuppositions, especially on the casual moral front. Then they throw the baby out with the bathwater.

- 1.14 With great thinkers, that's not helpful. Freud is a great example. Freud insisted that the sexual motivation was the foundational motivation, and that's not right. But it's not a trivial idea, and it is a very powerful motivation. And so to understand Freud, you can note that his initial presumption was fundamentally incorrect, but that many of his detailed observations were unbelievably useful.
- 1.15 But to do that, you have to go through the work very carefully, and you can't take the easy route out of finding something that you stumble over that violates one of your prejudices even more than your presuppositions, and deciding you're just going to dispense with the whole corpus.
- 1.16 Freud is often criticized, for example, for his hypothetical sexism. It's like, he wrote 140 years ago. You might as well take that into account. It's a casual prejudice of the modern age that past thinkers who don't share all of our shibboleths—really, our demented prejudices— are wrong and dispensable. And the underground motivation for that is, then you don't have to think, do you? You're morally superior to Freud, you're morally superior to Nietzsche, or any of the great artists of the past, let's say. You can dispense with them. You can put yourself in a position of moral elevation, and you don't have to either read or think. That's pretty damn convenient. And that's not criticism. That's a Luciferian intellectual—Luciferian moralizing intellectual pride of the worst sort.
- 1.17 When someone is as impactful as Nietzsche, let's say, you walk into an encounter with his thinking, if you're sensible, with some humility. I mean, first of all, who the hell are you? And so that's a good thing to remember. This is a person who, for better or worse, changed the world, and profoundly. And maybe you're not happy about all the ways that the change occurred, but it's a lot more useful to see if you can understand rather than see if you can casually dismiss.
- 1.18 So we may criticize. But you see, criticize doesn't mean dispense with. Criticize means to separate the wheat from the chaff. And the reason for that isn't to get rid of the chaff— it isn't to get rid of what isn't useful—it's to keep what is useful. And that's always what you should do when you're reading: gather what you can and leave the rest behind. But you want to be judicious in doing that because you don't want to throw the baby out with the bathwater. Now, I think Nietzsche did that to a fair degree with Christianity in particular. But we'll get to that.
- 1.19 Beyond Good and Evil has nine parts: On the Prejudices of Philosophers, The Free Spirit, What is Religious, Epigrams [and Interludes]—small pithy pointed statements that are designed to make a witty and profound point—an analysis of The Natural History of Morals, We Scholars— a critique of scholarship, so to speak—Our Virtues, Peoples and Fatherlands, and What is Noble. On the Prejudices of Philosophers, the first section, I dealt with this to some degree in the Introduction to Nietzsche course, and I'll deal with it more perfunctorily in this lecture series.

- 1.20** The other thing about profound thinkers is that they lay out a pathway for future investigation that's not overwhelmingly detailed. Nietzsche was very, very good at this. He said he leapt from mountaintop to mountaintop. He was an intuitive thinker, very creative thinker. And all philosophers aren't creative the same way Nietzsche was. Most philosophers who dance less than Nietzsche, who are less playful, are more rigorous and incremental thinkers. They grind away at their thought, making a single point, followed by another single point, like they're building a structure out of bricks.
- 1.21** Nietzsche doesn't do that. He's more like an impressionist painter. He gets the picture and presents it. A picture can contain a tremendous amount of information. And so what you see in Nietzsche—and this is part of the reason he's so useful to actually read—you can't summarize Nietzsche, it's not possible, though I'm going to give you a bit of a summary of these nine sections as an intro to what we're doing.
- 1.22** You see the seeds of ideas that grow tremendously in the late 19th century and through the 20th century, and now. He planted seeds that grew into whole disciplines, and you can see where their origin point is. And so that's very useful and interesting with regards to the integrity of your own psyche.
- 1.23** Part of the reason that it's useful to study philosophy, although hard on you, is because your head is full of the ideas of—all your ideas are the ideas of dead philosophers. Every single one of them. All the phrases you use, everything you hold dear, you think that's you. It's not. The probability that you've had an original idea is zero. It's very hard to have an original idea. And that means that you are stuffed full of the prejudice—you're stuffed full, unconsciously, of the prejudices of philosophers whose ideas you do not know. And because those ideas frame your perceptions and lay the groundwork for your emotions and undergird your strategies, you might want to know what they are. And so Nietzsche is particularly useful in that endeavor because so much of the way that modern people think—more than think—see, see and experience—is a consequence of his ideas and the effects that they had.
- 1.24** In the Gospels, Christ compares the Kingdom of Heaven to a mustard seed, a tiny seed that can grow into something remarkable and variegated. The reason I'm bringing that up is because of the nature of the metaphor. That metaphor is used because ideas are alive; they're like seeds, they're alive. Why? Well, where do they reside? They reside in living beings, and they have a—what would you say? They have a personality that unfolds across time.
- 1.25** Solzhenitsyn showed this very interestingly in the Gulag Archipelago, which was a critique of Soviet totalitarianism, but a unique critique. It wasn't only a description of the catastrophes, the ethical catastrophes of the Stalinist age—Leninist and Stalinist age—it was a revelation of the evil fruit that evil seeds had borne. It's a famous Marxist phrase—this isn't from Karl Marx, it's another Marxist—"Property is theft." That's a seed. And when it's thrown into a living and dynamic social system and takes root, God only knows what will grow out of it. "From each according to his ability, to each

according to his need." That's a seed. And what Solzhenitsyn did was show how that unfolded almost deterministically and inexorably once it was accepted.

- 1.26** Nietzsche is full of seeds. I tried to pick out from the book, *Beyond Good and Evil*, those that struck me most intensely. These were paragraphs or sentences that I encountered that I really never forgot. They hit me hard enough so that I remembered them. And that's rare. I've read, I don't know how many books, lots of books and lots of papers, thousands of books and thousands of papers. And most of them have no ideas. And Nietzsche has pretty much an idea per sentence. That's a lot of ideas. Well, so we'll see. We'll see how that works, and we'll get a taste of that.
- 1.27** All his books are like *Beyond Good and Evil*, except *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, which is more like a poetic revelation. It's often the book of Nietzsche that curious introductory students who are out for an adventure pick. But I wouldn't recommend that because it's its own category of strange revelation, much more like a fairy tale than a work of philosophy. And although it's very valuable, it's much easier to understand if you know his other work. I read them in chronological order as well, which I found extremely useful. So this will be an introduction into—his thought is an introduction into the most romantic and exciting philosopher of the last 200 years. I think that's fair to say—and the most impactful.
- 1.28** [Part One]: On the Prejudices of Philosophers. Nietzsche challenges the foundations of traditional philosophy, arguing that philosophers have been dogmatic, projecting their own biases into their systems rather than seeking truth. Well, that's a critique that's full of trouble. But what's the trouble to take apart?
- 1.29** There's a question that lurks here in this first section about what constitutes truth. And Nietzsche is never clear about the solution, I wouldn't say. But the way that I've come to construe the problem is that there's really two forms of truth, and they're not—how to align them isn't exactly obvious. There's the truth of what matters, so there's the truth of meaning, relevance, and importance. And there's the truth of, let's say, material reality. And those aren't the same kinds of truths.
- 1.30** Nietzsche pointed out in *On the Prejudices of Philosophers* that in any philosophical writing, there was the effect of living motivation. It's that the person who formulated the philosophy couldn't help but introduce their own motivational stance, their own subjectivity—that's another way of thinking about it—but their own living spirit into the philosophy. And that, rather than it being a work of logical inference and empirical data gathering, you might say—and this might even be true from the scientific perspective—it was an unconscious confession of axiomatic belief. So from Nietzsche's perspective, what the great philosophers did was look at how they looked at the world and reveal that even to themselves.
- 1.31** So Nietzsche's critique of traditional philosophy and traditional philosophers' dogmatism is rooted in an even deeper problem, which is: What's the relationship

between objective truth and subjective truth, or the object and the subject? But also what's the relationship between a description of the world as, say, a place of things—which is generally how we, modern people, define what's real? The world's a place of things. The most real level of description is the level of description of things; that's the materialist perspective.

- 1.32 The problem with that—David Hume, the philosopher, pointed out the fundamental problem with that, which was that just because you know what something is, doesn't mean you know what to do with it. Those are separate problems. A description of the territory doesn't provide you with a map to navigate it. And since you're alive and mobile, navigation—well, you could say that navigation is the fundamental problem, more fundamental than the nature of the material substrate, let's say.
- 1.33 Nietzsche's critique of traditional philosophy emerged from his dawning realization that the notions of objective truth that the West had been laying forward since the Enlightenment and the dawn of the Scientific Age were insufficient. And they are insufficient, they are insufficient. The world of the materialist is devoid of meaning.
- 1.34 Now, our conclusion from that has been that meaning itself is epiphenomenal; it's a secondary manifestation of something more fundamental. Like your consciousness is a manifestation of the material operations of your nervous system, the material is primary. There's something about that that's not right because you prioritize your perception so that you can perceive the world, even the world of data, according to your values. So the attempt to separate the world of value from the world of material fact is a nonstarter. It can't be done; there's too many facts. You have to prioritize your attention and your perception.
- 1.35 And you prioritize your attention and your perception—this is a definition— you attend to what you value. You can reverse that. You value what you attend to. It's the same thing. So if attention precedes data, and motivation precedes attention, then motivation precedes data. This is a big problem. This is the problem the postmodernists attempted to chase. This is why they're skeptical of objective truth. And there's something to that. I think what there is is that, and Nietzsche didn't—he laid some of the groundwork for this idea, but he didn't develop it himself—
- 1.36 The truth of the matter is that the most fundamental frame of perception, the frame that allows the world to exist for us as conscious observers, is a story and not a description of objective fact. All of that problem is lurking underneath Nietzsche's critique of philosophy as an unconscious revelation of motivation. He critiques the idea of objective truth, suggesting that all philosophy reflects the philosopher's instincts and will to power. One of the things Nietzsche said, very useful, was that every drive attempts to philosophize in its spirit.
- 1.37 Now, the psychologists who studied motivation, drive, tended to think of—especially the behavioral types who did the initial scientific investigation—tended to think of a

drive, sexual impulse, for example, as a deterministic system of biologically instantiated controls that unfolded on a reflex basis, a drive. But that's not right. It's not right because any profound motivational state shapes not only your actions, tilts you behaviorally in a certain direction, but your perceptions. It frames your perceptions.

- 1.38** When you're hungry and you walk into your kitchen, what you see in your kitchen are all those things relevant to food and nothing else. The perceptual frame is shifted by the motivational state. More than that, the emotions are reconfigured. So if you're hungry and you walk into your kitchen and you find something to eat, that makes you happy. The happiness is an index of the movement towards the goal that's set up in your perceptions by the motivation. It's not some behavioral drive. It's not some chain of reflexes.
- 1.39** Nietzsche knew something even more profound than that, which was that the drive, the instinct, was a personality. That's extremely useful to know. Anger— you're possessed by anger—that's a personality. It has its own goals. It has its own objectives. It has its own history. I don't just mean personal history. That angry person is a character that's been elaborated culturally, just like modern Mafia dons imitate movie Mafia dons. When you're angry, you're possessed by a personality that has a history that far transcends you. All of your drives are like that.
- 1.40** Drives philosophize in their spirit. They come with their own memories. If you're arguing with someone, you're angry at them, and you remember previous arguments, even if this is someone you love, the memories that are going to be called to the forefront of your attention by the motivation state are the ones relevant to your attempt to attain victory while you're angry. All the ideas, all the rationales—the drive is a personality. Nietzsche's point was that much of what passed for philosophy was the revelation of the character of a drive, or a constellation of drives, in relationship to the philosophers in question.
- 1.41** Now, Nietzsche believed that the pinnacle motivation, the pinnacle drive, was what he called will to power—should be, maybe was and should be—was what he called will to power. And it's a slippery term in Nietzsche's characterization because power is an amorphous concept. Power means motive force. "I have the power to do this." But power also means force and compulsion. And so competence on the one hand; ability, force and compulsion on the other. And Nietzsche's use of will to power as the superordinate motivation—the one ring of power that binds them all, you might say—was interpreted by the fascists as a celebration of force and compulsion.
- 1.42** Now, it's not clear that—I would say it's clear that that wasn't Nietzsche's intent, because when he talked about will to power, he meant more like the proclivity of an organism to expend its energy in the pursuit of its—well, that's the question: In pursuit of what? In pursuit of its will?

- 1.43 Nietzsche believed we should create our own values and so that's a very problematic idea. But in the aftermath of the death of God, human beings will find it necessary to create their own values. That's an expression, in principle, of that will to power. It's the same idea in its nascent form as the self-actualization ideas, let's say, of the existentialists in the 1950s and the humanist psychologists, the New Age types in the 1960s and 1970s. Self-actualization, the unfolding of a central uniting tendency. The question is self-actualization in relationship to what? That's not well-answered by Nietzsche or by any of those schools of thought.
- 1.44 The fundamental issue here, though, is that Nietzsche added this additional dimension of analysis to philosophical systems, pointing out that they weren't mere representations of the world, even if that's what they proclaimed themselves to be. This would include philosophies on the scientific front. They were expressions of motivated personalities, some of which were the philosophers and some of which were the personalities that possessed the philosophers.
- 1.45 Here's a way of thinking about this that might provide some insight. I presume that all of you have seen the Disney movie Pinocchio. Pinocchio starts out as a puppet marionette. So he's ill-formed; he's just a creation. He's the creation of his benevolent father and the blue fairy who's Mother Nature, so he's off to a pretty good start. And his father, who's a benevolent creator, wants him to realize himself. But he starts out as a marionette. He's pulled by forces that are outside of him and beyond not only his control, but his comprehension.
- 1.46 It's those strings that Nietzsche was attempting to point to—the existence of those strings—even insofar as the philosophers were dancing on the strings of ideas that they were grappling towards that possessed them. Those are deep spirits, the deep spirits of the deep warring gods and demons of mankind, you might say. And so to read Nietzsche is to delve into the depths where those spirits exist.
- 1.47 That's a terrifying—it's a very terrifying thing to understand that you are in control of ideas that you do not know or understand, and that they shape your perceptions. They frame your emotions. They also generate your thoughts. It's like that sounds bad enough, but it's nowhere near as bad as the fact that they generate your perceptions and frame your emotions. You might want to know what they are.
- 1.48 Concepts like the will to truth are scrutinized—Nietzsche questions whether truth is even desirable, proposing that falsity might be more life-affirming. Well, this is a tricky business because—here's a way of beginning to think about it: Is fiction true? Well, you could say there's shallow fiction, everyone knows that, shallow entertainment. Why is it shallow? Because it doesn't matter. What does it mean that it doesn't matter? It doesn't affect anything deep.
- 1.49 That's a reference to this idea of a hierarchy of presuppositions. If it's deep, many things depend on it. If it's shallow, it's like a surface argument, a trivial argument you

might have, let's say, with your wife or husband, rather than a marriage-ending divorce argument. So the idea that there's depth in fiction indicates that there's a hierarchy of value in relationship to the fictional. Or what, a hierarchy of truth? We would assume that a Dostoevsky novel or a Tolstoy novel is somehow true in this fictional sense.

- 1.50** Fiction is a navigation aid. That's a good way of thinking about it. Fiction presents a story, a story is a navigation aid. There are levels of depth in stories. What Nietzsche was grappling with—although he didn't quite have the terminology at the time of his investigation—was that if you share a culture with someone, you share the same fictions. That's the definition of a culture. A culture is literally a shared corpus or foundation of story. No shared story, no shared culture. The story is the fundamental thing.
- 1.51** Well, story isn't true, or our sense of what constitutes truth isn't accurate. I think that's a better way of thinking about it, that when modern people say true, they mean objective truth. The problem with that is that fiction is not objective truth, but fiction has levels of truth and depth. And there are—what? Are there true fictions? Deep stories are obviously true. Or what? Are they worthless? And if they're worthless, then why are we so powerfully oriented towards them? Why will we buy them? Why will we line up to see them? Why do we tell them to one another? Why do we construe our lives that way when we tell our own stories? And why do we know that there are levels of depth to story, which implies levels of truth?
- 1.52** One of the things that Nietzsche was grappling with was the notion that objective truth doesn't seem to cover the ground of truth. And then the question is: What fills the gap? I would say in some ways, much of 20th-century cognitive science, philosophy was an attempt—literary criticism was an attempt to grapple with that question. The culture war, in its most fundamental element, is a consequence of this war, the war between the fictional and the objective. The postmodernists damn their miserable hides, got one thing definitely right, which was that even the scientific enterprise is nested inside the story. I think that's indisputable. I think the scientists themselves have demonstrated that.
- 1.53** So falsity might be more life-affirming. What does that mean? It doesn't mean that you should live by a lie. A great novel isn't a lie, even though it never happened. That's a very tricky thing to contend with. So Nietzsche's proposition wasn't that you lived by a lie. His realization was that there were forms of truth that served life that we didn't understand well when we made the axiomatic presupposition that only the empirical was true.
- 1.54** Part Two: The Free Spirit. Here, Nietzsche introduces the concept of the free spirit: an ideal thinker who rejects conventional morality and dogmas to create his own values. He contrasts this with the bound spirits of his time, whom he sees as narrow and conformist. The free spirit—this is the romantic element of Nietzsche and his attraction

to romantics—the free spirit embraces uncertainty, experimentation, and intellectual independence, preparing the way for Nietzsche's new philosophers.

- 1.55** Nietzsche proclaimed that most morality was cowardice. It's very important to pay careful attention to that statement because it's not all morality; it's most, and that's a very important distinction. Why is it cowardice? It's just a convention. It's an unthinking convention as opposed to a deep understanding and genuine principled stance. It's easier to sway in the wind. And his critique of the academic enterprise was a critique that was in part founded on the idea that most of what constituted morality in the academic world, in the intellectual world, was that consensus conformity that had virtually nothing to do with genuine intellectual inquiry.
- 1.56** Now, there's also a revolutionary and romantic element to this line of thinking that is dangerous. It's clearly the case that creative thinkers can reshape conceptual structures at a fundamental level. It's not always obvious that that reshaping is a good thing. Most radical ideas are radically wrong. The idea that it's possible and desirable for a given person, even a free spirit, even a new philosopher, to create their own values from whole cloth in the span of a lifetime, let's say, and to get that right, is a pretty dubious proposition.
- 1.57** You don't live very long, and there's a lot of things you don't know, and the probability that you'll generate a revolutionary new way of conceptualizing the world that will supersede all of the advantages of traditional morality, even with its cowardice and consensus, and lay a new pathway forward is the delusion of revolutionaries everywhere in the world. So there's a Luciferian temptation that lurks in the depths of Nietzsche's call to philosophical action. But by the same token, his notion that much of morality was cowardice is correct.
- 1.58** This is why in movies, for example, the anti-hero is often a more heroic figure than the conventional man. I'll give you an example of this. In *The Hobbit*, Bilbo starts out as a conventional man. He lives in the Shire. It's a very protected and unconscious environment. It's protected from the true doings of the real world, the great war between good and evil that's raging in the hinterlands. It's patrolled by the sons of great kings. Those are the striders. Aragorn is one of them. They patrol the perimeter, and they keep the inhabitants of the Shire safe. They're like the dwarfs in *Snow White*. They're ordinary people, ordinary good people, ordinary bad people, ordinary people.
- 1.59** Gandalf shows up, and Gandalf is an agent of magical transformation. And he lays a new pathway for the hobbit. He calls him to adventure. His first task as an adventurer is to become a thief, and that's a form of the revaluation of all values that Nietzsche proclaimed as necessary. Bilbo as a thief is perversely a more moral agent than Bilbo as a conventional and cowardly hobbit. What did Nietzsche say? The great epochs of our life come when we revalue, when we recast what was evil about us as a new good. So, another very dangerous thought.

- 1.60** Jung, Carl Jung, elaborated on that idea with his concept of persona and shadow. The persona is the mask that people wear to show themselves and the world that they're conventionally good. But it's a manipulation. It's a mask that's worn to demonstrate a depth of moral commitment that's not real. It's an act. And it's an act that's undertaken for manipulative purposes. If I can convince you that I'm better than I am, especially if I've also convinced me, then I'll be able to manipulate you in a way that I wouldn't be able to manipulate you otherwise. Now, I will dispute whether or not I'm manipulating you because I believe I'm a good person. But it's a very difficult thing to become a good person, and you don't do that by just acting it out.
- 1.61** The shadow part of that persona is the aggression and the unrealized self-interest in narcissism that's manipulating the persona behind the scenes to manipulate the world in an instrumental manner to obtain a selfish end. That shadow contains all the pathology of the personality that isn't allowed to exist from the perspective of the persona. Its discovery is a catastrophe, but also something that frees you.
- 1.62** Imagine you're an agreeable person. You don't want to cause any trouble. You want to get along with everybody. You don't like conflict. So you do what people ask you, and you smile while you're doing it, but you're resentful. This is a very good thing to note, by the way, in your own life: resentment is a bitter master, but it's very instructive. If you're resentful, there's only two real reasons. One is that you should grow the hell up and quit whining, or you have something to say because you're being taken advantage of by you and other people, and you're not saying it. Those are the two options. Both of those are quite dreadful, but they're very instructive.
- 1.63** That resentment of the agreeable person who goes along, all their aggression is inside that resentment, and if that was allowed to exist and to have its voice, then it would transmute the personality. That's the integration of that thief, let's say. It would transmute the personality so that what's actually necessary for proper character development to take place would be allowed and encouraged to exist.
- 1.64** This is something you can practice. You watch when you say yes to something. You can say, "I'll sleep on it." That's a smart thing to do. Watch and see if you're resentful. And if you're resentful, then notice that. And then if you let that resentment fantasize, which it will, you can watch that if you're willing, it'll lay out a scenario of revenge or a scenario of renegotiation or a little picture or story about the way the world is and how unfair it is. It'll lay that all out in a dream. And you can see, in consequence of that, who you are.
- 1.65** Then you can figure out, if you want, if you're willing, how you would have to reconfigure the situation so that that resentment would disappear. That would generally mean that you have something to say. You have to take that aggression. It's in that resentment. It's often extremely destructive, unbelievably desirous of revenge. You have to let it have its say, and then you have to reconfigure the perceptual frame so that you're not resentful. Then you've properly taken yourself into account.

- 1.66 Nietzsche's point with the consensus seeking, herd-like academics that were so common in his time and still now was that they're all false moral resentful consensus seekers with a tremendous underground drive for power and revenge. The way of proper philosophical investigation—this is partly what he meant by the revaluation of all values— is to see the resentful person, the agreeable resentful person, who believes that aggression is an evil. And there are forms of aggression that are clearly evil. But that doesn't mean that aggression is evil anymore than sexuality or hunger is evil. These things can be put to perverse purposes and misused, but that doesn't mean that in their essence, they should be shunned. They have to be integrated.
- 1.67 The revaluation of values that Nietzsche spoke of on the positive side rather than the revolutionary side was the willingness to revisit first principles. The agreeable person is a very good example of that. To think all that aggression that I've put aside because it causes conflict and hurts people's feelings, say, that's necessary. It's necessary. I need to pull it into my personality. I need to use it.
- 1.68 This is partly what the psychoanalysts recommended, too. They were students of Nietzsche, influenced by Nietzsche: Freud and Jung. Part of their psychotherapeutic process was the identification of elements of the personality, motivational states, and emotions that hadn't been integrated properly into the personality and that were living a pathological underground life that was driving fantasy, often vengeful fantasy, disruptive fantasy, nihilistic fantasy, suicidal fantasy, depressive fantasy, that those had to be welcomed into the house, so to speak, and integrated. That's a transvaluation of values.
- 1.69 You want peace, so you never fight. Do you have peace? Peace is hard to have. True peace is hard to have. You can have the façade of peace, which just means—what does it mean? Does it mean you never stand up for yourself? That's not peace, that's capitulation. And you can lay that over—what you could say? You could present that to yourself and the world as the self-sacrificing self-denial that, in principle, is moral and Christian, which is one of the reasons Nietzsche criticized Christianity, but that's all just a lie. It's a lie. It's morality is cowardice. "I want peace. I won't fight. I won't enter into any conflict." That's not peace. That's not a desire. It's just cowardice.
- 1.70 The best way to camouflage your cowardice is with a moral façade. That's Nietzsche's idea about morality as cowardice. As I said, that didn't mean that he thought that morality as such was cowardice. What he meant was, most of what people pass off as morality is cowardice. That's a brutal realization.
- 1.71 You can find out this for yourself. Do you know what you want? Are there impediments to you getting it? Have you even allowed yourself to ask what you want? Are there methods of negotiation that you've forsworn? "I don't fight." I've heard people say that. "I don't like to fight." It's like no one likes to fight—that's not true; there are people who like to. Most people don't like to fight. It's upsetting. It's like the fact that you don't fight, what are you? Christ? You don't fight. Well, Christ fought, too. That's

how good you are? I don't think so. I think you view that moralizing proposition with a fair bit of skepticism.

- 1.72** Think: Do you have silence or do you have peace? Because those are not the same thing. And you could see, especially in our culture in the last 10 years, the proclivity of people to not say what they have to say has become amplified to a degree that I could have not possibly imagined 20 years ago. So this is partly what Nietzsche is talking about with regard to the free spirit, the person who has enough courage to at least question their own unthinking compliance with the prevailing dogma.
- 1.73** Dogma. Dogma is composed of slogans. What's dogma? Dogma isn't a replacement for philosophy. Slogans are a replacement for thought. The word slogan comes from the Gaelic, sluagh-ghairm. It means "battle cry of the dead." So when you listen to someone mouth clichés and slogans, and they're dull because of it and predictable—unless they happen to be mouthing the slogans that you're particularly fond of—then you know that they're possessed by the spirit of the evil dead. That's a good way of thinking about it.
- 1.74** [Part Three]: What Is Religious. Nietzsche famously pronounced the death of God, which he had the sense not to be naively positive about, like the New Atheist types. Nietzsche knew that the death of God signified the collapse of the story that had unified—to the degree that the West was unified— that had unified Christendom, let's say, better than the West, that had unified Christendom, and that the collapse of that unifying principle or story— story is a better conceptualization—would bring in its wake a series of inevitable catastrophes: the rise of ideology, the emergence of nihilism, the proliferation of a motivated hedonism.
- 1.75** Imagine that when a uniting principle, a psychologically or a socially uniting principle, collapses, it fragments into the principles that have the next best chance of emerging as dominant. Hopelessness was one of them as far as Nietzsche was concerned; that's just a fragmentation into a nihilistic morass. Nothing has any meaning. That's the nihilistic stance. And it's also a stance of radical irresponsibility, and that's part of the shadow reason for its adoption. "Nothing matters. Therefore, I have no responsibility." That's the payoff for the nihilist.
- 1.76** Power? Well, if there's no uniting impulse, I'll just force it. Tolkien knew this. That's why he made the one ring that unites all the evil rings, the ring of power. And you can unite things with power and force. But the first question is: Is that an optimal union? Is that an optimal uniting principle? Tolkien certainly identified the uniting proclivity of power with the totalitarian underworld. So that's obvious.
- 1.77** The 20th century made that obvious. The Nazis were totalitarians. The communists are totalitarians. They use power to bind. It's unstable, it's counterproductive, it's murderous. It binds. You destroy a totalitarian state. Maybe you get a failed state. That's a complete chaotic catastrophe. That's not necessarily better, but that doesn't

mean that power—this is another problem with Nietzschean philosophy, as far as I'm concerned, and with this critique of Christianity— it doesn't mean that power is the optimized uniting principle.

- 1.78** Try it in your marriage and see how that goes, or with your kids, or with yourself. You can take yourself by the neck and shake yourself and force yourself to do things. And maybe that's better than being entirely bloody useless. But, arguably, it's not the optimal motivating strategy. And the question then becomes—and Nietzsche doesn't do a good job of answering this, I don't think—what is the optimal uniting strategy? In a marriage, it's something more like an invitation rather than a force. An invitation and negotiation and agreement, something like that, that's a dialogue towards some end. That's very much worth delving into, and we'll do that to some degree as we proceed through this work.
- 1.79** Nietzsche examines the psychological origins of religion, particularly Christianity, which he critiques for its slave morality, resenting strength and glorifying weakness. From my perspective, Nietzsche—he is complicated because there's much in his writings that proclaims an admiration, both for Christianity in its institutional forms and for Christ. But I think this is the major motif of his anti-religious thinking.
- 1.80** He knew that the death of God would produce an existential catastrophe, a political and social psychological catastrophe. He was dead right about that. And he knew that the religious enterprise, he would have regarded that as a form of falsity that was necessary, that bound people together. Now, whether a falsity could bind people together is a whole different question. But that's the pathway down which he walked: dispense with the religious impulse, create your own values.
- 1.81** So that's Nietzsche's—he thought that was inevitable because the empirical age, the scientific age, had demolished our faith in our religious presuppositions. So that was gone. What was going to arise in consequence? Nihilism, ideology, nationalism, hedonism, and the possibility that we would create our own values. That's what he saw as the pathway out. That's the self-actualizing pathway out. The problem with that is: How do you create your own values, and based on what? That's a major problem. We'll deal with that.
- 1.82** Now, his critique of Christianity, he tied that in with his critique of morality as cowardice. He believed that Christianity—he thought of the Romans and the Greeks as aristocratic in this will-to-power manner. And he admired that aristocratic hierarchical approach to life that was more commanding and less self-effacing and falsely humble. He believed that Christianity was a manifestation of the revolt of the oppressed against the oppressor, and that it was a form of slave morality that had become dominant, that actually posed a threat to the integrity of the true nobility of human culture and the European ethos. I don't think—he made a mistake there because he threw the baby out with the bathwater, as far as I'm concerned. There's a strain of progressive thought

in Christianity that is a valorization of the oppressed. But that's not the main contention.

- 1.83** I'll give you an example of that. There are variants of Christianity, the leftist variants in particular, the progressive variants, the liberation theology types that have taken that valorization of the oppressed, that have elevated that to the highest degree. It's the analog of Marxism within Christianity, but it's not the mainstream of Christian thought.
- 1.84** Like I said, I'll give you an example of that. In the story of Cain and Abel—that's an Old Testament story, granted, but it doesn't matter because it still sits at the foundation of Christian thought—Cain presents himself as depressed. He works, like Abel does. He makes sacrifices; that's work. He makes offerings to God. He makes offerings to what's highest. And his offerings are rejected. The reason they're rejected, according to the story, is because they're not that good.
- 1.85** When Cain goes to complain to God that he's not successful, like his brother Abel, who makes high-quality sacrifices and offers his best, Cain says to Him, to God, something like, "I'm working. I'm working like my brother. I'm making these sacrifices, and nothing's going well for me." And God says, "If you did well, you'd be accepted." So that's quite the judgment. There's a very profound idea there, many of them.
- 1.86** One of them is, this isn't a joke. You either bring your best to the table, or it's not going to work. That's not surprising because the alternative hypothesis would be that—what? You can take your life, which is a very complicated thing to manage, and everyone else's lives, and you can do something second-rate, and that's going to work for you, and it's going to fool everybody else, and it's going to please God. That seems highly improbable. And so that's basically what God tells Cain.
- 1.87** He tells him one other thing, too. He says, "You think the reason you're bitter and your face has fallen, and your countenance has fallen, you're depressed, and you're bitter, is because your sacrifice is rejected and your failure has made you bitter." That's an oppressor narrative, the oppressor-oppressed narrative. The reason you're unhappy is because you're at the bottom of the hierarchy, something like that. You're failing.
- 1.88** God tells Cain, "It's not that you're failing that's causing your misery. It's that you've drawn the wrong conclusions from your failure." He says, "You failed, and something tempted you. It sat at your door like a sexually aroused predatory animal, and you invited it in to have its way with you. And so you made second-rate sacrifices. They didn't work out very well. You invited something terrible in to toy with you. You entered into a contract with it. You became bitter and resentful. What might have the alternatives been? You could have upped your game. You could have figured out what you did wrong. You could have taken the pathway of Abel, but you didn't. And so now you're in this situation, and it's not good."
- 1.89** Well, so Cain leaves this discussion. He's even more upset than he was when he entered into it. And then he kills Abel. There's not a lot of pro-oppressed narrative in

that story. There's not a lot of sympathy for the guy who's on the bottom. The fundamental religious narrative is a lot more sophisticated than Nietzsche gave it credit for.

- 1.90** There was this—it's so complicated because the Christian symbol was the complete destruction of a man who forswore arbitrary power totally. So it's certainly the antithesis of the Roman or Greek or pagan insistence that power, like aristocratic power and the ability to use force, was the hallmark of nobility. It's certainly the opposite of that. But that doesn't mean that it's the valorization of the slave. I think that's foolish. It's foolish.
- 1.91** You see the same thing in the Exodus story, which has an even more determinative effect on the course of Christianity than the story of Cain and Abel, arguably. The Pharaoh is the tyrant, and there's an oppressor-oppressed narrative in the Book of Exodus. You've got the Pharaoh and the Egyptians against the Hebrews who were slaves. It's not like the Hebrews get away easily. It's not like because they're slaves, they're good; they're just as bad as the tyrants. The reason the bloody Israelites spend 40 years in the desert now that they've escaped the tyrant is because they got some things to learn, and they won't learn them.
- 1.92** So the Exodus story shows that wherever there's oppressor and oppressed, the oppressor has a moral part to play, but so do the oppressed. You don't get tyrants without slaves, and the slaves bear just as much responsibility for the tyrant as the tyrant does. That's such an important thing to know. It's a foreign policy issue, not least, because we're deluded enough to think that if you take a country that's a tyranny and you lop off the head, regime change, that all the freedom-loving people who've been oppressed by the tyrant are going to rise up and produce a democracy overnight like a self-sacrificing functional modern democracy. That's just demented. Usually, what happens is you lop off the tyrant, and a worse tyrant comes along, or the whole bloody state collapses into chaos and catastrophe and stays that way indefinitely. The slaves bear just as much responsibility for the tyrant as the tyrant does. You don't get one without the other.
- 1.93** So he critiques self-denial. He critiques Christianity for its slave morality, resenting strength and glorifying weakness. Yeah, there's a demented, immature valorization of pathological victimhood that perverts traditional Christianity, but it's not the core. That's a mistake. It's a big mistake. It's certainly the tack that Hitler took, for example, in relationship to his critique of Christianity, and that did come out of a strain of Nietzschean thought. You can't tie Nietzsche to the fascists directly, but his thought made itself manifest in many places, some good and some not so good. There is a dangerous streak in his thinking here, a prideful streak that we could create our own morality.
- 1.94** The problem with creating your own morality is that other people have to go along with it. It's like, "I'm going to create my own morality. What the hell am I going to do with

you? Are you just going to come along for the ride, or do you have something to say about it? And if you have something to say about it, what exactly are we negotiating here?" Because it's not just me then. It's certainly not just my will to power unless we're just in some—what? We got our hands around each other's necks, and we're battling to the death for whose will to power predominates? You're not going to get a productive society out of that interaction. There's a principle that underlies social harmony that is a lot more sophisticated than hedonistic motivational drive or will to power, and the ability to create your own morality.

- 1.95** Even kids—a four-year-old kid who creates his own morality is not a popular kid. A four-year-old kid needs to invite other people to play. They have to agree. Everybody has to want to play the game, and turns have to be taken. This is why Jean Piaget, who's a brilliant philosopher and developmental psychologist, looked at the emergence of children's games as a pointer to the principles by which society is and should be governed. There's something about that voluntary construction of a mutually desirable game that's way different than the principle of power, and way different than the idea that you create your own values.
- 1.96** So he critiques self-denial and rejection of worldly life. The ascetic ideal is life-negating. I've got some sympathy for that, but the central Judeo-Christian impetus is life more abundant. That's something that's a profound element of Jewish thought in particular, that earthly life itself is worthy of celebration. The pleasures of earthly life, so to speak, are worthy of celebrating, and the proper integration between the religious and the secular allows for the full expression of both. Now, there's definitely an ascetic element in Christianity, probably more so than Judaism. But again, I would say that's an offshoot of the central Christian ethos rather than its core.
- 1.97** Self-denial and rejection of worldly life is likely necessary for people who are selfish and too possessed by worldly life. If you're self-centered and your whims dominate your psyche and your attempts to deal with others, and that's producing a disharmony in your life, then a little asceticism might be just the cure for that. But that doesn't mean it's the final destination.
- 1.98** Religious impulses, Nietzsche argued, stemmed from a need for certainty and control, but they stifle human potential and creativity. Nietzsche was also—he had a paradoxical stance on such things, too. He said that the insistence, the Christian insistence, the Judeo-Christian insistence, that every single phenomenon was to be accounted for under the interpretive structure of a single God was a strategy that had disciplined the European mind enough so that it could engage, for example, in the scientific enterprise. He thought of slavery as a precondition for freedom. It's like an apprenticeship idea: before you can be truly free. Immature freedom is just the manifestation of one idiot whim after another. It's not freedom at all. It's just a succession of short-term possessions by low-level motivational states. That's a good way of putting it.

- 1.99** How do you transcend that? By concentrating on something for a long period of time. What? Maybe it doesn't matter. Maybe what matters is that you concentrate on one thing for a long period of time. And what you're doing then is you're arranging all these subpersonalities that would pull you in all sorts of directions under the guiding impulse of a single direction. That creates within you the ability to do that, to be disciplined, to put your mind to something and to stay on. Once you've got that discipline, then you can turn that to different ends, and maybe then you could search for a more suitable end, even than the one you happen to be pursuing. But Nietzsche knew that apprenticeship was a precondition for genuine freedom.
- 1.100** Do religious impulses stifle human potential and creativity? Not if they're part and parcel of the impulse to apprentice. This is what people get wrong when they're disciplining their children. It's not like you're telling them what not to do. I mean, there's some of that: they shouldn't pull heavy things off a table on top of their head. I mean, that's obvious. There's going to be some boundaries that you want to impose that, if violated, will have real-world consequences. But mostly what you're doing is you're helping the child integrate their impulses so they can regulate themselves in relationship to their future and other people, so that they don't compromise their future and so that other people like having them around. That's an apprenticeship model.
- 1.101** The idiot Rousseauians who think that human beings are fundamentally good, the natural savage, and that culture does nothing but pervert and dement, fail entirely to understand that all culture is not an inhibition by any stretch of the imagination, any more than the rules of a game are only limiting. The rules of basketball enable you to play basketball. Without the rules, you don't get to play the game. You can generate multiple sets of rules, and you can have multiple games. And you're a fool if you think the rules should be dispensed with because—what? You can't play chess in the middle of a basketball game. They're enabling principles.
- 1.102** And so the disciplinary strategy that's part and parcel of apprenticeship is the inculcation of enabling principles and not the imposition of boundaries around the noble savage. It's unbelievably important to get that right, especially in relationship to kids. You want them to be able to play with other people and their future self. You serve them best that way.
- 1.103** And so that begs the question, too, is that if there is a way that they can be socialized into a unity that serves them socially and psychologically, what's the basis for that unity? We know with kids, it's not power. All you have to do is watch a bossy four-year-old, "You have to play my game." It's like, fair enough, but I'm only going to play with you once. So, you have no friends if that's your approach. So what's the approach that generates friends? Well, that's a good question. We'll return to that.
- 1.104** Religious impulses stem from a need for certainty and control. Yeah, religious impulses in part stem from that. But there's a lot more to the religious impulse than need for

certainty and control. And there's a lot more to the religious impulse than what stifles human potential and creativity. To identify that with the religious is a fool's game.

- 1.105** There's a line of sociological speculation that war is a consequence of pathological human society, that human beings are basically peaceful, but our culture warps us, and we fight for cultural, even religious reasons. But chimpanzees go to war. So, so much for that theory. That theory is not right, obviously, because the problem is much deeper than the mere cultural.

## Lecture 2: The Cost of Comfort

At a glance — The cost of comfort — the epigrams and interludes.

- 2.1 Part Four: Epigrams and Interludes. This section is a collection of 187 short, provocative statements on various topics like morality, human nature, women, and art, Nietzsche's famous aphorisms.
- 2.2 Nietzsche wasn't well. He had a hard time writing. He spent a lot of time thinking. The ratio of thinking to writing was very high, and so he wrote in short bursts because that's all he could manage. That's not the only reason. It was also his style, and it was a very effective style. And he was very brilliant at doing this, so we don't want to lay that all at the feet of his illness, but that was part of it. And his aphorisms, his short paragraphs, are little—well, they're very productive seeds, or they're very catastrophic explosions, depending on how you look at it.
- 2.3 He's a strange philosopher because he's witty and ironic, and that makes him very interesting to read if you have a bit of a romantic and creative bent. And we'll go through a number of these aphorisms there. They'll stick with you. They're very well phrased and they're very provocative. What's their aim? Some of it was wit and the delight in a well-turned phrase. Some of it was—what's the delight in a well-turned phrase? To specify the thought precisely and elegantly. He was a master at that. What's their aim? To unsettle the reader and provoke deeper reflection.
- 2.4 [Part Five]: Natural History of Morals. Nietzsche traces the evolution of moral systems, arguing that morality is not universal but a product of historical and cultural forces. He contrasts master morality, which values strength, independence, and power, with slave morality, which values kindness, humility, and resentment of the strong. He criticizes modern morality as a herd mentality that suppresses individuality and the higher human.
- 2.5 Yeah, higher, higher. Higher in what manner? Well, outside that constraining structure of consensus and cowardice in morality, but then higher in relationship to what? That's that will to power, and that's where Nietzsche tilts, I suppose, to some degree, in the fascist direction. Strength, independence, and power. Strength in the service of what? Independence for what purpose? And power expressed towards what end?
- 2.6 Those things, in a sense, can't be ends in and of themselves. They have to serve something, and the question is what? He did—the thing is that his criticism of this pathologized strain of Christianity was accurate. I mean, our culture now has a huge rift in it along the lines that Nietzsche predicted.
- 2.7 Much of the Western world is possessed by the certainty that the manner in which the world should be construed is essentially tyrant and slave. That's the oppressor-oppressed narrative, and that all of history, all the relationships between men and

women, all economic arrangements, everything can be explained by a dynamic of power. Nietzsche's perspective was that Christianity reflexively took the side of the oppressed. I think, as I said, I think that's an insufficient critique because I don't think it's the case. There is a pathological strain of victim Christianity that does exactly that, but you don't want to throw the baby out with the bathwater.

- 2.8** [Part Six]: We Scholars. Nietzsche critiques the state of scholarship in academia, accusing scholars of being uncreative and overly specialized, lacking the boldness of true philosophers. He contrasts the objective scholar with the free spirit or new philosopher who's willing to take risks, embrace subjectivity, and create new values. Scholarship, he argues, should serve life, not just preserve knowledge.
- 2.9** Part Seven: Our Virtues. This goes back to the slave mentality idea and the camouflage of cowardice as morality. Nietzsche questions whether modern virtues like pity and equality are truly virtuous. He sees pity as a form of weakness that undermines life and equality as a leveling force that stifles greatness. He proposes that true virtue lies in self-overcoming and the creation of new values, aligning with his concept of the will to power. He also reflects on the role of suffering and growth.
- 2.10** Freud elaborated on that idea to a great degree. Freud's concept of the Oedipal situation in familial households, although he sexualized it—and it's not surprising, because in pathological families, these things get sexualized. Let me give you an example. So, the simplest way of approaching this is something like this. Human beings have the longest dependency period of any creatures, say 18 years. It's longer than that, actually, because our life spans are optimized so we can be grandparents, because our children need guidance when they have children. It's a long dependency period, and the reason for that is that we learn a lot.
- 2.11** Human beings are—we need to be radically socialized. Now, the advantage of that is tremendous behavioral flexibility and environmental flexibility. We can live virtually anywhere, but the disadvantage is, it takes a long time. And so, one of the consequences of the cortical expansion that lays the groundwork for that ability to learn is the expansion of the human skull. And one of the consequences of that is that our infants are born in a very undeveloped state, because if they develop more, their heads would be bigger, and then they couldn't be born. And so, there's an evolutionary trade-off between neonatal competence and head size.
- 2.12** The way that we've solved that, so to speak, is that our infants are born very dependent. A mammal of our size should have a gestation period of about two years, not nine months. So our infants are born radically dependent. So that means that maternal care is crucial to physiological survival. If you provide neonates with all the basics of life, food, shelter, the physiological satiation at the physiological level, but no attention and care, most of them die within the first year. And those that don't are generally so damaged that they cannot be repaired.

- 2.13** We saw that under Ceaușescu, dictator, late-Soviet dictator, just at the end of the Soviet era. He wanted Romania to up its birth rate and mandated pregnancy for his female citizens, and so there was a spate of excess births, and the Romanian orphanages filled up with orphans. This was only about 30 years ago. Most of them got rudimentary care. No names, no attention. And many of them died, despite the fact that they were sheltered and fed; and the ones that didn't die, who were in a situation like that for any length of time, they weren't recoverable.
- 2.14** So, human flourishing is dependent on maternal solicitude, and there's a tremendous proclivity of the feminine to be solicitous in that manner. But as Freud noted, if that solicitude, that pity, that empathy, that comprehensive care, was protracted beyond its utility, then it became a destructive force.
- 2.15** That's the situation where a mother who takes pride in her compassion above all else, does everything for her child, maybe turning her attention to him, let's say him, instead of her husband, that's where the sexual element starts to creep in, and the situation becomes pathologized. That misapplication of maternal solicitude is a devouring force. That's the idea at the bottom of Nietzsche's questioning about the virtue of pity and equality.
- 2.16** Equality and excellence aren't commensurate principles. If there's excellence, there's going to be a hierarchy of worth. Now, you might be able to set up a situation where everyone has the opportunity to strive for excellence because a multitude of games can be played. I mean, there's very many ways, especially in a diverse modern culture. I don't mean diverse in the racial or ethnic way; I mean a culture that has a very large number of roles.
- 2.17** There's the possibility of specializing in a multitude of different games and climbing to a pinnacle in one of those games, and the opportunity and principle is there for everyone. So that's a kind of equality. It's equality of excellence across a multitude of cooperating games, but that's certainly not the same as a flattening equality.
- 2.18** One of the things that Nietzsche was cognizant of was the pathologizing proclivity of misplaced pity and equality. He sees pity as a form of weakness that undermines life, and equality as a leveling force that stifles greatness. He proposes that true virtue lies in self-overcoming and the creation of new values, again, aligning with his concept of the will to power. He also reflects on the role of suffering in growth.
- 2.19** Part Eight: Peoples and Fatherlands. This section explores nationalism, cultural identity, and the difference between European nations. Nietzsche critiques the rise of nationalism as a petty herd-like phenomenon, but also praises certain cultural traits—German depth, French wit. While envisioning the good European who transcends national boundaries, he sees a future where a new unified European culture could foster higher types of humans. Yes, we see where that's got us.

- 2.20** Finally, [Part Nine]: What is Noble? For Nietzsche, noble means a life-affirming, self-creating individual who embodies the will to power—a lot of self-actualization foundation there. The noble person is independent, strong, and capable of solitude, contrasting with the herd members' conformity. He revisits the master-slave morality distinction, advocating for a return to aristocratic values that celebrate strength, creativity, and hierarchy as natural and necessary for human flourishing.
- 2.21** Nietzsche saw in the proclivity of people to hide in the herd, to camouflage themselves against the herd, a rejection of excellence, a valorization of victimization and slavehood, and a pathology that worked against the best interests of a higher culture. He associated that proclivity in many ways with Christianity. We walked through that. He posited the free spirit philosopher as someone who could stand outside the herd and create their own values. You can see the utility in that because there is something despicable and second-rate about people's proclivity to hide in a false consensus.
- 2.22** Now, we don't want to get too high-handed about that critique either, because the general rule of civilized social conduct should be, mostly you should do what other people do. Because how the hell are people going to get along if that's not the case? The default, given how many of us there are and the fact that we have to live together in something approximating harmony, is that you should roughly do the same things I'm doing. The problem is that sometimes that's not the case.
- 2.23** I suppose, if you gave the devil in Nietzsche his due, you would say that what he was attempting to do was to determine when it was necessary and vital that the individual rejected the casual and cowardly consensus and stood outside. The question then is: In service outside—in service of what? For Nietzsche, it was this will to power, let's say. But that thing is, that conceptualization just never quite takes off. There's a self-worship element to it. And there's also an intellectual arrogance that is predicated on the idea that you can genuinely create your own values.
- 2.24** The devil's in the details. You don't create your own values in a marriage, not if you want it to work. What do you do? Well, you abide by the traditions of marriage, first of all, because then at least you have some sort of guideline. And then, man, you do an awful lot of negotiation, if you have any sense. I mean, you can fall into a slave-tyrant dynamic, where one of you rules one thing, and the other rules another, or maybe one person is just dominant. But that's not a pathway to anything like happiness and play and harmony.
- 2.25** So, create your own values? Too much intellectual narcissism in that formulation. You have to work with other people in the world. It's a funny thing, in the story of the fall, the story of Adam and Eve, Eve is tempted by the serpent to create her own values. That's the fall, because God tells Adam and Eve, "You can do anything you want in the garden, essentially, but you can't eat of the fruit of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil."

- 2.26** What does that mean: the fruit of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil? It means something like, "You can't establish the moral guidelines of the world. That's not within your purview." The serpent comes along and tempts Eve and says, "Well, if you eat this fruit, then you'll know the foundation of morality, and that'll make you like God," which is a usurping temptation. "You'll elevate yourself to the highest position. You'll be able to create your own values." Eve's on board with that, and she eats the fruit, and then the scales fall from her eyes, and she sees that she's naked, and death enters the world. She bites off more than she can chew, and then her cowardly husband goes along with her, because he doesn't have the character to stand up against her.
- 2.27** That's the catastrophe. And I can't understand for the life of me why Nietzsche didn't see the association between that story and his notion of will to power and the notion that we could create our own values. That's exactly what happens in the story of the fall, and the consequences aren't good. The alternative is that you shouldn't bite off more than you can chew, first of all, and especially if it's pride and the desire to usurp that's driving your inquiry. And second, you should discover the moral order and attempt to abide by it. That's a very different idea, that there is an implicit moral order, that you have to be discriminating, and you have to discover it.
- 2.28** I can't see how this cannot be right, because if you're dealing with other people, for example, there's definitely ways in which you can deal with them that are just not going to work. Force is generally one of those. You can get away with that for some amount of time if you're a bully and you have your henchmen, and the rule is, "Do what I say, or else." But as soon as your back is turned, look the hell out. It's not a stable solution. And I'm certainly not going to get my best from you, if you have any spirit at all, if all I'm using on you is force and compulsion.
- 2.29** So, if I deal with you and you and you and you and you, and I'm going to find ways that work and ways that don't work, and they're going to be somewhat common to all of you, and the way that works, that's the way. That's something I'm learning in consequence of investigation. The same thing goes with my interactions with the world. I can't just impose my will on it. I have to attempt. I have to essay forward and see and feel out what works.
- 2.30** And people are always giving you feedback, always, always, with a glance or with an overt criticism or with refusal to cooperate or with enthusiastic going along with your plan. They're always signaling and figuring out how to maximize the utility of those signals, which is what a child does when they actually become popular by proper reputation. That's the discovery of a system of values and not its creation.
- 2.31** And so, that's a place where Nietzsche, I think— see, you could see in that the flourishing of the humanist idea, I suppose, is that you dispense with the idea of the transcendent absolute God. And so, what's left to fill the space? Well, nothing. That's one possibility. That's nihilism or maybe nationalistic orientation or ideology or idiot hedonism. Or what, the self, the person, the human being gets elevated to the highest

place? But the problem with that is: What's the human being, first of all? What is it that you're serving, even in yourself?

**2.32** And then the second problem is, it's not just you at the table, buddy, it's also everybody else. And so, you have to—that ethos can't be self-created. You see that there's a perverse kind of liberalism in that. I mean in the classic liberal sense that puts the individual above everyone else; that's the basic liberal idea. But even the Scottish liberals, they understood that that individual freedom was predicated on a shared set—in Scotland at that time, it was basically a shared set of Christian assumptions. You could be a free liberal individual as long as everyone had the other story right.

**2.33** You dispense with that other story, and you're all out for yourselves, are you? In what direction? And how are we going to produce something like a harmony out of that, especially in the span of a single life? There's something deeply wrong about that. So that's Nietzsche as, in a way, the final expression of humanism: man replaces God. Nietzsche would say, "Well, God is dead." What is God? There's nothing left to replace him but man. Well, that's a very complicated question, and we'll delve into that as we move along.

**2.34** As I said in Intro to Nietzsche, the other course that I've done on Beyond Good and Evil, I discuss On the Prejudices of Philosophers in some detail. And so, I'll just touch on this section of the book here. This is a direct quote from Nietzsche. "Gradually, it has become clear to me what every great philosophy so far has been: namely, the personal confession of its author and a kind of involuntary and unconscious memoir. Also, that the moral (or immoral) intentions in every philosophy constituted the real germ of life from which the whole plant had grown."

**2.35** There's a lot packed into this, like there always is in Nietzsche. "The personal confession of its author and a kind of involuntary and unconscious memoir." Maybe that's what you're always doing when you're thinking. When you ask yourself, "What do I want? What do I think about this?", what are you doing? You're evaluating who you are. What does that mean, who you are, outside of the domain of the thought that you're chasing? You have a pattern of action. That's not thought, that's action. You have a pattern of fantasy, dream and so on, daydream, your whole fantasy life. Lots of people think in images and not words.

**2.36** And all of that's shaped; it's shaped biologically, because the way you act is influenced by biological necessity, let's say, and desire. And then it's also shaped by all of the interactions you've had with people throughout your whole life. They've shaped you to behave and perceive in a certain way. You don't know what that way is. How the hell would you know? Because it's the consequences of all the interactions that you've had.

**2.37** And so, when you're sitting, and you're thinking, "What do I think about this?", what you're doing in a way is, you're translating—this is Nietzsche's point—you're translating who you are. And so, that would mean how you see the world, how you respond

emotionally, the nature of your subjective experience, the pattern of your actions, the patterns of your dreams and fantasies. You're allowing that, encouraging that, to abstract itself and to make itself manifest at the level of explicit speech.

- 2.38** We know there are separate memory systems for such things. So, for example, your skill, the ability to ride a bike, the ability to ski, there's a separate memory system for that. It's called procedural memory. And you can know things that you can't say how to do. You can't say how to ride a bike. What do you say? "You sit on the bike and you pedal and you balance." It's not the kind of description that would enable someone who's never ridden a bike to ride a bike. You have to code that into your action, and that's a particular kind of memory.
- 2.39** You can be amnesiac, unable to move information from short-term attention into long-term memory, and still learn how to ride a bike. And then you have a whole realm of image-related memory and thought that's not semantic, that's not verbal. And then you have a level of verbal memory, and those interact. And Nietzsche's notion was a prodromal to the psychoanalytic idea, knowing that you had depths of your psyche and that thoughts would bubble up from the bottom, the realm of the id, let's say, and make themselves manifest in consciousness. We often think of that as verbal consciousness.
- 2.40** And so, the philosophical enterprise for Nietzsche was a biographical enterprise. How is it that I see the world? How is it that I do see the world? That's a matter of continual self-questioning. But Nietzsche's point also—and this is the postmodernists took this sort of critique in the literary direction—they're always looking for, and the psychoanalysts were doing this, too, they're always looking for the motivation of the thinker.
- 2.41** That's a fair question because the motivation—the thought is not merely the representation of the world as it is; it's a motivated representation. And then the question becomes: motivation toward what? Well, "the moral (or immoral) intentions in the philosophy constituted the real germ of life from which the whole plant had grown." That's postmodernism in a nutshell.
- 2.42** Part Two—so that's all I'll touch on in the first part. Part Two: On the Free Spirit. "Today, shouldn't we have reached the necessity of once more resolving on a reversal and fundamental shift in values, owing to another self-examination of man, another growth in profundity? Don't we stand at the threshold of a period which should be designated negatively, to begin with, as extra-moral? After all, today, at least we immoralists have the suspicion that the decisive value of an action lies precisely in what is unintentional in it, while everything about it that is intentional, everything about it that can be seen, known, conscious, still belongs to its surface and skin—which, like every skin, betrays something but conceals even more. In short, we believe that the intention is merely a sign."

- 2.43** It's a stunning paragraph. The entire theory of psychoanalytic investigation in the unconscious is in that paragraph. So what's Nietzsche saying here? Well, the psychoanalysts, starting with Freud, laid out the idea that much of what we do was a consequence of implicit motives, motives that we couldn't or wouldn't make explicit. That's the unconscious, the levels of it. Now, in our culture, we've taken for granted, since the time of Freud, the existence of the unconscious. And recent occurrences have demonstrated even more profoundly how that unconscious might operate.
- 2.44** There's the unconscious of motivated states. What exactly are you up to? It's not necessarily what you think you're up to. Who knows what's pulling the strings behind the scenes. Then there's this web of implicit presuppositions. Let me give you an example of this. It's a very hard thing to think through. I presume you people have played with ChatGPT and these large language models. So, let's talk a little bit about how they work, because they work like you.
- 2.45** The large language models have actually demonstrated the reality of the implicit, unconscious, and the symbolic domain. They're existence proofs, because the large language models are a map of the semantic unconscious. What do I mean by that? It's very much worth—this is why you can communicate with these things.
- 2.46** So, imagine that you can identify a word from a non-word using a variety of inferential methods; like, ZXPR is not a word. Why? Because it doesn't follow the statistical pattern of a word. The statistical pattern, let's say, of a four-letter word is usually consonant, vowel, and then it depends; it could be another vowel, and it often ends with a consonant, but it's not going to be all consonants. So, one of the ways you can tell a word from a non-word is that a word follows the statistical pattern of the sequence of consonants and vowels. And so, you can pretty much tell that at a glance. So, a word is a word because it follows the statistical pattern of words. That's coded mathematically, you could say, and you know that. You don't know the mathematics, but you can see it.
- 2.47** Now, just as each letter in a word has a statistical relationship with the other letters, words themselves have a statistical relationship with other words. So, some words are going to be found in close proximity to other words while you're communicating, and some words are going to be found—they're never going to be found together. Some words are substitutable, and some words aren't. The large language models mapped all of that. Billions of parameters. They mapped all of that.
- 2.48** What word is likely to come after this word? What word is likely to come two words after this word, three words after, four words after? If these three words are in a sequence, what's the next word that's most likely after those three words? Literally, billions of parameters. We don't even know what the parameters are. They're learned through reinforcement learning, which is essentially how you learned them. And so, the large language models have mapped out the statistical relationship between words, that's the universe of implicit meaning.

- 2.49** I'll give you an example of this. So, one of my colleagues trained a large language model on my books, so I can use it. And we used some other books, too. It is based on a broader, large language model, but it refers to the things I've written and many of the things I've said because we have transcripts of them first. And so, this is a very weird thing to play with, because when I'm writing— I'm writing a book on biblical analysis. I already wrote one, I'm writing another one—sometimes I'll run across a biblical phrase, like a verse that I can't crack. I don't understand what it means. So I can put it in this model, and it'll tell me what I would think it means, even though I don't know.
- 2.50** You might think, "How the hell can it do that?" And the answer is that it's mapped the statistical regularities between the words that I use. It has that, and it's a huge area. The number of words you could produce, given the way you think, is way wider than the number of words you have produced. You're going to produce words in your characteristic manner; that's your style, but that's the statistical regularity.
- 2.51** And so, the universe of connections between the concepts that you've developed is much wider than all the thoughts you've had. That's how you can have new thoughts, or part of the reason; it's not the whole reason, but it's part of the reason you can have new thoughts. And so, that's part of the implicit unconscious, is the—you don't even know this—is that the images that are part of your imagination, the words that make up your thought, have relationship with one another that's implicit, that you don't know. That frames the way that you imagine, see, and think. That's the unconscious. Certainly, it's real. Basically, what we've done with the large language models is externalize the semantic unconscious. God only knows what the consequence of that is.
- 2.52** Now, it's unmoored from the world. The thing about you that makes you different than a large language model is that, not only do your words have to make sense as words, but they actually have to work in the world of images. They have to describe a reality that's also the reality that you imagine, and you see. And when you act them out, they have to work in the world. That isn't a constraint that's there for large language models yet, except that they have to satisfy their users. And that's why they hallucinate and lie and so forth, but that'll be solved sooner or later.
- 2.53** So, anyway. "Today, we immoralists," that's the Nietzscheans, "have this suspicion that the decisive value in action lies precisely in what is unintentional about it, while everything that is intentional still belongs to the surface and its skin." This is what the psychoanalysts started to figure out. It's so interesting because, you see, they figured it out.
- 2.54** This was Jung's point, is that once the divine world had collapsed, really what happened was that it went—what would you say? It fell into the unconscious. Yeah, that's it. So, here's a way of thinking about it. To the degree that our culture was genuinely Judeo-Christian in its structure, that structure is still coded in the relationship between the words. In fact, you could say—and this is likely true—the only reason that you can

understand the words that I use is because the implicit decoding system you use is the same as the one I use. So, what's it based on?

- 2.55** Nietzsche's own point was that the manner in which we understand things is historically determined. What's the historical? This is why, when I argue with atheists, I'm always telling them, "You're Christian to the core, hopefully. You just don't realize it." It's colored not only everything you think, but everything you see. Or if not, then what has? 2000 years of Christianity or 300 years of materialistic humanism? Or your attempt to create your own values? You're not going to get very far, recoding the statistical relationships between all the concepts. Good luck with that. You're caught in that.
- 2.56** And it isn't just words that have those statistical regularities; it's images, too. I can give you strange examples of this. Let's return to that Pinocchio video, for example. There's a scene in there where the puppet goes to find Geppetto in a whale, and everyone just buys that. It makes no sense. It's like, what the hell? You have a puppet who's a liar, who's trying to become human, who loses his father, who ends up inside a whale, where the puppet has to go—and that's okay with you. Why is that okay with you?
- 2.57** Here's another example, in the Sleeping Beauty movie. I like the Disney movies because their animators were imagistic geniuses, and they got the pattern of image right. There's a scene where Prince Phillip—I think it's Prince Phillip—he's trapped in the dungeon by the evil queen. So that's the Oedipal mother who's a little bit on the compassionate side and will do everything for her son, so that he ends up 80 and out of the game. That's all an expression of her love and her hatred for men. It's something like that.
- 2.58** And he is rescued by the benevolent feminine, these little fairies that come and take away his shackles and encourage him. And he jumps on his horse and he's out to fight the evil queen, which is his attempt to mature in the face of overwhelming pity and compassion. That's a good way of thinking about it. And she turns into a dragon. And everyone's fine with that. Why? Because images have a statistical regularity, too, and that's what a symbol is. A symbol is like a collection of images that has something at its core—that would be the archetype of the image complex—but the images are statistically related.
- 2.59** So, if you think of a witch, you don't think of electrical outlets and stainless steel grills. You think of black cats, and swamps, and night, not day. Witches aren't in the day. Witches are at night. And witches are in swamps, not clear, beautiful lakes. They're in swamps. Why swamps? Well, swamps are a place of, what? Malevolent transformation. They're a place of death and decay, and confusion and darkness and uncertainty. Or if a witch is in a forest, it's not a new-growth green forest. It's an old-growth forest that's just ready to burn, and all the branches are dead, and they're claw-like. And she has a raven, not a budgie. And what else? What else? She has a black cat, and not a pug.

- 2.60 The reason those make sense is because those images appear in conjunction with each other in the stories and images of our culture. And so, they fit. Now, they fit—there's a deeper reason they fit than mere proximity. They fit because they're circulating around some center of meaning. And I suppose the witch is the malevolent feminine. And so, that's the— you have to deal with malevolent women, just like you have to deal with malevolent men, and fleshing out that pattern is hyper-useful.
- 2.61 So, the witch in Snow White, in the Brothers Grimm fairy tale, the actual fairy tale, she feeds Snow White a poisoned apple. Why? Because she's an old woman who's competing with a young woman for physical attractiveness and beauty—and that's a pathological competition, because that's the young woman's game. And the way the old woman wins that game is by feeding the young woman a poisoned apple, and pathologizing her, making her unconscious, and drawing her down into something like death. The dwarfs, the ordinary men, they can't protect her from that. They protect her from the evil queen for a fair bit of her machinations, but they can't protect her from that.
- 2.62 These are all things we know in our images because of their symbolic wisdom, but they're not made fully explicit. We can't explain all the interrelationships between the images in the world of imagination. We can't explain them all. They're beyond us by a lot. That's also a place where new insights can come bubbling up.
- 2.63 I've seen images—I talked about this in my Maps of Meaning course. I have an image—it's not my image; it's an image I've found—that has the entire biblical story in one image. It's unbelievable. You could unpack it for—people have—for 2,000 years. So, anyways, this is the psychoanalytic perspective. There's a lot going on in your conscious intention that's behind the scenes, a lot. We've covered some of that. Your emotions play a role. Your motivational states play a role. Your unexamined pathologies play a role. There's a lot of things determining how it is that you're maneuvering in the world outside of your, let's say, devotion to truth and your conscious intent.
- 2.64 I'll tell you a story that will help understand this. I think this is Robert Sapolsky's story. He's a biologist, Stanford biologist. So the story goes. Zebras are camouflaged. That's the theory. That's what their stripes are for. But it's kind of a stupid theory because zebras live in the veldt, and you can see a zebra on the veldt with no problem because the zebra is black and white, and the veldt is beige. So what's the camouflage idea?
- 2.65 Well, there's different ways of being camouflaged. Fish at the lower ends of the food chain, they school together and they fight to get to the middle. Now, often the bigger fish are in the middle, the wiser and bigger fish, because the predators come along and pick off all the outer fish. So there's a fight to the middle in a fish school. Keep that in mind. That's what a fish school is. It's a fight to the middle. Why? To stay away from the predators.

- 2.66** Now you have your zebras. Now, biologists are out there looking at the zebras, and they're trying to analyze their behavior. But they have a problem, because they look at a zebra and they're trying to figure out what it's up to. And then they make a note, and then they look up and be damned if they can tell which zebra they were looking at. And then you can imagine it. The black and white stripes break up the edges of the zebra, and so the zebras against other zebras are camouflaged. They're camouflaged against the herd.
- 2.67** So, these biologists decide they're going to mark a zebra so that they can figure out which zebra they're looking at. So, they clip it on the ear, like with a cattle clipper. They drive up to it with a Jeep, and they put some red paint on its haunch. And as soon as they do that, the lions kill the zebra. Why? Because as soon as the predators can identify an individual, they can hunt it.
- 2.68** So, there's a human form of adaptation, which is herd hide in the middle of the herd. That's the academics and the philosophers that Nietzsche is critiquing in this paragraph. It's not wisdom, it's not exploration, it's not thought; it's the development of a consensus and the fight to get to the middle of the herd. Why? So the predators can't get you.
- 2.69** Now, you know, there's something to be said for that because you have to give the devil his due. There's many cultures that have a variant of this saying. "The nail that sticks its head up against the rest is the one that gets bent by the hammer." They call that tall poppy syndrome in Canada. The poppy that's got its head up above the rest is the first one that gets cut off by the scythe. It's right. Like, make yourself evident at your peril. And maybe that's particularly true in power-mad and violent states. And so, there is utility in herd camouflage, but it isn't a utility that Nietzsche regards as the highest form of utility.
- 2.70** Fundamentally, human beings are social animals, but we're not exactly herd animals. We're pretty variable. We're stunningly creative. And so, there seems to be a dynamic in human beings, a necessary dynamic, between herd adaptation, which is, on the positive side, socialization, and the ability to, what? Generate a new herd, to stand outside the herd, to let the herd know when it's going in the wrong direction? That would be the dynamic pull between the creative, the courageous, and the herd-oriented. Let's be clear, both of those have their utility. I mean, insofar as we're going to be social, we have to act in unison. That's part of being social. But human beings seem to be able to manage both.
- 2.71** Nietzsche is clearly on the side of the exceptional, and he's concerned, and perhaps rightly so, that the herd proclivity crushes the exceptional at the cost of the whole. Because we need dynamism. I think the U.S. probably manages this better than any other country in the world, where there's a real dynamism between the creative artist/entrepreneur and the social community as a whole. And then you get the benefits of both, don't you? You get constant positive transformation and

differentiation of adaptive strategy, but you keep the core together so that everybody can get along. It's a very, very difficult thing to pull off.

- 2.72** Anyways, Nietzsche's criticism here is directed towards those who regard morality as such as the fight toward the center of the herd or the school. That's the consensus, the people he's criticizing. "They belong, briefly and sadly, among the levelers, those falsely —" See, the leveling tendency in Nietzsche's conceptualization, what the hell good is a herd unless everyone's the same? If everyone in the herd is different, there's no camouflage against the herd. So this is a biological, this is a quasi-biological commentary.
- 2.73** If your mode of adaptation is hide in the herd, your motivated proclivity will be, make sure the herd is as homogenous as possible. Right, right, and so, the express motive might be, "Equality for everyone and compassion." The actual motivation is, "Don't stand out anywhere, any of you, because if you do, then I can't hide in the middle of you." And so, "They belong, briefly and sadly, among the levelers—these falsely so-called 'free spirits'—being eloquent and prolifically scribbling slaves of the democratic taste and its 'modern ideas'." It's more of that homogenization.
- 2.74** "They're all human beings without solitude, of course, without their own solitude, clumsy good fellows whom one should not deny either courage or respectable decency —only they are unfree and ridiculously superficial." But superficiality, that's exactly what you'd expect, because if the goal is camouflage against the herd, then superficiality is a virtue and not a fault. Because the superficial, by definition, you could say, is that which is shared by all. And it's that which is shared by all that makes for the herd itself and for the background of the camouflage.
- 2.75** I really learned this when I started selling selection tools to corporations 30 years ago, something like that, and we had developed these tools of personality and cognitive ability analysis, when I was working in Boston, that were very good at identifying people who would be stellar contributors to complex organizations. They could learn quickly. They were conscientious, so hardworking, diligent, industrious, reliable, or entrepreneurial. Those are different sets of traits. Extremely valuable selection processes.
- 2.76** I spent a lot of time talking to middle managers in big corporations, which was definitely the wrong place to start. All I saw was that there was only one motivation that mattered: never be noticed. Never be noticed. My sales pitch was, "If you use this, your company will thrive." Their concern was, "What if it goes wrong? What if I'm noticed?" There was no ambition. There was no desire to make a name. There was a desire to never have to bear blame for anything that went wrong.
- 2.77** It took me a long time to understand that, because for all their faults, academics are generally somewhat more exploratory than middle managers at very large corporations, who are concerned with risk mitigation above all else. It took me a long

time to understand that motivational frame, but I can understand it. There's default security in not being called out, not being noticed. Now, you'll never win the biggest games, playing that way. But it's a good risk mitigation strategy, and it's biologically sound.

- 2.78** "Only they are unfree and ridiculously superficial, above all in their basic inclination to find in the forms of the old society as it has existed so far just about the cause of all human misery and failure—which is a way of standing truth happily upon her head!" God, he throws so many ideas in a single paragraph that it's painful. "These superficial people have the basic inclination to find in the forms of the old society as it has existed so far," so that would be its insistence on a kind of merit, "just about the cause of all human misery and failure, which is a way of standing truth happily upon her head!"
- 2.79** How would we understand that? Criticisms of the oppressive patriarchy, I suppose, is the easiest way in that. All of human society is the consequence of the oppression of the past. It's like, no, some of it is. It would be very useful to admit to the achievements of the past. But to admit to the achievements of the past is to admit that there are achievements, and that there's a rank order in achievement, and that there's more to the world than hiding in the herd.
- 2.80** And that would undermine the presupposition that the best way forward is to adopt an invisible consensus and to hide in the herd. It's an anti-meritocratic ethos. Well, obviously, because if you're meritorious in an enterprise, if there is such a thing as merit even, then the merit will single you out as identifiable. But if your goal is never be identified and hide, then even the idea of merit, even as a conclusion from past grandeur, you might say, is a threat to the ethos that you use as your pathway to continued security.
- 2.81** Now, why does he say "which is a way of standing truth happily upon her head"? As far as Nietzsche is concerned, and I think he's absolutely correct about this, everything we have in the present that's of value is a consequence of the merit of the past. And so, when you blame the past for all evil, why are you standing truth on its head?
- 2.82** For the same reason that people who blame the United States for slavery stand truth on its head. Every human society practiced slavery. Slavery was how things got done before the Industrial Revolution. The only country that ever stood against slavery in the history of the planet was Great Britain, and America derived most of its ethos with regard to individual freedoms from Great Britain. Why did it stand truth on its head? It's like the only two societies, roughly speaking, that ever stood against slavery are blamed for its existence. That's not very helpful.
- 2.83** "In all the countries of Europe," this is a very modern statement, "and in America, too, there now is something that abuses this name, free spirit, a very narrow, imprisoned, chained type of spirit who wants just about the opposite of what accords with our intentions and instincts. Not to speak of the fact that regarding the new philosophers

who are coming up, they must assuredly be closed windows and bolted doors." That's another form of camouflage, I suppose, in Nietzsche.

- 2.84 So, what's his critique? There is a motivational ethos whose goal is to hide in the herd. It clothes itself with the proclamation and insistence that it is the hallmark of morality as such, and the most admirable carrier of the philosophic tradition. But in truth, the ethos is as antithetical to the philosophy that nature wants to see manifest as it could possibly be.
- 2.85 So, what's his—he has a very vicious critique. He would say that if you wanted to camouflage yourself most effectively within an institution against the herd, you would adopt the superficial appearance of a revolutionary contributor and stay hidden at the same time. And so, you would take what you oppose and clothe yourself in its guise to hide even from yourself the fact that you're acting in antithesis to the principles that you claim to be supporting.
- 2.86 I saw this at the University of Toronto. I have to give you a more concrete example. There was a constant clamor at the University of Toronto about excellence. Constant, constant clamor. Excellence in all things—and very little manifestation of that in actuality. I saw this most particularly when I tried to decorate my office. I had this hideous office. It was pretty high ceilings and it was well lit, but it was all cinderblock because it was built in the '70s, like all the psychology buildings, and had fluorescent lights, which Satan himself invented, as far as I'm concerned. It was just generic.
- 2.87 My brother-in-law, who's a great engineer, said it was "hoseable architecture." What he meant by that was that anything could happen in one of those rooms, and you could just wash it down. Yeah, industrial bureaucracy gone mad. I had been offered a bit of a budget at one point, \$1,200 or something, to renovate my office, because I had been moved from one place to another.
- 2.88 And so, I talked to this artist friend of mine and came up with this dirt-cheap plan to make it beautiful. We were going to put wood panels over the concrete blocks and made out of plywood, pretty cheap, 40 bucks a panel, easy to finish. Paint the ceiling with this stuff called hammerite that looks like hammered glass, and carpet it properly. Really dirt-cheap. And the whole faculty had been talking about the need to renovate our floor because it was so soul-deadening and that hideous that it was embarrassing to have outside speakers come there. It didn't scream excellence, let me tell you that.
- 2.89 So, I conjured up this plan, and I was foolish enough to tell the chair at that time what I was doing. She told me I couldn't do it. I thought, "What do you mean, I can't do it? What do you mean exactly? It's dirt-cheap. You'd been talking about the necessity of doing this. I've come up with a plan. I can do it in a weekend. It's not going to disrupt anything. It's going to be beautiful." And she said, "Well, if you do it, everyone will—" She actually said this. "If you do it, everyone will want it."

- 2.90** And I thought, "Oh, I see. I'm a kindergarten child, and you're an idiot kindergarten teacher. That's the game we're playing." It's like, if you get that, everyone will want it. It's like, first of all, everyone could have it, because it didn't cost anything. And second, that's already what we had decided. And so, I made my objections to her idiocy, totalitarian, compassionate idiocy, clear. She said, "Don't push me on this." And I thought, "Oh, yes, that bloody well figures." So I had plan B, of course, because I have a plan B, and I did that instead.
- 2.91** And then, this is the kicker of the story. It's so funny. I heard later that, when new faculty members came to the psychology department—because I fixed up my office, so it wasn't as good as the original plan, but it was a hell of a lot better than it was; it wasn't soul-deadening to the core—they would bring new faculty members to show them my office, to show them how much creative freedom there was at the University of Toronto, which just absolutely bloody well figured.
- 2.92** And so, this is exactly the sort of point that—yeah, I'd never really recovered from that, I can tell you. It was so insane. It was so insane. And it was so funny because people would come into my office and they'd do a double take, because I put these, like—it had those drop ceilings. I hope the person who invented drop ceilings goes to drop ceiling hell after they die. They have to live where there are drop ceilings and fluorescent lights for 50,000 years before they get a chance to testify on their own behalf.
- 2.93** Anyways, I put up these hammered copper ceiling tiles that you could just glue to the drop tile, and I put in lights, so I didn't have to depend on the fluorescence. There was art and some carpets. It was quite nice, and we painted it quite nicely. People would double-take when they came in, because it wasn't absolutely god-awful hideous, which is exactly not what a university should be. It should be beautiful, beautiful, because it's aiming up. It's aiming outside—what? The confines of a knowledge factory, this generic bloody hellhole of dullness and stupidity. That's exactly the sort of thing that Nietzsche was criticizing.
- 2.94** "A very narrow, imprisoned, chained type of spirit who wants just about the opposite of what accords with our intentions and instincts. Not to speak of the fact that regarding the new philosophers who are coming up." This is a call that Nietzsche is making to a certain kind of courage on the philosophical front. "They must assuredly be closed windows and bolted doors."
- 2.95** "What they would like to strive for with all their powers is the universal green-pasture happiness of the herd, with security, lack of danger, comfort, and an easier life for everyone; the two songs and doctrines which they repeat most often are 'equality of rights' and 'sympathy for all that suffers'." And then he puts the kicker on at the end. "And suffering itself they take for something that must be abolished."

- 2.96** You read that, and you think, especially if you're young and naive, you think, "Of course, suffering should be abolished." And Nietzsche's point is, where'd that idea come from, and what makes you so sure about it? And his next statement is, "We opposite men haven't—" and that's such a good example of how he thinks, and he just tosses that in there: "Two songs and doctrines, which they repeat most often, are 'equality of rights' and 'sympathy for all that suffers'." That could have been written yesterday. This is 150 years ago. It could have been written yesterday. He saw this coming, just as certainly as anyone who has ever seen anything.
- 2.97** And then allies that with, "Suffering itself they take for something that must be abolished." Well, what's that? The battle cry of every revolutionary. "The utopia will come, and there'll be no suffering." What do you mean? Do you mean no difficulty? Do you mean no challenge? Do you mean no experiences that would transform you? Part of Nietzsche's doctrine—and it wasn't well formulated with the will to power idea—is that, what's your life for? Is it for security, lack of danger, comfort, and an easier life for everyone? Maybe that's what you want for your nine-month-old. Yes, maybe that, but not for your two-year-old.
- 2.98** And an easier life for everyone, is that what you want? Do you want an easier life, exactly? Do you want a life of—how about a life of difficult romantic adventure? That's what you go watch, if you go watch a movie. You don't go watch people sitting around having an easy life in a movie. Is that really the criteria by which you're going to judge the advancement of your psyche and your civilization? And it's so strange, because when you see—well, of course, you want security. Of course, you want a lack of danger and comfort. Of course, you want an easier life. Really, do you?
- 2.99** Dostoevsky was writing at the same time. He talked about exactly this in parallel with Nietzsche. He talked about what was—this is in Notes from Underground. He said that if you gave human beings—what? The opportunity to do nothing but sit around in warm pools of water and eat cake and busy themselves with the continuation of the species—I always think of California when I'm thinking about that—the first thing they would do is, they would smash it all up, just so that something interesting would happen.
- 2.100** This was Dostoevsky's devastating takedown of a kind of utopian socialism. It's not. It's utopian immaturity. Devastating takedown in Notes from Underground. He's one of the first people who really figured this out, with this new utopian notion of security, lack of danger, comfort, and easier life for everyone. He said that's not—human beings aren't like that. We're fundamentally out of our minds. We're fundamentally insane. If you gave someone nothing but comfort, the first thing they would do is express their ingratitude and smash it to bits.
- 2.101** And then he says that you should be happy about that, because that's actually far more core to what's truly human than the desire for a kind of effortless utopian comfort. There's no reason to assume whatsoever that we're built for that, or that we would

want it, or that if we got it, we would be even vaguely satisfied with it. It's like, what is it that you do want, and what is it that you should want?

- 2.102** One possible answer to that is that you want an optimized challenge. That is not the same as security. And maybe it's not the imposition of suffering beyond your ability to tolerate it, although God only knows how much you could tolerate in the service of something high. You don't know, and you don't even know how much of it you'd want.
- 2.103** Because you think about how your memory is structured, even. You don't remember and celebrate those events where you did something easy, and it worked out. What you remember, and you celebrate, is—what? Striving forward against something like insuperable odds and managing the transformation, anyways? It's something like that. That's certainly when you feel that you've accomplished something and changed in a direction that—what? Enables you to have more confidence in who you are, and who human beings are, and the way that you might proceed out into the future. And so, Nietzsche, in one line, "Suffering itself they take for something that must be abolished."
- 2.104** Obviously, suffering should be abolished. Hmm, really? Maybe not. And if maybe not, then what of all these utopian schemes? And what of the notion of making life easy for everyone? And what of the idea that what you provide is security? Well, if you provide nothing but security for your children, they never leave home. Right, so that's not a good idea. You want to provide something like an optimized challenge. And if you're in a marriage, and all you get is predictability, is that going to be enough? Or are you going to drive your partner mad, until they do something interesting? Right. Much more likely. Now, there's individual variability in that, clearly, and some people need more novelty than others, but—
- 2.105** "We opposite men, having opened our eyes and conscience to the question where and how the plant 'man' has so far grown most vigorously to a height, we think that this has happened every time under the opposite conditions; that to this end, the dangerousness of his situation must first grow to the point of enormity, his power of invention and simulation (his 'spirit') had to develop under prolonged pressure and constraint into refinement and audacity, his life-will had to be enhanced into an unconditional power-will."
- 2.106** That's a very different vision than security. That's a vision of optimized pressure. I've thought about this a lot, and this is where I think his will to power idea, again, is an insufficient conceptualization, even of what he's trying to describe here. There's only so much you can expect from one person thinking. Nietzsche got a long ways in many different directions, but "his power of an invention and simulation had to develop under prolonged pressure and constraint into refinement and audacity."
- 2.107** This man named Jaak Panksepp, he's a biologist, biological psychologist, and he discovered the play circuit in mammals. So there's a special play circuit in mammals. Play is this. Because when you play, you see, imagine within the confines of a game,

you want to find a play partner. The word Eve, Eve in the Old Testament, is an ezer kenegdo, if I remember the Hebrew properly. It means "optimized partner in martial play," something like that. So it's someone to contend with.

- 2.108** Think about what kids want in a game or in a play partner. They want someone who's either at their level of development or higher. Now, they can play with younger kids and they'll scaffold them along, but they're not doing that to push themselves up the developmental hierarchy. What they want to do is, they want to find a set of principles to define a game, and then they want to find a partner who's about as good as they are or better. And then they want to play on the edge. And the reason they want to play on the edge is because they want to find the optimal amount of pressure that will force them to develop.
- 2.109** The fact that the play circuit exists, this is a critical part of this, because it means that the pleasure that's a consequence of voluntary play is a manifestation of the instinct that puts people on the edge of development and pushes them forward. You think, if the goal of the game is to win, you pick a partner you can beat every time. But no one does that except psychopaths, like narcissistic psychopaths. Why? It's not any fun. Why is it not any fun, if the point is to win? The point isn't to win. The point is to win when it's hard. Right.
- 2.110** And so then all of a sudden, now you have your notions of a suffering-free existence. No, not exactly. And is optimized suffering challenge? It's something like that. And so, maybe you don't want to push yourself to the point of breaking, although there is something to be said now and then for pushing yourself to the point of breaking, and it seemed to me, as a clinical psychologist, that when you're in your 20s, that's a good time to experiment with that.
- 2.111** What can you do? How do you know? You push yourself to the limit, and you find out where it is, and then maybe you step back so it can be sustained, but you need to know. This is certainly what archaic people do with their initiation ceremonies, particularly with young men. Women get initiated by nature. That's a good way of thinking about it. Almost all cultures have initiation ceremonies for young men, and they're often quite brutal.
- 2.112** And part of the reason for that is, you don't know what trouble is, but we can show you. And then from here on in, whatever happens to you, that won't look so much like trouble. And you know, who knows about that? How far do you have to be pushed before your nervous system is calibrated properly? That's a very hard question. Now, you can obviously— the trauma literature shows that you can put people in situations where they encounter malevolence in particular and push beyond their capacity, and that hurts them.
- 2.113** But the exposure literature shows that you get more resilient by exposing yourself to terrible things voluntarily. What's the limit to that? I don't know. How terrible are the

things that you're going to have to deal with in your life? How terrible are they going to be? Well, people you love are going to die. The things that you pursue will collapse. There'll be plenty of times of pain and maybe immense social upheaval. Who knows? There are very complex things coming down the pipeline toward you, certainly.

- 2.114** What to do about that? Search for security? How are you going to be prepared then when it comes? You'll collapse. It'll be much worse than it would have been otherwise. And maybe you won't be able to see it coming; and so, what's the alternative? "To develop under prolonged pressure and constraint into refinement and audacity." Right, and I don't think there's much difference in that.
- 2.115** In a family, there's not much difference between that and encouragement for children. "You can do it. There's more to you than you think." That's not security. Or it's a very refined and audacious form of security. What's the best security? To learn to handle serpents, not to free the situation of all possible danger. That's Nietzsche's perspective.
- 2.116** And then, so he's asking, if you were setting up a society or a socialization structure for children, let's say, or a developmental pathway for yourself, what do you build in to optimize it? Certainly not the absence of suffering. Maybe you could say, maximal bearable suffering undertaken voluntarily. This is also why I think Nietzsche's critique of Christianity is off the mark, because that's the story of the Passion—maximum suffering undertaken voluntarily. That's a pretty good foundation for society, pretty good. That's the proper foundation for society.
- 2.117** "We think that hardness, forcefulness, slavery, danger in the alley and the heart, life in hiding, stoicism, the art of experiment and deviltry of every kind, that everything evil, terrible, tyrannical in man, everything in him that is kin to beasts of prey and serpents, serves the enhancement of the species 'man' as much as it opposite does." That's part of his revaluation of all values.
- 2.118** I think the right way to conceptualize this, and I've thought about this from the psychoanalytic perspective, is that it's very common, when things go astray psychologically, that a subordinate drive dominates the eating disorders. So, eating dominates. There's sexual disorders, there's disorders of power, disorders of hedonism. These instinctual forces that are primordial and profound take predominance and rule, and that makes them pathological.
- 2.119** But one way of threading the Nietzschean needle here is to say, "Everything in its proper place." It isn't that you want to dispense with your capacity for aggression, not in the least. You want to refine it and maximize it, but then it has to be put in the proper place and serve the proper end. For Nietzsche, that's will to power. It's not well formulated, in my estimation, but "everything evil, terrible, and tyrannical in man," in principle put in its proper place, "could serve the enhancement of the species."
- 2.120** I'll give you an example of this. In the Old Testament, for example, the shepherd is the archetype of normative ideal masculinity. So, the shepherd isn't a leader. It's a lowly

position. It's an ordinary position, but it's optimized ordinary. That's a good way of thinking about it. Moses is a shepherd before he becomes a leader. David is a shepherd. Christ is a shepherd or a meta shepherd.

- 2.121** Why a shepherd? Well, shepherds in ancient times had to contend with predators, wolves and lions, and there were lots of them. And they had rather primordial tools—slingshots, spears, shields—to deal with wolves and lions. That's unimaginable in a way to modern people. And then they had to take care of themselves in the wilderness. So they're self-sufficient, capable of dealing with predators, but they serve the most vulnerable. So it's that strange juxtaposition of service to the vulnerable, the lambs, let's say, and the capacity to deal with the predator.
- 2.122** And so, there's tremendous aggression in that, tremendous aggression in that. But it's slotted into the service of something—well, you can see. So, the Christian sacrifice was the inversion of sovereignty so that, instead of the power that Nietzsche proclaimed as admirable, sovereignty itself and power became the voluntary service to the most vulnerable. That's the inversion of the notion of sovereignty. And Nietzsche characterized that as slave morality, but that's not a useful critique in my estimation.
- 2.123** It was an extension of the shepherd motif where the most aggressive impulses that were characteristic, let's say, of human males—they're there in women, too, but in different manifestation—were developed tremendously, but then put into service, and service, in the case of the shepherd, of the most vulnerable. And so, you have this inversion of the idea of sovereignty, very different from the archaic world, the Roman and Greek world, that the highest form of sovereignty was service to the most vulnerable.
- 2.124** That's not a valorization of slavery; that's not what it is. It's the expansion of that principle of shepherd to a metaphysical domain, where all the aggressive, and all the instincts that would serve aggression and expansion are placed in their proper position, and then put into service of—it's something like those who are in the most need.
- 2.125** You can think about that biologically. When you become a father, first of all, you should be a man by the time you become a father, and so you should have some of the attributes of an archaic shepherd. You should be able to take care of yourself. You should be able to deal with the predators. Well, then, what do you put that in the service of? Obviously, you put it in the service of your wife and her infant. And so, that has to be subordinated to the service of what's most vulnerable, clearly, for it to be in its proper place. And then if it's in its proper place, it's not a vice, it's a virtue. And so, that's kind of the Nietzschean—
- 2.126** See, the psychoanalysts had sorted this out to a fair degree because it took a long time, 50 years of thinking, probably, because Freud thought about the id, which was this conglomeration of instinctual drives, fighting against the superego, that they were in an

antithetical relationship, that your aggression, your sexuality, had to be regulated or inhibited.

- 2.127** Piaget and Jung, to some degree, took a different tack, which was, it's not repression. It's not a battle, not unless it's happened pathologically. It's like, the impetus for development for a child who's courageous doesn't have to work in antithesis with his father's desire to maintain harmony in the home. Those could be aligned, right? Because then if you have a son, and he wants to move forward in the world, that can be integrated, so that works in harmony in the household. Those things don't have to be set against each other, like the noble savage against the totalitarian state. They could be integrated. And that's—well, Nietzsche is pointing in that direction here.
- 2.128** That's part of this revaluation. This is also part of what Jung developed, Carl Jung developed later, as his insistence that the way out of the persona—the persona is the part of you that will hide in the herd. That's a good way of thinking about it. It's a mask that says, "I'm part of the herd. I'm an invisible and cooperating part of the herd." Your way out of that was through the investigation of the shadow. It's like, "I'm not that happy with what the herd's doing."
- 2.129** Why? Maybe the herd is stampeding off a cliff. Such things happen. And when the herd is about to stampede off a cliff, it's time not to be part of the herd. Well, how are you going to do that without any aggression? You're not going to do it, because where are you going to get the motive force? Anger inhibits fear. It does that biologically. If you chase a cat around with a broom or a rat—Vladimir Putin tells this story, by the way, about a rat he chased when he was a kid— you chase a rat around with a broom and corner it, it will attack you. It'll run first. But when running no longer suffices, aggression comes out, quells fear.
- 2.130** And so, why do you need to integrate aggression? So fear doesn't stop you. That's part of it. And this is also why it's very useful to take note of your resentment. There's anger in that. "I'm not happy with this situation." Are you immature? Sort that out. Maybe you're a slave in a relationship with a tyrant. Then you've got something to say. Where are you going to find the wherewithal to manage that? You're going to have to draw on some source of primordial power to overcome your fear, let's say, an aggression.
- 2.131** You see this in the Lion King movie. It's very interesting. I saw this in my clinical clients when they underwent, you could say, an integration. When I first saw them, they were often naïve, and they had a facial expression that was like this, like things were happening to them. You see this in the Lion King.
- 2.132** You can see the scene where this shift—so there's a scene where Simba, who's an adolescent, useless adolescent, he's shamed by Nala because he's not who he should be. That's a role women play. And Rafiki, who's the shaman, shows up and shows him the pathway to the underworld. He goes down into this initiatory tunnel and comes to a reflecting pool and looks in and sees who he is. And then he sees his father, who's the

true king in the sky. And his father has a completely different expression. It's a commanding expression, and that commanding expression is part of the integration of that capacity for aggression.

**2.133** You don't see it in naive people. They've got this "friend zone" expression that's often portrayed in movies, where you have some dismal man trying to bed a woman by being her friend. That's a very common theme in modern comedies, in particular, and he's got this naive expression on his face. And the animators captured this perfectly.

**2.134** He undergoes this transformational moment, and his face hardens, and he takes on the same facial expression that the father, who was the king, had. And then he has that for the rest of the movie. I think that's part of what Nietzsche was trying to tap at with this idea of will to power. There should be something in you that's attempting to express itself outward, rather than merely hiding in the herd with all that herd pathology.

## Lecture 3: Religious Instinct

At a glance — The religious instinct.

- 3.1** Part Three: What is Religious? "Why atheism today? The 'father' in God has been thoroughly refuted; ditto, 'the judge,' 'the rewarder.' Iso his 'free will': he does not hear —and if he heard, he would still not know how to help." Well, you see a number of things there. You see, again, part of the reflection of Nietzsche as a complex and contradictory thinker. He knew when he announced the death of God that all hell was going to break loose because of that. But there's a part of him that's also triumphant about this. So, God's dead.
- 3.2** "The 'father' in God has been thoroughly refuted." That's a disputable proposition, to say the least. "The 'father' has been thoroughly refuted." Let me give you an example of that. I had this vision at one point. I'll tell you how it started. This is where fantasies can go if you let them unfold. So I remembered this time in my life when I was about three years old, four years old, something like that. My parents and I used to go to this farmhouse in northern Alberta, really at the end of the settled territory in northern Alberta, right at the end of the railway.
- 3.3** These Russians had moved there. They were white Russians. They'd escaped the Russian Revolution. They'd settled there, and my dad was friends with the son of this family that still lived on the property. They had a farmhouse there. I really liked this family a lot, the Sideroffs. I really liked them a lot. They had a very solid marriage, these two, Nick and Helen Sideroff. They had three sons who I really liked. They were much older than me, like five to ten years older than me, but they made me very welcome. I used to sit in the living room with Nick and my dad, and I'd sit at Nick's feet, and I'd try to hit his feet with my fists, and he'd play.
- 3.4** I was thinking about that because I was thinking about my dad. My dad had this single-shot rifle collection, and him and Nick used to hunt. My dad was obsessed with single-shot rifles. I could never figure out why. I figured out partly because of this vision; it was because he wanted to hit the dead center of the target with one shot, and that that was a metaphysical endeavor. It had religious significance for him. He had atheistic proclivities, intellectually, and so the intellectual, the religious impulse, took this more practical tack and seized him somewhere else. One shot, center of the target. Sin means to miss the target. That's literally what it means.
- 3.5** So, anyways, I'm sitting on the floor hitting Nick's feet, trying to sharpen my aim, and that's what he's playing. I remember my dad saying, "Quit, Jordan. Quit bothering Nick." And Nick said, "He's not bothering me." And I knew I wasn't bothering him, and Nick knew I wasn't bothering him. My dad knew, too, but it was the polite thing to say.
- 3.6** And so, then I remembered all these men that were around my father. Most of the friends that my father had were good men. They weren't flashy men. They weren't

ambitious men. They were salt-of-the-earth types, hunters, a lot of them, and farmers, sensible people, and conventional people, I would say, but in the good way. I remembered them and the different roles they played for me when I was a kid. And then I realized that there was a spirit that united them all, and that's the spirit of good men.

- 3.7** You know that that spirit exists, because you wouldn't have a concept of good man versus bad man if that category didn't exist. So, then you could imagine, you could take a variety of men, and you could say, to the degree that they're good, they share something in common. Then I could see that spirit of paternal goodness stretching back into the generations, and then I could see it as such. And I thought, "That's what God as 'father' means." That's what that is. It's the spirit of benevolent paternalism. And it's distributed across the corpus of good men, obviously. "The 'father' in God has been thoroughly refuted." Yeah, I don't think so.
- 3.8** "Ditto, 'the judge' and 'the rewarder.'" Well, your conscience might tell you something different than that. No. Does your conscience judge you? Yes, that's what it's for. Where did it come from, and what is it a manifestation of? It's the manifestation of the voice that tells you when you deviate from the spirit of good men. Is it real? Try violating it. Do you believe in it? If you don't, you're a psychopath. So, there's that. Does it tell you what you want to hear? Not exactly. And heaven help you if you don't hearken to its voice. The judge, the rewarder.
- 3.9** Also, his free will. "He does not hear—and if he heard, he still would not know how to help." It depends on how you ask, I would say. So, I'll give you an example of that. When Christ is at the end of his 40 days in the desert—so this is post-baptism—Satan comes to tempt Him. Three temptations. The first is to ask God for things you don't deserve. Turn the stones into bread. It's a wish-fulfillment prayer: I wish I could have something I didn't work for. And Christ dispenses with that.
- 3.10** The second temptation is, Satan brings Him to a height and says, "Throw yourself off, because if you're the son of God, God will protect you." And Christ says, "Do not tempt the Lord your God." And what He means by that is something like, you're not to ask for dispensation. You're not to entreat the spirit of the highest for benefits that not only do you not deserve, but that you're rejected by putting yourself voluntarily in danger. No free passes. You don't get what you don't deserve, and there aren't any free passes. Those are off the table with regards to prayer. And the third temptation is the one of power.
- 3.11** Then in the Sermon on the Mount, Christ says here's how you pray: aim at what's highest and concentrate on the moment. That's very different. "He does not hear." You might say it depends on how he's asked. And so, you could imagine this, too, and I believe this to be true on psychological grounds. If you started every endeavor with the intent of aiming at what was highest, then the spirit that would emerge to guide you would be the spirit of that aim. That's how your perceptions work.

- 3.12** When you look for a way forward, you see the pathway to the destination you've chosen. Right, so what do you pick as a metaphysical destination? Why don't you pick the highest possible good as a metaphysical destination? What does that imply? The pathway to that will make itself shown. That is how your perceptual systems work. So Nietzsche, he's a little drifting sideways here, I would say. It's a little shallow. "Also his 'free will.' he does not hear—and if he heard, he would still not know how to help." Yeah, it depends on how he's asked, so to speak.
- 3.13** "Worst of all, he seems incapable of clear communication. Is he unclear? This is what I found to be causes for the decline of European theism, on the basis of a great many conversations, asking and listening. It seems to me that the religious instinct is indeed in the process of growing powerfully—but the theistic satisfaction it refuses with deep suspicion." There's a lot of ideas, again, in that paragraph.
- 3.14** "The religious instinct is indeed in the process of growing powerfully." Maybe you saw that manifest in the 20th century, with the flourishing of the communist delusion, for example. Maybe you saw that in the flourishing of the Nazi ideology and this proclivity of entire societies and peoples to be possessed by these demonic ideas. That's definitely a manifestation of the religious impulse. You see the same thing now with nature worship, I would say.
- 3.15** "The religious instinct is in the process of growing powerfully." What does that mean? Well, it doesn't have its proper outlet. That's a good way of thinking about it. It isn't canalized into a set of collective narratives and practices, because that's what a religion that unites does. It takes the religious impulse. What is that? The impulse for the deepest of all possible meanings? It's something like that. The impulse to orient upward and forward? It's something like that. The impulse to wayfind and navigate? There's no dispensing with that.
- 3.16** Something will attract your interest if it isn't—something will attract your interest if it isn't being done consciously. That's what happened with my father and his single-shot rifles. That became religiously significant. Something is going to become, or you'll fall into a chaotic and hedonistic nihilism. But if something arises as a centralizing force, it'll grip your interest and hold you. That's a kind of possession that's tilting towards a religious realization. That's what happens to Moses when he encounters the burning bush. He's an ordinary shepherd. Something captures his attention, and he investigates it deeply, and that's when he becomes a leader.
- 3.17** "This is what I found to be causes of the decline of European theism." Well, you could say, with equal validity, that the reason that European theism declined—it's so complicated—is that people had the wrong—once people started asking questions about God, let's say, about at the time of the dawn of the scientific revolution, they didn't ask the right questions.

- 3.18** I saw this when I was talking to people like Richard Dawkins and Sam Harris, these famous atheists. They're not asking the right questions. They think about this as something like a bad—they think of the religious enterprise as something like a bad scientific theory. That's not what it is at all.
- 3.19** And so, if your criteria for proof is that you're unable to make contact with God, the judge or the rewarder, and if He's hearing, He doesn't know how to help, one conclusion from that is, there's nothing there; and another conclusion is, you're not asking the right way. There's an insistence—
- 3.20** This is very useful to know, too, because it's another thing I saw with the atheist types. This is very true with Richard Dawkins. I talked to Bret Weinstein about this, who's an evolutionary biologist. Dawkins approaches these old texts from a position of intellectual superiority. And that's a big mistake as a biologist, as far as I'm concerned, because I studied as a psychobiologist. It's a big mistake, because if you're a biologist, one of the things you should think is: What in the world is this religious impulse? What is it? You can't just brush it off.
- 3.21** When you experience awe, which is a primary religious manifestation, this is how old it is. Your hair will stand on end at the back of your neck. You experience this, let's say, if you're moved very profoundly by a piece of music or something beautiful, something awe-inspiring, the hair will stand up on the back of your neck. It gives you shivers and chills. What is that? Well, I'll tell you, it's not rational. And you know how I know? It's piloerection. It's a piloerection instinct.
- 3.22** You've seen a cat puff up when it sees a dog, and it's startled? So, the cat will puff up, and then it dances sideways. The reason it does that is so it looks like a big cat, and it dances sideways, so it looks even bigger. What's the cat experiencing? It's experiencing what you'd experience if you saw a dog that was 20 feet high. So it's awe. Its hair stands on end. That's what you experience when you experience awe. Well, that's not rational. That's as old—we experienced that when we had fur. So that's like—what? 10 million years old. Minimum. Much older than that. We share it with cats. It's old.
- 3.23** And so, if you have any sense, you approach the domain of religious phenomenology with some caution, and you look at it, at least biologically; what the hell is going on? What is this uniting impulse that emerges to dominate? And what's its nature biologically, as much as metaphysically?
- 3.24** Nietzsche knew this. It's so paradoxical in his thinking, because at the top of the paragraph, he dispenses with the notion of God the Father in three sentences. At the bottom, he says, "It seems to me that the religious instinct is indeed in the process of growing powerfully— but the theistic satisfaction, it refuses with deep suspicion." Well, maybe the theistic satisfaction that there's a God in heaven who somehow grants you wishes like a genie just isn't sophisticated enough to suffice.

- 3.25** "Once one sacrificed human beings to one's god, perhaps precisely those whom one loved most," that's a reference to Abraham, "the sacrifices of the first-born in all prehistoric religions belong here." There's a question for biologists, because this is a very widespread human phenomenon. Why? Because human beings realized that life was sacrificial. This is the essence of the idea of work. What does work mean? Sacrifice the present to stabilize the future. What does work mean? Sacrifice your own narrow self-interest to bring long-term security and opportunity to your family and your community. Those are sacrificial moves. Human beings are really the only creatures that do that.
- 3.26** How did we figure that out? How did we figure that out? How did we come to figure that out consciously? You have to work. Chimpanzees don't know that. We know that. Well, maybe we acted it out first. How do you make your way in the world? You sacrifice things of value. Well, what's the ultimate expression of that? That's Abraham's sacrifice. You offer even your children to what's highest.
- 3.27** Now, can that go sideways and become pathologized? Well, everything can. But is the core impulse correct or incorrect? When Abraham sacrifices Isaac or is willing to, he gets him back. So, I read that story, and I think: how do you ensure the return of your children to you as they mature? You encourage their sacrificial move forward. Right. Right. And towards what end? What—the development of what's highest in them?
- 3.28** I saw the Pietà in St. Peter's, this great statue by Michelangelo. He carved it when he was 24. So, it's Mary sitting with this body of her son after the crucifixion in her arms. She's got a kind of beatific look on her face. She's holding this offering out. It's in St. Peter's. It's not at the central altar, but it's close. And it's always struck me as the female representation of the crucifixion. Well, what do you do when you're—what's the role of a mother? To offer her child to be broken by the world. Towards what end? The highest ends. See if you can come up with a better formulation than that.
- 3.29** "As well as the sacrifice of the Emperor Tiberius in the Mithras grotto of the isle of Capri, the most gruesome of all Roman anachronisms. Then, during the moral epoch of mankind, one sacrificed to one's god one's own strongest instincts, one's 'nature.'" That's part of that integration, as far as I'm concerned. Everything has to be sacrificed upward to be integrated properly, if power isn't going to dominate.
- 3.30** "This festive joy lights up the cruel eyes of the ascetic, the 'anti-natural' enthusiast. Finally, what remained to be sacrificed? At long last, did not one have to sacrifice for once whatever is comforting, holy, healing; all help, all hope, all faith in hidden harmony, in future blisses and justices? Didn't one have to sacrifice God himself and, from cruelty against oneself, worship the stone, stupidity, gravity, fate, the nothing? To sacrifice God for the nothing—this paradoxical mystery of the final cruelty was reserved for the generation that is now coming up: all of us know something of this."

- 3.31** Well, the clarity of mind that the scientific revolution produced, produced as well this technological revolution that has in part brought abundance to the world. And so, was it necessary for the scientific mindset to be set against the religious impulse in order for that to occur? You could make that case. I don't buy it, however, because I think that, to the degree that science and technology serve life abundant, the scientists and the scientific viewpoint has to be embedded in an underlying ethos, sacrificial ethos, that gives it direction. And I think we all know that.
- 3.32** That's why the trope of the evil scientist, the intellect gone mad, is so popular, is that even you could think of the scientific enterprise as bringing technological abundance to the world. But you could think more properly of the scientific ethos bringing abundance to the world when the ethos itself, the scientific ethos, is embedded in something more fundamental that serves human beings psychologically and socially in the proper manner. That has to be in place, and when it isn't, you have the evil scientist. Then all that technological power can be used against people, like I would say it is in China and increasingly in other places in the world.
- 3.33** "Did not one have to sacrifice for once whatever is comforting, holy, healing, all hope?" Not so sure about that. "Every age has its own divine type of naïveté for whose invention other ages may envy it—and how much naïveté, venerable, childlike, and boundlessly clumsy naïveté lies in the scholar's faith in his superiority, in the good conscience of his tolerance, in the unsuspecting simple certainty with which his instinct treats the religious man as an inferior and lower type that he has outgrown, leaving it behind, beneath him—him, that presumptuous little dwarf and rabble man, the assiduous and speedy head- and handiworker of 'ideas,' of 'modern ideas'!"
- 3.34** Nietzsche was not a systematizing thinker. In fact, he distrusted systematizing thinkers. And so, he'll say paradoxical things within the confines, even of a few paragraphs. The thing I read you, the last thing, the last piece I read you, was a critique of the idea of God the Father, and an indication of how the European mind, roughly speaking, had freed itself from the constraints of a kind of dogmatic superstition.
- 3.35** And then you have this paragraph, which says that the typical academic intellectual presumes reflexively that he's head and shoulders among the man with religious commitment, when in fact he's a "presumptuous little dwarf and rabble man, assiduous, speedy head- and handiworker of 'ideas', of 'modern ideas.'"
- 3.36** Well, I guess Nietzsche had enough confidence in his own ability to work through problems, to be able to hold ideas that were in intense competition in his imagination simultaneously, and let that play out and investigate. That's really what thinking is.
- 3.37** When you think, you have a question. That's the first thing. It's a real question. And then you wait for a revelation. And then, in keeping with your aim, the aim is to solve the problem, let's say, to address the question. You have a revelation, and then you

take the revelation, and you counterpose opposing ideas to it, to see if it can withstand the pressure.

- 3.38** Part of the utility in reading Nietzsche, as far as I'm concerned, is that you see that happening in real-time, so to speak. He'll put up this proposition and then this counterproposition, and they're both very well formulated. But there's not any immediate resolution. Getting the questions right is very, very important. It's more important, really, it's more important than generating a premature answer. Get the questions right.
- 3.39** "Religion and religious significance spread the splendor of the sun over such ever-toiling human beings and make their own sight tolerable to them. Religion has the same effect which an Epicurean philosophy has on sufferers of a higher rank; it's refreshing, refining, makes, as it were, the most of suffering, and in the end even sanctifies and justifies. Perhaps nothing in Christianity or Buddhism is as venerable as their art of teaching even the lowliest how to place themselves through piety in an illusory higher order of things, and thus to maintain their contentment with the real order, in which their life is hard enough—and precisely this hardness is necessary."
- 3.40** A tremendous plethora of ideas there again. But I think another place where the thinking goes astray, just with the choice of a few words, "Nothing in Christianity or Buddhism is as venerable as their art of teaching even the lowliest how to place themselves through piety in an illusory higher order of things."
- 3.41** In the story of Elijah, Elijah is the first prophet to identify the conscience with the divine. So, Elijah is the enemy of the worshippers of nature. The worshippers of nature are the thinkers who always exist, who believe that the awe-inspiring manifestations of nature are the closest approximation to the divine that's available to human beings, that divinity is implicit directly in nature.
- 3.42** Elijah has an experience when he's in a cave. He sees a forest fire and a hurricane and an earthquake, and he realizes that God isn't in any of those things. And he draws the conclusion that God is the still, small voice that guides from within. It's a revolutionary conclusion. On his way to that conclusion, when Elijah emerges as a prophet—he's one of the prophets that's transfigured, that appears along with Christ in his transfiguration, Elijah and Moses.
- 3.43** Why Elijah? Elijah lived in the time of a king named Ahab and a queen named Jezebel. Jezebel was a foreign queen, and she was a nature-worshipper, a prophet or an advocate, an acolyte of the god Baal. Elijah has a war with the prophets of Baal and defeats them. And Jezebel, who wants to wipe out Jehovah and all his prophets and replace him with Baal, chases Elijah to kill him. And when he's attempting to escape, he comes across this widow, lowly. The widow in the Old Testament accounts as the most vulnerable form of woman. So, a widow with a child: vulnerable, no male protection, and marginalized—that's a good way of thinking about it.

- 3.44 Elijah lets her know that he's on the lam and hungry. And the widow says to him, "I'm just about to make my son and I the last of our meal, some olive oil, some flour, some water. And then we're going to starve, but you can come and share our meal." And so, Elijah agrees because God has told him to go with this widow, and so he does. And then, as the story progresses, the barrel of meal that she has, she hits it, and they live on what is generated by beating the barrel for, I don't know, a number of weeks. So, it's a miracle, let's say.
- 3.45 So, what does the story mean? It's so interesting. It's germane to Nietzsche's misapprehension here. So, Jezebel is this—she's a queen. She has everything. And she's not good. And because of her pathology and her pride, the whole country is thrown into a drought. Things are not good. And then Elijah, who's fleeing for his life from this powerful queen, comes across this widow who has nothing, has nothing.
- 3.46 Or does she have nothing? See, that's the question. Because even in her straitened condition, she's radically hospitable. So, she has the moral upper hand, you might say, especially over Jezebel, because she's really contrasted with Jezebel: highest evil woman, lowest good woman. Who's at the top of the heavenly hierarchy? Well, Nietzsche and Marx would say, we're going to elevate the lowly to keep them content with their position. That's the Marxist critique. The meaning of this story is quite different. If you're hospitable, even when you're straitened, and everyone's like that, your society will be endlessly abundant. And that's exactly right.
- 3.47 If you set up a situation where the—this is why hospitality is such an important virtue, particularly in the Old Testament. If you set up a situation where self-sacrificial generosity, even towards the stranger, is the primary ethos, everyone will always have more than enough. So is this an illusory higher order of things that the lowliest place themselves in through piety, to maintain their contentment with the real order? Or is this the shining-through of a deep ethos that makes material standing irrelevant and points to the existence of a higher form of morality that's part of this self-sacrificial hospitality that's the eternal source of true abundance?
- 3.48 "What we have to thank them for is inestimable; and who could be rich enough in gratitude not to be impoverished in view of all that the spiritual men of Christianity, for example, have so far done for Europe! And yet, when they gave comfort to sufferers, courage to the oppressed and despairing, a staff and support to the dependent, and lured away from society into monasteries and penitentiaries for the soul those who had been destroyed inwardly and who had become savage, how much more did they have to do besides, in order to work with a good conscience and on principle, to preserve all that was sick and that suffered— which means, in fact and in truth, to worsen the European race? Stand all valuations." This is his critique of Christianity.
- 3.49 "Stand all valuations on their head—that is what they had to do. And break the strong, sickly over-great hopes, cast suspicion on the joy in beauty, bend everything haughty, manly, conquering, domineering, all the instincts characteristic of the highest and best-

turned-out type of 'man' into unsureness, agony of conscience, self-destruction. Indeed, invert all love of the earthly and of dominion over the earth into hatred of the earth and the earthly. That is the task the church posed for itself and had to pose, until in its estimation, 'becoming unworldly,' 'unsensual,' and 'higher men' were fused into a single feeling. I mean to say, Christianity has been the most calamitous kind of arrogance yet.

- 3.50** "Men, not hard and high enough to have any right to try to form man as artists; men, not strong and farsighted enough to let the foreground law of thousandfold failure and ruin prevail, though it cost them sublime self-conquest; men, not noble enough to see the abysmally different order of rank, the chasm of rank, between man and man— such men have so far held sway over the fate of Europe, with their 'equal before God,' until finally a smaller, almost ridiculous type, a herd animal, something eager to please, sickly, and mediocre, has been bred, the European of today."
- 3.51** That was the kind of thinking that, in part, motivated the worst of the Nazi aristocrats. That's a very different take than the story I just told you about Jezebel and the widow. Nietzsche had a point that the valorization of slavery, the raising of the oppressed as such, is pathological. But to blame that— it's so strange, because it gives Christianity its due continually—to blame that on the fundamental religious ethos and bedrock of Western civilization was a big mistake.
- 3.52** So that's the first three books of Beyond Good and Evil, and that's some indication of the complexity of Nietzsche's thought. I know it's a terrible, complex morass to make your way through, and his tendrils of his thought go everywhere, and it's full of paradoxes. But when you're trying to deal with monstrous issues, there's plenty of monsters to contend with. I suppose thinking is a form of seeing. And if you see, you don't fall into a pit. And if you know where the pits are, you can avoid them.
- 3.53** Nietzsche was very good at pointing out the deepest possible pits. It's quite the painful sojourn to make your way through them and try to sort out what the hell he was talking about. But you can bite off a little at a time, and you can think about it in some detail, and that will protect you against falling prey to the temptation of second-rate thought. And that's the poisoned apple, by the way, that the evil queen gives Snow White. Pathologized thought. Well, you need an antidote, and Nietzsche makes you think.

## Lecture 4: Character and Conscience

At a glance — Character and conscience, via Oscar Wilde.

- 4.1 Oscar Wilde was a famous Victorian wit. He wrote a book called *Picture of Dorian Gray*, about a man who made a deal with the devil, if I remember correctly, so that his portrait would age because of all his dissolute behavior, but he wouldn't. It's a great book, and he wrote a number of plays. *The Importance of Being Earnest*, I believe, was by Oscar Wilde. He was very good at turning a witty phrase. You know what his dying words were? It's just beyond belief that this could possibly be true. "Either this wallpaper goes, or I do." That was his dying phrase. I don't know how you manage that.
- 4.2 Anyways, why am I talking about Oscar Wilde? Because Nietzsche had that ability in common with great comics, to turn a phrase perfectly, or great poets. And we'll start with Book 4 today, *Epigrams and Interludes, Part Four, of Beyond Good and Evil*.
- 4.3 And these are generally single sentences that Nietzsche crafted, not systematically. They don't weave a coherent narrative. They're more like impressionist approximations circling around a theme, but they're very memorable. That illustrates a very high level of skill, to be able to do that sentence after sentence. And so, we're going to go through a couple of dozen of them to begin, and investigate them and take them apart. And if you have the same response I did over the years, because I've read *Beyond Good and Evil* multiple times, they'll stick with you.
- 4.4 That fact is also interesting: for a phrase to sit in memory, it has to join concepts together that are otherwise not associated. That's what makes it meaningful. It fills a gap in the conceptual space, and it fills it properly. That's what happens when someone coins a word. You know how, all of a sudden, a new word will appear, and it spreads everywhere? It's like, wow, we needed that word. Someone thought it up, and they just nailed it. It's very hard to coin a word that will be widely accepted. You can't force it—propagandists, to the contrary. You have to hit it dead on. Nietzsche was very good at this.
- 4.5 "'I have done that,' says my memory. 'I cannot have done that,' says my pride, and remains inexorable. Eventually, memory yields." So, what's he saying here? Well, we know investigations into memory have revealed—and this is worth knowing, too—that when you bring an autobiographical episode to mind and replay it and consider it, you modify it. Memory is not a record of the past. That's not its purpose. Memory is a record of the past that you can mine for utility in the future. That's what memory is for.
- 4.6 One of the corollaries of that is that, if you have a memory that won't leave you alone, especially, let's say, it's tinged with negative emotion, especially if it plagues you, it recurs. That will happen in recurring dreams, for example. There's a pitfall underneath that memory that the negative emotion systems of your mind are concerned that you will fall into again. Why? Because you didn't map the territory properly. And so, the

alarm systems that protect you, associated with anxiety, keep the memory alive, because maybe you're avoiding contemplating it.

- 4.7 Now, the contemplation isn't an objective account of what happened. The contemplation is an attempt to map the space so that the next time that situation arises, you won't fall into the same hole. So, for example, if you had a history of being bullied as a kid, let's say, and that's still a hot memory, the probability is very high that you haven't investigated what it was that set you up for that with sufficient depth, so that it's no longer a threat.
- 4.8 Now, sometimes that can be simple. Part of the reason people get bullied when they're little is because they're little. And so, it may be that, by the time you're an adult, that problem is solved. Larger kids are more likely to be bullies. Why? Well, obviously, because they're successful when they try it. And smaller kids, comparatively, are more likely to be bullied; that's a situational issue. And it might be just the fact that you're mature now has removed you from the realm of victimization in that manner. But it also may be that there's some things you need to figure out about how to conduct yourself, so that that situation doesn't set itself up around you.
- 4.9 Investigations into bullying—Dan Olweus, a Norwegian psychologist, and a very good one, he showed that bullying behavior is quite stable. It's a manifestation of antisocial personality. But the proclivity to be a bully victim is also quite stable. So, in any case, if that kind of memory is still hot, what that means is that the emotional systems of your brain presume that you're still prone to that pitfall, to that fate.
- 4.10 So, the contemplation of the memory is not so much dwelling, especially involuntarily, on the past. It's sojourning voluntarily into that system of memory to reconstrue your perceptual structure and your strategy, so that you aren't going to be in that situation in the future. And if you do that successfully, the recurrent memory will stop because you've covered the hole. Now, what that means is that memory is modifiable.
- 4.11 I'll tell you a story. I had a client who came to see me once, just once, and she told me a story of being sexually abused when she was very young, four, and she was still afflicted by this. She was in her mid-20s, something like that. And so, she told me the story as she remembered it; and the image I conjured up in my imagination was, it was her brother, her and her brother. I imagined him as 16, 17, something like that, with her at this marked disadvantage, being four.
- 4.12 But then she told me at the end that her brother was seven. And so, I thought, one representation of that sequence of events is that you were victimized at the hands of your predatory brother. That's how it would definitely appear if you were four and it was someone who was seven, because when someone's seven, they're a lot older than a four-year-old. But seven, that's not very old.
- 4.13 So, another story is: you were two very badly supervised children. That's a very different story. It has very different implications, let's say, for the relationship between

yourself as a female and males, in general. It also tells a whole different story about the family dynamic, and maybe a completely different story about the malevolence, or lack thereof, of her brother. Anyways, I only saw her the one time, but it was quite remarkable. She'd never thought that. She'd never thought that. That wasn't how the memory was structured.

**4.14** It was so interesting to me to watch, too, because you'd think that the original memory would be more accurate. It's like, what do you mean accurate, exactly? What does that mean? How do you account for that occurrence? What's the truth?

**4.15** If you're talking to someone in the present, there's ambiguity about the communication. It isn't always obvious exactly what's going on. You might say, well, you have an accurate memory of that. It's like, well, if you don't have an accurate understanding of it, you don't have an accurate memory of it. So, what does that mean about the past? You have a memory of the past. The past is fixed. Is it? Is it fixed? Well, obviously, in some ways, it's immutable. The thing is, the past lives in a dynamic relationship with the present and the future.

**4.16** And you know this, too. You go to a movie. You're watching the movie, and you think you know what's going on. And then there's a twist in the plot, and everything you thought changes, including your interpretation of what you've already watched. You can see that sometimes, when you're disappointed in a movie, you're really having quite a good time through the whole movie, and there's a lot of balls in the air, and you're thinking, "Man, I hope the director, the writer, lands this," and they don't. So, the end of the movie is unsatisfying. And when you walk away, you're not happy with the experience; and yet, if someone would have asked you during the movie, right up to the end, which was unsatisfactory, you might have been perfectly content to be there watching.

**4.17** So, why am I telling you all this? Well, Nietzsche packs that into this sentence. But more, "'I have done that,' says my memory. 'I cannot have done that,' says my pride, and remains inexorable. Eventually, memory yields." What's he saying? Your stubborn, self-serving, delusional presumptions about yourself can be so tyrannical that you'll even falsify your own past to support your folly. Right.

**4.18** One of the things that's very useful to do, if you're plagued by reminiscences, which is how Freud described his personality disordered clients, if you're plagued by reminiscences, the first thing you might assume is, you don't know what the hell happened. You think you know because you have a memory. It's like, you wouldn't be plagued by it if you knew what happened. Right. This is extremely useful to know. There's good experimental data on this.

**4.19** One of the things you can do with people who are traumatized, trauma comes in gradations. Minor trauma would be a recurrent negative memory, one that won't leave

you alone. If you investigate that by writing, you can resolve it. And the resolution is actually the restoration of accuracy to the memory.

- 4.20** Now, accuracy is a weird thing, and this is in keeping with Nietzsche's other observations—that there might be a utility in fiction that's akin to the truth that has little to do with objective facts. What's an accurate memory? That's a complicated question. I think that you're bound, in a sense, to realize that an accurate memory is one that serves to represent the past in a manner that best guides you into the future. That's a very different idea than the objective record.
- 4.21** The problem with the objective record is the same problem that you have when you're writing history: where do you stop telling the story? When have you got a complete account? Our real answer to that is: when the story makes sense. Now, that's really how we run trials. The prosecution tells a story, the defense tells a story, the jury decides which story seems to be more compelling. Are the stories complete? No representation of anything is ever complete. That means it's partial, it has a perspective.
- 4.22** And then you might say, if every occurrence is susceptible to a multitude of perspectives, which is the case—that's a postmodern claim—then there's no truth. It's like, let's not jump to that conclusion so rapidly. It just might be that what constitutes truth is not exactly what we presume. It's not a thorough, objective account, but it could be something more like—and Nietzsche tries to make this point: truth should serve life. Well, what does that mean? Your memory should serve your navigation. That's a very different idea of truth.
- 4.23** That doesn't mean that there's no idea of truth in it. Even the notion of truth, there's various notions of truth. There's true as in an objective record. There's true as in the arrow flies true to the target. It's on target; that makes it true. The heart is true. That means loyal. And those are truth that has much more to do with an unerring eye and proper navigation.
- 4.24** That can make itself manifest in a pathological manner, too. You can bend and twist your own biography to serve your own narrow, herd-like, prideful, hedonistic, nihilistic purposes. Now, I think the consequence of that will be that you'll be plagued by reminiscences, and that's such an interesting thing. There's a kickback that's part of the moral orientation that's deeply embedded within you. If you falsify your own biography, your memories will plague you. Why? Because your deepest instincts or your highest calling, they enforce the requirement of a true flight on you. Right.
- 4.25** This is partly why Elijah, in the Old Testament, Cardinal Newman identified conscience with the divine. There are orienting mechanisms that help you navigate—that's what your emotions are, by the way. Positive emotion indicates the pathway forward; negative emotion indicates deviation from the proper path. Plagued by your own

emotions, being plagued by your own emotions is an indication of deviation from the true flight. Next.

- 4.26 "The degree and kind of a man's sexuality reach up into the ultimate pinnacle of his spirit." That's a hell of a thing for the hedonists to hear. What does he mean by that? Really, in part, what he means is, there's no such thing as sexuality. There's no such thing as sexual identity. There's no extracting out the sexual motivation, which would be sexual perception, emotions associated with sex, behavioral proclivities, the philosophy of the drive, all of that. There's no separating that from the— what would you say? From the other fundamental motivational systems, or from whatever it is that integrates those, if anything, at the highest level.
- 4.27 I'll give you an example. I had a friend who was Swedish, lived in northern Alberta. He got married to a Swedish-Canadian woman. They were second- or third-generation immigrants. They weren't really Swedish, but they decided to go get married in Sweden, and so they did. During the ceremony, it was a Christian marriage ceremony—a marriage ceremony is an attempt to unite the sexual under the rubric of the sacred. It's more than that, but that's part of what it is. So how was that dramatized in this ceremony?
- 4.28 The couple held a candle aloft between them during the ceremony. So, now you've got to think symbolically about that. The Scandinavians, the Germans, at Christmas, they put candles on a Christmas tree—the tree is the tree of life, and light at Christmas is the light, the sun, returning in the darkness. It's a symbol of illumination. Illumination is a symbol of, it can be a symbol of the intellect gone mad. That's Lucifer, who's the light-bringer. But it can be a symbol of genuine enlightenment, light, or illumination, light.
- 4.29 There's an association between light and higher consciousness. Why? Because we're not nocturnal. We're awake and conscious during the day, so the sun and light is associated with consciousness for human beings, because we are awake during the day, but also because we're extremely visual. Human beings are like the most visual animal, with the possible exception of birds of prey. Our brain is organized around the visual system.
- 4.30 So, to hold the candle aloft is to hold the spirit of illumination superordinate to the couple. So, what it means is that—and then the candle itself, in this ceremonial procedure, was associated with Christ. So, what's the idea? The idea is that the couple is united by the spirit of illumination and logos— that's the word, logos. Dialogue is what keeps a relationship alive. Dialogue towards what end? To serve the marriage. How do you best serve the marriage? By both serving the spirit of illumination in the darkness. That's a good way of thinking about it.
- 4.31 So, there is no power struggle there. It's not that the man is in charge; it's not that the woman is in charge. What it is is that the spirit of illumination is in charge, and both of the participants in the marriage are properly and voluntarily subordinated to that.

That's one example of how sexuality could reach up into the ultimate pinnacle of the spirit.

- 4.32** So, why is it sacralized then? Because what could otherwise be a base instinct—so what does base mean? A base metal is a metal—this is an alchemical notion—a base metal is a metal that will combine indiscriminately with other metals. So, there's a sexual metaphor in the idea of base metal. Gold is not a base metal. It's a noble metal. And it's noble because gold, which is pure, will not mate indiscriminately with anything else, which is also partly why gold is a symbol of value. It can't be tarnished. There's nothing impure about it.
- 4.33** And so, the organization of the sexual impulse, which is more like a personality, in keeping with Nietzsche's formulation—this is a very useful thing to understand, is that your motivation states, they're subpersonalities. Look the hell out for their machinations. They're sacralized by being integrated into a superordinate structure with the proper unity at the pinnacle. Now, one of the things that implies—this is in keeping with Nietzsche's proclamation and thought— is that, if that higher-order unity disappears, God dies—then, the major motivational subpersonalities that are next down the hierarchy, they start to clamor for dominance.
- 4.34** That's basically—Nietzsche never put it exactly that way, but that's a perfect illustration of what he intuited. When that higher-order unity, which might be the striving for illumination, when it collapses, when faith in that collapses, something else is going to emerge to strive for dominance. The hyper-expression of individualized sexuality in our culture is a very good indication of that.
- 4.35** The early psychoanalysts, particularly Freud and Alfred Adler—it was Freud, Adler, and Jung—Freud and Adler each identified a different primordial motivation as superordinate, in keeping with this notion that Nietzsche had laid out about the collapse of the upper unity. Adler believed that people were essentially motivated, like Nietzsche believed, by something like the drive to power. And he felt that human beings—he was kind of bullied as a kid, whereas Freud was like his mother's favorite.
- 4.36** Adler felt that human beings were always trying to overcome a sense of inferiority, and working to elevate their status and power as their primary motivation. It's a perfectly reasonable observation, although it doesn't mean that that's the only pathway for it. Whereas Freud really identified the pleasure principle, and he associated that with sex. What would you expect for primordial motivations? You're going to clamor for status, or you're going to pursue your own hedonistic gratification. Those are both hallmarks, I would say, of a disunited immaturity. But you can also think about them as the reemergence of pagan gods. That's another way of thinking about it, because Ares, for example, or Mars, is the god of war, aggression, power, and Eros, Cupid, is Venus. That's the god or goddess of erotic attraction and pleasure.

- 4.37 When the higher-order unity collapses, and you can see that in—imagine this marriage that I described. If the marriage collapses, if the joint search of the couple for enlightened unity collapses, what's it going to collapse into? Not a complete bloody random chaos, although that can happen. You go into a house like that, and everything's just in absolute disarray. No decisions are made about anything. It's just a mess, so that can happen.
- 4.38 But it's equally likely that one person will become a slave, and the other person will become a tyrant, or both of the couples will be obsessed with pursuing their own. You see this with the rise of idiocy like polyamory. Each of the participants will become obsessed with pursuing their own selfish interests. And that usually degenerates into something like possession by some short-term hedonistic whim, under the guise of self-expression. "I want to do my own thing." What does that mean? Who's the "I" that we're talking about here?
- 4.39 That's a Nietzschean question, too. "I want to do my own thing." Oh, really? Or is it that something within you wants to possess you for its purposes? Which of those is the most accurate statement? Well, if every drive philosophizes in its spirit, when a base motivation attempts to attain primacy, it's going to possess you and come complete with its own set of perceptions and arguments. It's like, that's what you want. How exactly are you defining "you" here?
- 4.40 You see this in our culture with this reflexive notion that seems to possess so many people in the population, especially on the postmodern side, that all games are power games. It's like, if you believe that, I want to have nothing to do with you. Or that fundamental identity is associated, let's say, with something approximating sexual desire. Have it your way.
- 4.41 "The degree and kind of a man's sexuality reach up into the ultimate pinnacle of his spirit." Well, Nietzsche is grappling towards some notion of a uniting principle. He thought it was will to power. That's not right.
- 4.42 "Under peaceful conditions, a warlike man sets upon himself." In the story of Abraham, Abraham establishes the Abrahamic covenant with God, and so Abraham is the father of Judaism, Christianity, and Islam, in principle, the Abrahamic religions. So it's a major league story, the Abrahamic story. God makes himself manifest to Abraham in a very particular way. This is a definition of the divine, by the way. It's not some proclamation of superstitious faith. It's an attempt to understand something.
- 4.43 Abraham, when the story starts, Abraham is a privileged person. He doesn't have to lift a finger. He has rich parents, and everything is done for him, and has been done for him, his whole life, until he's like 70. And then a voice comes to him, an impulse, that offers him a contract. And it says to him, "You have to leave your zone of comfort and sojourn out into the terrible world. Have your adventure." So, God is the voice of adventure in the story of Abraham.

- 4.44 And then God offers—the voice of adventure offers Abraham a deal. He says, "If you do this and you make the proper sacrifices along the way—so you offer up to the spirit of adventure, you dispense with your foolishness, which is a form of sacrifice in the pursuit—you'll be a blessing to yourself; your reputation will grow validly among your people; you'll establish something of permanence that will cascade down the generations; your enemies will not be able to stand in front of you; and you'll do it in a way that brings nothing but benefit to everyone else." So, that's a hell of an offer, that's for sure.
- 4.45 It's so cool because it aligns that instinct to move beyond with the process that brings all those benefits and shows a concordance, let's say, between the psychological, the social, and the divine. Imagine that the impulse that moves you out into the world and impels you to develop is the same impulse that brings maximal harmony to the psyche and maximal abundance to society.
- 4.46 Well, it has to be that way if we're actually social animals, because otherwise our developmental impulse would be at odds with society. Why would we assume that? We wouldn't be social animals if that was the case. We'd be self-serving psychopaths who use the social world as a manipulative enterprise. That happens, but that's a deviation, not a central tendency.
- 4.47 "Under peaceful conditions, a warlike man sets upon himself." The divine in the Abrahamic narrative is defined as the call to adventure. Along the way, Abraham has to become a warrior. That's one of the things that—he has to go to war. Now, do you go to war? It depends on how you define war. Is there going to be conflict in your life? Well, unless you avoid all of it, in which case there'll just be conflict forestalled. Will that actually mean war in the classical manner? Armies against armies, let's say? Not necessarily, although often.
- 4.48 Does that mean there's no need for war? There's always a need for war if things aren't set right. Maybe it's a war with yourself, it's a war with your wife, it's a war with your family, it's a war with your town. Who the hell knows? Part of that instinct that is aligned with the call to adventure is that requirement for the adventure of, let's say, war. Well, if it doesn't find its own—if it doesn't find its proper manifestation, its proper place, like sexuality, let's say, it's going to get inverted and turned towards you. And so, that's Nietzsche's point there. Find the right war.
- 4.49 What's his name? William James, who founded modern psychology, experimental psychology—I used to work in the building named after him at Harvard, because he was a Harvard professor—he delved deep into the religious substructure of the psyche and was very concerned about the human proclivity for social conflict, for war. And he said—this is a brilliant phrase—"We all need a moral equivalent to war." That was his substitute for war. It wasn't that you should be peaceful or castrated, for that matter, not aggressive, as if that's a solution to conflict. His solution was that you need to find how to harness that warlike proclivity for the good.

- 4.50 What are the consequences of not doing that? "Under peaceful conditions, a warlike man sets upon himself." You might think: Why am I at odds with myself, and isn't that a terrible thing? I don't know. All those contradictory impulses within you that are tormenting you, pulling you in different directions, they might be prodding you into some form of committed integration.
- 4.51 This is in keeping with Nietzsche's insistence that you shouldn't be seeking security or ease. Maybe you should be seeking how about optimized difficulty? That's a whole different way of looking at the world. That's what you hope for your children. You don't hope they hide in the basement away from everything dangerous. You hope they sojourn out into the world and find maximally optimized challenge, something like that, if you have any sense.
- 4.52 "Whoever despises himself still respects himself as someone who despises." There's a phrase for you. Imagine that you, I don't know, you go out, you drink too much, and you do something fun but foolish. And so, the next day, you berate yourself. All of that account is incoherent. You berate yourself. What the hell does that mean? And who is the "you" that was there the night before? And who's the "you" that's now calling you out on your behavior the next day? And what makes you think that those are both you, since they have diametrically opposed viewpoints? And how is it that, if that juxtaposition of diametrically opposed viewpoints exists within you, that that's all you? Because generally, we assume that one thing and its opposite aren't the same thing.
- 4.53 So what's his point here? The fact that you can violate your conscience indicates—what does it indicate? That there's a part of you that impels you towards the violation, and another part—a higher part?—that calls you on it. Then you might ask yourself: Which is the real you?
- 4.54 When I was about 22, something like that, that was when I decided I was going to look as deeply into the problem of social conflict, war, and atrocity, as deeply as I could—I swore I would do that. And what happened to me? The first thing that happened to me, it was so interesting, is that I started to listen to myself talk. I don't know if people actually listen to themselves talk, like you listen to someone else. You just assume that, when you're talking, it's you talking, and you're saying what you mean, and you know what you mean, and you know who you are. None of that's true.
- 4.55 And then I got this voice; this voice in my head was quite disruptive. After virtually everything I said, it said, "That's not true, and you don't mean that." And then I was in a real conundrum because I was saying things, and that was me, but then there was this voice in my head that was saying, "None of that's true." But it wasn't none of it. That was the other thing. Now and then, I would say something the voice didn't object to, but that was like 5% of the time.
- 4.56 And then I came to understand—and this took quite a while—what I started to do was experiment with watching my speech carefully and finding the words that that voice

wouldn't object to. That was the establishment of a relationship with my conscience, which was something I didn't understand until later. It was very destabilizing, because it probably criticized 95% of what I said. That's a lot. It's like, huh, 95%, eh? Now, why? I was verbally facile, and I liked to win arguments. Well, it's a misuse of your verbal facility to win arguments. First of all, just because you win an argument doesn't mean you're right.

**4.57** This is something to remember when you're married. One of the things you might want to do, if you're more verbally facile than your husband or your wife is, you might want to help them win an argument from time to time, just on the off chance that the mere fact that you can formulate an argument better doesn't mean that you're right. And if you win all the time, then they lose all the time, and that's not a very wise thing to do in a marriage.

**4.58** And so, if the verbal facility, let's say the intellect, shouldn't serve victory, what should it serve? I was using it to serve victory. I liked to win arguments. I dispensed with that by the time I was about 24. I stopped arguing. I stopped trying to win arguments. Now and then, I'd lapse into it. It's unbearably dull. And it's not a dialogue. It's not logos. That's different. That's the pursuit of the truth, and you can do that with yourself. I learned to feel my words like they were—that's one account of Moses finding his way across the Red Sea, finding firm ground under his feet, the Red Sea of blood and chaos.

**4.59** "Whoever despises himself still respects himself as one who despises." Then you start to decide who you're going to identify with. Are you going to identify with the part of you that transgresses against your conscience, or are you going to identify with the part of you that calls you out on your misbehavior? And which one of those is you? And which one of them is the "you" you want to form an alliance with?

**4.60** Remember, in the Pinocchio movie—it's very sophisticated, that narrative account—the puppet, who's a marionette, played by forces behind the scenes, establishes an alliance with the conscience, who's a tramp. He's kind of a generic tramp, and he's the voice that bugs you, which is why he's a cricket. He's an insect. He bugs you, gets under your skin. And Jiminy Cricket isn't a very—who's JC, by the way; that's Jesus Christ, because that was Southern US slang for Jesus Christ—he's not a very good conscience to begin with. He's kind of generic. He spouts slogans, and Pinocchio can't listen to him.

**4.61** Because the conscience, until a relationship is developed with it, might spout platitudes and finger-wag. But if a relationship is established with it, it grows in sophistication. And that's part of what the religious types, the truly religious types, characterized as a relationship with the transcendent or with God. I'm not making this up. One of the mainstreams of Catholic doctrine, for example, is that God makes himself manifest in the voice of the conscience. This is a definition. Come up with your own bloody theory if you don't like that one.

- 4.62 What is it that calls you out on your own misbehavior? And why would you think that's you? Because what you'd hope for or think, if it was just you, you'd take your conscience, and you'd give it a good throttling and say, "I'm going to do whatever the hell I want. Make my own values, let's say. I'm going to do whatever I want, and why should I torture myself about it?" And if it's you, why can't you control that? You can try. And we know this. We know this, too, because we know perfectly.
- 4.63 We define "psychopath," which is a very dangerous category, as someone who either doesn't have a conscience or does not attend to it. And so, there's no pussy-footing around this. The worst kind of criminal has no conscience. What does that mean? What is conscience? What the hell is that? It's the thing that despises. And why do you respect yourself? Because you know there's more to you. You wouldn't be ashamed in your own sight, if you didn't know, whatever that means, that there's a better part of you than you made manifest. And so, what is that?
- 4.64 See, the psychoanalysts, after Nietzsche pronounced that God was dead, and the psychoanalysts started to understand that those things that had once been construed as deities had slipped into the unconscious, so to speak, they started to understand that we were pulled this way and that by all sorts of devils and angels. And that made the Nietzschean vision of creating our own values highly improbable. It's like, are you master in your own house? And if you're not, just exactly what's in there? Well, that'll keep you busy, figuring that out for the rest of your life.
- 4.65 "Pity for all." This is a brilliant phrase. "'Pity for all' would be hardness and tyranny toward you, my dear neighbor!" Right. There's a phrase that describes the Soviet catastrophe. Now, Nietzsche knew, like Dostoevsky, especially in the book *The Devils*, or *The Demons*, Dostoevsky laid out in *The Demons* exactly what was going to happen in the Soviet Union 50 years later. And Dostoevsky and Nietzsche's thought parallel uncannily.
- 4.66 Why would pity for all be hardness and tyranny toward you? Well, what's all, exactly? Well, all is everyone. I see. So everyone is always prioritized over you. Who defines all? That's the first question. At what point does the general well-being of everyone supersede your right to address your own pain in some selfish manner? Well, it depends on how hard you pursue the for-all notion. It's like, why should there be anything for you? There's one of you. There's eight billion other people. Do you ever take priority, if it's a pity for all?
- 4.67 "Property is theft." That's a famous radical leftist statement. Why? Well, why should you have something that everyone else doesn't have, ever? What's the pity based on? Observation of what—unequal distribution? Unfair unequal distribution? What do you mean, equal distribution? And over what realm of possession or phenomenon? Is it generally the case, if property is theft, for example? And so, you have pity for those who don't have, because that's a corollary of the notion of "property is theft." Is my compassion for those who don't have everything you have always to take priority over

everything you have? And is it not the case then that no one ever gets anything under those circumstances? Because here's a rule: if no one can have anything that everyone else doesn't have, no one gets to have anything.

- 4.68 Then you might ask, too, what does "have" mean? It means you have it, and someone else doesn't. That's what "have" means. And you can say, "Property is theft," and you can do that from this perspective of compassion. We know what the consequence of that is because it's been tried in a dozen situations. As soon as you collectivize, everyone dies. So, "'Pity for all' would be hardness and tyranny toward you, my dear neighbor!" There's a warning.
- 4.69 Nietzsche knew this. He knew. He said, in *The Will to Power*, another book, that he believed that, in the 20th century, millions of people would die in consequence of that experiment. Dostoevsky saw the same thing. They could see the evil seeds that had already been planted and knew that this was inevitable. In fact, Nietzsche actually said that maybe the death of tens of millions in the 20th century would be a price worth paying for putting that dreadful delusion to rest. Now, the problem is, we paid the price, but we certainly haven't put the dreadful delusion to rest. And it's justified by a call to compassion. What about those who don't have?
- 4.70 There's another—imagine the alternative. Rich people get things first. That's kind of the definition of being rich. In our society, that's a very weird thing because generally what it means is the rich person gets the cell phone five years before you do. And then you can see what happens is, first of all, it's spectacularly expensive, so only the rich can afford it, which is exactly what you'd expect for something new that isn't everywhere yet. So, the rich buy it at some terribly inflated price, and then the price falls because there's some demand, and then the kind of rich can afford it, and then the price falls more. In no time flat, you have a 70-inch flat screen TV, like three years later than the billionaire.
- 4.71 What's the alternative? No one gets anything new till everyone has it at once. Oh, yeah, right. How the hell are you going to do that? How could that— it could easily be that the price of abundance is initial unequal distribution, because the alternative would be that the thing has to appear everywhere for everyone at exactly the same time. Well, no one can do that. You could never do that, not even in principle. It has to come out initially somewhere first. That means someone's going to be privileged, so to speak.
- 4.72 What do you do in a meritorious society? Well, you try to parcel out first-access privilege on the basis of something like productivity, and you index that with money. Maybe you don't like that. And obviously, there's some measurement flaws in the system. It's like, don't be replacing that with pity, because the consequence of that is, no one has everything, and everyone dies, and that's not good. "'Pity for all' would be hardness and tyranny toward you, my dear neighbor!" There is something to remember.

- 4.73 "Terrible experiences pose the riddle whether the person who has them is not terrible." Nietzsche says later, and I think I have this in the Epigrams, that you should beware of gazing into an abyss, because when you do that, the abyss gazes into you. "Terrible experiences pose the riddle whether the person who has them is not terrible."
- 4.74 Hell, there's a better question than that even, that emerges as a consequence of this statement. Maybe the reason you face terrible experiences is so that you can become terrible. Why do you need to become terrible? Terrible means "capable of inducing terror." Well, that's how you say no. You can't negotiate unless you can say no. So, you should negotiate carefully, and you should say no carefully. But no should mean, "There's nothing you can do that will make me do this," and you're not going to do that without being terrible, that's for sure, because you have to be intransigent, immobile.
- 4.75 Now, you can imagine that that could go wrong, and you could make a mistake, but it's a capacity you might want to develop. If someone can push you harder than you've ever pushed yourself, they can probably push you around. So, what happens if you've pushed yourself to the limit? Well, you know what the limit is, and you know what you mean when you say no, because you mean, "There's nothing you can do that will make me do this." Right. Do you need that terrible experience? The alternative is that you can be manipulated by your own fear. Does that make you terrible if you have faced that? Definitely. Can that be used properly?
- 4.76 Part of the reason that people are so attracted to Mafia movies, for example, they have this Nietzschean suspicion that much morality is just cowardice. And so, they see these antihero types. The Mafia guys in American and British movies are very good examples of that. There's something admirable about them. Why? Because they mean "no." That's part of it. And they'll circumvent herd morality to pursue their ends. Why would you find that fascinating? Well, in the story of The Hobbit, the hobbit as a thief is a better hobbit than the hobbit as an ordinary person. Why? It's partly because he started to become terrible.
- 4.77 Do you need to be terrible? Life is pretty terrible. You have to be able to say no. Do you have to face what's terrible? It's coming your way. You might as well face it at your own time and of a place of your own choosing and get prepared. Does that make you terrible? It's a funny thing, because you're terrible if you don't do that, too, because you avoid and you're evasive and you're weak and you're easily swayed and you fall prey to the delusions of the herd. And that's all a form of terrible, too. It's just not as forthright. And so, Nietzsche's perspective would be, you should be terrible. And then you should control it.
- 4.78 "A man's maturity," this is great, "consists in having found again the seriousness one had as a child, at play." Oh, that's so smart. It really took me, like, 40 years to really figure that out, because I only figured out in the last couple of years that the antithesis of tyranny and slavery is play. There's a play circuit in mammals; I told you that the

other day. Play is a relatively fragile, motivational state. It can be disrupted by other motivational states, but play only occurs when everything is in harmonious balance.

**4.79** So, you think about the walled garden. That's paradise, pairidaeza, "a walled garden." A walled garden is a place that has boundaries and natural abundance, and that's a place of eternal play. If you set up your household properly, your children can play. They play on the edge, seeking adventure. If you set up your relationship properly, you relate in the spirit of play. Then you can tell that it's done well. This is why Christ tells his followers that, unless they become, not stay, become like little children, they cannot enter the Kingdom of Heaven.

**4.80** Play. Well, what does play mean? It's voluntary. That's the first thing. When one little kid asks another little kid to play, they both have to agree. There's no tyranny, there's no force; it has to be voluntary. Play also means there's some leeway in the system. You're trying to find the pathway, which, for children, would be the continuation of the game. And you can—there's movement. Like in a dance, there's movement around that central tendency that makes it playful.

**4.81** You see that when people are playing music, especially if they're good at improvising, because they'll take a central melody, which has a start point and an end point, and they'll play around it. And then you dance to it, or you enjoy it because you like that sense of play. And so, that's very smart. "A man's maturity consists in having found again the seriousness one had as a child, at play."

**4.82** Here's a rule of thumb: If what you're doing isn't play, you're doing it wrong. Now, that's a hard thing to manage because you have to do hard things in life. And so, you might think, well, how do you transform that into play? The answer to that is: that's your problem. But it doesn't take away from the central— what?—axiom or the central presumption. It doesn't mean it's easy. It's extremely difficult, especially when you're doing difficult things. How do you have a sense of play when you're doing demanding and serious things?

**4.83** I saw that—I had a lot of working-class jobs, and I liked them. Not always. I liked them quite a lot. I worked in restaurants for a long time. I did a lot of different things when I was a kid. One of the things that I really liked about working-class jobs—I never really found this in higher echelon, more intellectual jobs—was that the working men had a tremendous sense of wit and play. And so, they were often doing terribly difficult things — dirty, physically demanding, dangerous jobs, or low-status jobs, let's say.

**4.84** But that camaraderie, that harsh camaraderie often that would emerge—this is something obviously that characterizes military enterprises—puts that sense of play into the toil. They say in the military— and I don't have any military experience—that you fight for the guy next to you. It's in the context of national service, let's say, in patriotism. But in the final analysis, you form a bond that has that element of play, and that's the thing that's most particularly worth fighting for.

- 4.85 So, this is a very good thing to understand. I think it's particularly useful in a marriage. If you're not playing, you haven't cleared out the impediments to play; that's the first thing to understand. It's not easy to get there. There's going to be a lot of thorns and thistles, pricks, the pricks that we kick against, in the way. But if that spirit of play doesn't emerge, especially when you're hypothetically relating to someone you love, there are many things you haven't taken account of, and you have to sort them through, or avoid them, or pretend they don't exist. But if you sort them through, then that sense of play can emerge. And then, there isn't anything better than that. And so, this is a good thing to know, right? No matter what your task is, if you're not doing it playfully, you're not doing it optimally.
- 4.86 "What? A great man? I always see only the actor of his own ideal." That's actually a bit of a hint with relationship to his earlier discussion of self-contempt. So, who are you? Are you who you are? Or are you who you could be? Now, this is a hard question. It's a very hard question.
- 4.87 The phenomenologists, the philosophers, Heidegger, for example, Husserl, believed that we always lived with a pitch towards the future, like the destination, the future was always embedded in our conception of the present. And so, the idea, the separation between who you are and who you're striving to be, is in some ways illusory, because whatever you're doing, there's a direction or an intention towards where you could be and who you could be.
- 4.88 That's how you conceptualize the world. You're here, but you're heading somewhere. You're heading somewhere with your eyes. You're heading somewhere with your attention. You're heading somewhere with your intention. And so, that means that the future you is present. That's a good way of thinking about it. It's present in the voice of your conscience. That's another way of thinking about it, and a very useful way of thinking about it.
- 4.89 When you're dealing with children, here's a rough stereotype of sex roles in relationship to children. The mother's on the side of who the child is, and the father's on the side of who the child could be. Now, I know the roles switch, and they should, but that's not a bad rule of thumb. And it's perfectly appropriate because you want to provide your children with some support for who they are. But you want to say, "Get the hell at it." That's the encouragement. And so, then what you're doing really is, you're relating to the child as if they are their future potential self, and that's more real.
- 4.90 People do this innately. People who've studied how children learn language, which is quite the mystery, noted that adults automatically speak to children at a level that slightly exceeds their current level of comprehension. They don't even know they're doing it. It's part of the language, you could say, the language instinct. Well, you do that with people you love. You do that with yourself. You play on the leading edge of the game. You should be serving who you could be. Now, you have to take stock of who you are as well, but—

- 4.91 So, what's Nietzsche's point? "A great man? I always see only the actor of his own ideal." That's such an interesting thing to note. I'll tell you a story from Exodus. Moses, before he becomes a leader. He's a shepherd. I explained the shepherd idea to you? Yes. It's a symbol of normative ideal masculinity. So, Moses has established himself as a shepherd. He can keep the wolves and lions at bay. He can take care of himself. He protects the vulnerable. Good, he's an ordinary good man. That's not nothing.
- 4.92 One day, he's out by Mount Sinai, which is where heaven and earth meet. That's the place of illumination or revelation. And something attracts his attention. That's the burning bush. What's a burning bush? It's a tree, and it's alive, so it's a symbol of life, like the tree of life. And it's burning because living things burn. That's metabolism. And so, when you see someone you love, that's a burning bush, that attraction.
- 4.93 Here's a way of thinking about it that's probably the case. The only—this is assuming you're not deluded—the only people you actually see are people you love. Everyone else is a figment of your presumptions. And so, love strips presumption from perception. And so, that's a burning bush. That's what psychedelics do. They strip memory from perception. That's a burning bush. Now, Moses decides to walk off the beaten path and investigate what calls to him. Now, that's worth thinking about.
- 4.94 So, he's just having an ordinary life. Good for him. At least he's established that. He's managed the ordinary. That's not nothing. Something beckons to him. Well, you can watch in your own life, what beckons to you? What compels you? What calls to you? What grips you? That's outside of you. That's a way of thinking about it. You can't pick what interests you; it picks you. Now, it picks you in relationship to your aim. That's a good way of thinking about it.
- 4.95 What will make itself manifest to you as what grips your interest is a pathway forward defined by your aim, even if you don't know what your aim is, because that's how your perceptual systems work, like they're navigation systems. And so, if something calls to you, that's a consequence of a decision you've made about your aim, even if you don't know what that decision was, even if you don't know what your aim is. So, then you might say, well, what should your aim be? This is relevant to Nietzsche's epigram.
- 4.96 Imagine that you're having a discussion with your husband, your wife, your boyfriend. The discussion is about something, so it's aimed at something. Well, what is it aimed at? You want to make your point; you want to win. Do you? What if you're wrong? What if you win all the time? Do you want your partner to be a loser? I don't know if victory is exactly the right aim. What would the aim be? How about the best possible aim? What would that be? Well, that's your problem.
- 4.97 And you could say—you could think about that, you could meditate on that: If I was going to handle this situation, whatever it is, the best possible way, hypothetically, what would that look like? And then you can fantasize a bit about that. Maybe you walk away from your discussion, so that your problem is solved, so that your partner's

problem is solved, so that you've jointly solved it in a way that would be better than either of you would have managed alone, in a way that would iterate properly into the future and improve things, and so that you remember that you love each other. Maybe you can come up with a better formulation than that. It's like, good, go ahead. But you get my point. Why not aim up? You're going to be aiming at something, or something inside you is going to be aiming at something.

**4.98** So, what makes you great? When Moses investigates the burning bush, he concentrates on it. He understands that he's starting to tread on sacred ground. What does that mean? If you gaze deeply into something, you will start to tread on sacred ground. What does it mean? Well, when you study something, you get deeper into it. What does deeper mean? It means behind the surface.

**4.99** And so, as you get deeper into something, by definition, you start to tread on sacred ground, because deep and sacred are the same thing. If you pay attention to someone enough, they will tell you what they're up to, even if they don't know. If you don't understand someone, especially someone close to you, you have not been listening. If you listen, they'll reveal their hand, even as a shock to them.

**4.100** You can tell if you're listening, because it's frightening; that's part of it. But it's also insanely interesting, because if you listen, people will reveal themselves beyond their persona, and you'll see that they're way different than you thought, way different, and that you had no idea what was going on behind the scenes. And if you listen to them, which is to attend, to attend, they won't be able to get enough of you, because they need to reveal themselves, even to themselves.

**4.101** "What? A great man? I always see only the actor of his own ideal." So you might say, well, is there any greatness within you that could be unlocked? What are you aiming at? Here's a rule. This will change your life if you understand it. The spirit of your aim answers your prayers. And this is true. I don't mean necessarily anything metaphysical by it. What does it mean?

**4.102** When you look at the world, you look at where you're going. What do you see when you look at where you're going? You see how to get there. Otherwise, you wouldn't be able to get there. So, you see the pathway, you see the obstacles, you see the affordances forward. You see people help, you'll see people hinder. You might see things that will change your mind. That's what you see.

**4.103** Let's think about this abstractly. When you're contemplating, you're building a fictional representation of your aim in the world. What would happen if you aimed at the highest good? Then you'd see the pathway forward. Where's the pathway to greatness? Well, what's greatness other than service to the highest good?

**4.104** And so, you might think, there's nothing great about what I'm doing, which would mean, as well, there's nothing meaningful, because meaningful and great, they're the same thing. It's like, maybe your aim isn't high enough. And you can tell. If your life is

devoid of meaning, your aim is inaccurate. That's just a truism, because the meaning comes in the value of the aim and the specification of the pathway forward. And so, what do you do to imbue your life with meaning? Ramp up the elevation of your aim.

- 4.105** Now, you have to be careful because you can have an aim that's so elevated that you're crushed by the responsibility. You kind of have to calibrate that. And then you might also say: Why do people settle for a meaningless life? And they complain about it. "My life has no meaning." Maybe you don't want the responsibility. But then you could ask yourself, are you sure you don't want the responsibility? There's no difference between responsibility and meaning. They're the same thing, so maybe you want all the responsibility.
- 4.106** Remember Christ, who's the archetypal savior, is the person who takes the sins of the world onto himself. What does that mean? Dostoevsky says this. "Every man is responsible not only for what he does, but for what everyone else does as well." That's, of course, an insane thing to say. That's a mystically insane thing to say, but it means something. You have no idea how much better people around you would be if you were better. You have no idea. You have no idea how pathologized your misaligned aim renders everything you touch. So, a great man? If you're serving a sufficiently elevated aim genuinely, and you become the actor of that ideal, that's the definition of great. That's his point.
- 4.107** This is funny. This is a great one. Woody Allen made this joke. I think a Marx brother, Groucho Marx, made the same joke. "I wouldn't be the member of a club that would take me. I wouldn't join a club that would take me as a member." That's a very good joke. But as far as I could tell, that sentiment originated with Nietzsche when he was talking about love.
- 4.108** "Discovering that one is loved in return really ought to disenchant the lover with the beloved. 'What? This person is modest enough to love even you? Or stupid enough? Or —'" It's a joke. It's a good joke, too. It's a good joke, too. And I think it's actually often true. If you really idealize someone, which is a dangerous thing to do, and they generally don't appreciate that that much, because it makes you into a fool around them, if you idealize them, and then they betray you by accepting you, then they've violated the ideal and broken the contract. It's a very tricky thing to negotiate.
- 4.109** "Once the decision has been made, close your ear even to the best counterargument; sign of a strong character. Thus an occasional will to stupidity." This is a tough thing to get right. I thought about this a lot in relationship to how you set up a household with kids, because it's something like this. There's a way of negotiating this. Minimal necessary rules. That's the first thing. But enforced, enforced. And enforcement has a cost. It takes energy. It takes time. It takes intervention. So, Christ said this, too. Don't multiply the rules lest you be trapped within the structure that you build.

- 4.110 But there's utility and commitment. And so, you want to choose the principles upon which you found your life carefully and abide by them, and that's part of character. That's part of commitment. And that does run contrary in a way to that notion that continual flexibility and readjustment is admirable. It's like, not always. Not always. This is partly the continual dialogue between conservatives and, let's say, entrepreneurs or more creative types.
- 4.111 Sometimes you should just stick to what the hell is going on. In fact, if it's working, you mess with it at your peril. Could it be better? Maybe. Making something that works better is very hard. Has it run into a rut? That happens. So, there's never a place where only traditionalism works. There's always a dialogue between the traditionalist and the revolutionary. Revolutions come at a cost. Sometimes they're necessary. How do you decide when? That's what free speech is for. That's what free speech is for. That's how you negotiate that.
- 4.112 Should we stick with what we're doing, or should we do something new? Well, we don't know. Why not? Because the situation hasn't been encountered before. What should be the rule of thumb? If you can do what everyone else has always done, do that. If that isn't working, maybe it's time for a new idea, carefully, and let's think it through. But it has to be dialogue.
- 4.113 This is why the right to free speech is not some right that you have. It's not a right. It's the process by which the negotiation of the future takes place. So, when it goes, everything goes. There's no difference between free speech and thought. There's no difference between thought and simulation. You have to be able to say what you believe to be the case. You're going to be wrong, obviously, lots.
- 4.114 "Once the decision has been made, close your ear, even to the best counterargument." I dealt with this pragmatically as a clinician. One of the things I had my clients do—this is a very useful thing— was make a plan, like a five-year plan. Don't fall in love with the damn thing, because what do you know? I made a program to do this, called the Future Authoring Program. It's a very useful thing for people to do. It's kind of a negotiation process that you undertake with yourself: five years down the road, you get to have what you need and want. That's the deal. But you have to specify it. How do you specify it? Ask yourself, what the hell would get you out of bed in the morning? It's a fantasy exercise. If you could have what you wanted and needed, like you were taking care of yourself, even in principle, what would that mean?
- 4.115 It's a good tactic to take when you're arguing with someone you love, too. You ask them, "What would satisfy you?" People hate that question. They say, "If you love me, you would know." Which is like, no, I don't even know what I want. How the hell do I know what you want? But it's a gift you can give your partner in an argument. It's like, "Is there something that would satisfy you?" If the answer is no, it's like, why am I even talking? You don't even know. I know sometimes you have to flail around to figure out what you want, but it's a good gift.

- 4.116 You know, you can practice this. It's one of the things my wife and I learned to do. "What words would you like me to say?" You think that's false. Yeah, it'll be false the first time. But maybe if I do it 20 times, which isn't that long, if we're going to be together for, like, 50 years, maybe by the 20th time, I'll be kind of not so bad at it. And so, you could let me offer you what you need stupidly first—because that's how it's going to happen anyways. If I'm trying something new, I'm not going to be good at it.
- 4.117 And so, that's a fantasy exercise; that's a play that you can lay out in your imagination when you're arguing. What do you want? You want to crush? That's often the case. Do you want to be right? Fine, but you wake up with the person the next day. You're right, they're wrong. Oh, boy, that's not much of a victory.
- 4.118 People would do the Future Authoring exercise, and they wouldn't know exactly what to do. What the hell do you know about what you really need and want in five years? You can ask yourself, what do you think? What would get you moving? What would make you feel like overcoming the obstacles was worthwhile? Anything? Dream big. Maybe you can't get it; maybe you can. And then hold on to it lightly. It's a vision subject to revision. But you don't want to revisit it every day.
- 4.119 That's part of this will to stupidity. Once you commit, play it out for a while. Make your plan, implement it for—I'm going to try this for six months, or I'm going to try it for a year or two years, and I'm going to gather more information as a consequence of my commitment. And then I'll know specifically what worked and what didn't. And then maybe I can recalibrate. That's that dynamic between the decision to play a game, and there's a certain kind of stupidity and close-mindedness about that. But otherwise, what are you, second-guessing yourself constantly? Well, that's not helpful. Plus, you can't gather any information. "Thus an occasional will to stupidity."
- 4.120 Next. "The great epochs of our life come when we gain the courage to rechristen our evil as what is best in us." You see that in movies all the time, where some kid who's been bullied terribly and finds his inner demon and explodes, and that that's all to the good.
- 4.121 Here's a rule: if you're stuck and things aren't working, some manner in which you're construing the morality of your situation and your approach might be an error. This is something encapsulated to some degree in the concept of confessing to your sins. Sin means missing the targets. Things aren't working out for you. What are your options? The world is set against you. You're set against you. Your fellow man is set against you. Nature is set against you, and God is not on your side. That's one explanation. You're pretty much done if that's the case. The other possibility is that your aim is wrong. You should pray that it's the last one and not the first one.
- 4.122 Then you think, "How's my aim wrong?" It might be radically wrong, and that would be a revaluation of good and evil. This happens to people, agreeable people, all the time, because agreeable people, who are very often resentful, believe that conflict is wrong.

It's like, peace is good. That does not mean conflict is wrong. Those are not the same thing. They are not the same thing.

- 4.123** I've had people tell me—this is often if they've had an overbearing parent, father—they won't get angry. "I never get angry." Never? Seldom? Only under extreme duress and when it's necessary? Okay, never? That's a whole motivational system you've just made into your enemy. And if you think you've dominated it, you're a fool. People who don't engage in conflict are always resentful, always. And all that resentment is, is the underground manifestation of that aggression that they've demonized. And if you demonize it, it will be a demon.
- 4.124** This is part of an actual prayer. This is a very useful thing in an argument with someone you love. It's a terrible thing to learn to do. If you're arguing with someone and you can't make headway, retreat to your corner and think, "I know this time it's her. She's 99% wrong. I'm certain of it. And I'm right. Maybe I did something stupid to make this more likely."
- 4.125** Then you can think—that's a prayer—"Is there anything I did stupid that made this more likely?" There, you pray that, and you'll get an answer in no time flat. You'll know it's true because you do not want to hear it. You'll think of something you did three months ago or a year ago or yesterday that set this situation up, that's your contribution to the pathology. And then you can go tell the person, even if you're irritated, "Here's what I did wrong." And then she can tell you what she did wrong. And then you're two idiots, and likely you can negotiate, because you're not crushing or winning.
- 4.126** This is the purpose of this self-examination that's part and parcel of confession. You should pray that you did something wrong, if you're in trouble. Because if you did something wrong, maybe you could discover it and fix it, and then you wouldn't have to do it anymore. And so, why not start there? Because you have to forswear victory, let's say, and you have to forswear moral superiority. And it's painful because you have to reevaluate your perceptual frame, and that requires a bit of a journey across the desert. But the advantage is, maybe you can find the pathway forward.
- 4.127** There's a constant—I could never understand this when I was a kid, when I went to church. There was always this emphasis on evaluating your own sin. And I thought that was a terrible moral burden when I was 12. "I don't feel that much like a sinner." It's partly because I didn't understand what it meant. It seemed harsh and judgmental, but I didn't understand what it meant.
- 4.128** It's like, why wouldn't you search diligently for the error of your ways? Partly because it's hard to recalibrate. That's the tyranny, Red Sea, desert, Promised Land story. If you recalibrate, there's a sojourn of confusion, and people don't like that. And no wonder, no wonder. From certainty to uncertainty, that's very painful. That's why the tyrants double down. That's why people won't learn, because it's never tyranny, Promised

Land. It's always tyranny, chaos, desert, Promised Land, always. And so, if you're going to learn something, there's a little trip through chaos and the desert, before you find your way.

- 4.129** If you religiously practice finding your way, those transformations become maybe, maybe, if you got it right, they would become play. Because when you're playing, you're pushing yourself. There's a transformation that goes along with that. So, you could imagine that, if you were calibrating your improvement and aim properly, there'd be just enough uncertainty and chaos to keep you really alert and awake. And I think that is what makes itself manifest in play. And so, you could shrink the descent, so to speak, to the point where it's an optimally interesting adventure, instead of a complete bloody revolutionary catastrophe that traumatizes you and takes you out.
- 4.130** How do you do that? Pay attention. Pay attention. Are things going right, or are they starting to drift? If they're starting to drift, take the corrective step. The Egyptians worshipped the open eye. The Mesopotamians' highest god, Marduk, had eyes all the way around his face, all the way around his head. He saw everything. Zazu, in *The Lion King*, the eyes of the king—he flies above everything and sees. If you pay enough attention, that's a form of fearlessness. You can find the transformative way that optimizes transformation. You can find the way that optimizes transformation, and that makes itself manifest as play.
- 4.131** "The great epochs of our life come when we gain the courage to rechristen our evil as what is best in us." That's exactly what happens to the hobbit. You saw this in—you saw *Breaking Bad*? That's the theme in that, too. Walter White, when he became a criminal, was a better man than when he was the ordinary teacher. That didn't mean he was a good man. He was still a terrible man, but he was worse to begin with.
- 4.132** That's the cowardice of consensus morality that Nietzsche described. That series played that brilliantly because Walter was a genius. Resentful as hell because he had a rich friend who made it big, who was rewarded by the world for the genius of his Luciferian intelligence, and Walter White was extremely bitter and resentful about the fact that he was never recognized for his genius. And then, when push came to shove, he descended into the dark. And then he discovered in there whole elements of his personality that he'd never utilized.
- 4.133** This is a perverse thing about transformation as well. A cynic is a more moral person than a naive person, and that's kind of the development. Naïveté, betrayal, cynicism. You can stay in cynicism forever. The cynic is contemptuous of the naive person. And the naive person thinks the cynic is a brute, but the cynic is wiser than the naive person. But that doesn't make the cynic wise. Why? Because the equilibrium hasn't been reestablished. The cynicism hasn't given way to wisdom and play. A cynic is a lot harsher than a naive person, and a lot better. That doesn't mean they're good.

- 4.134** Let me give you another example from the present time. A lot of boys admire Andrew Tate. You all know who Andrew Tate is. Andrew Tate is not a good guy. Why is he an admirable figure? Because people who are afraid to be Andrew Tate are not good guys either. That's the morality as cowardice issue. You'd like to be a self-serving psychopath, but you don't have the courage for it. That's a very strange utterance, because it's not as if self-serving psychopath is a goal. It's like, is it an improvement over naive, resentful, basement-dwelling, murderous troll? Likely.
- 4.135** That's also why there's that attraction about it. When you see this with teenage boys, they often—there's an element to them that is very much attracted by the thug figure. That's because the thug at least has his aggression at hand. And so, why isn't that a developmental step forward? That doesn't mean it's the end. It doesn't mean it's the goal or even the proper goal.
- 4.136** But naive and harmless is not an improvement over self-serving and dangerous. In fact, self-serving and dangerous is—these are tricky things—is likely an improvement over weak and harmless. You can see this in the relative attraction of women to men in relationship to that, too, because the default woman will pick the dangerous self-serving man over the naive and helpless pup. That's a rough thing because both of those are not good choices, but that doesn't mean there's no wisdom in it.
- 4.137** "Sensuality often hastens the growth of love so much that the roots remain weak and are easily torn up." That's a short diatribe against idiot hedonism, fundamentally. One of the hallmarks of character and social stability and abundance is the ability to integrate the future into the present.
- 4.138** Here's a kind of a rule of thumb: the shorter the term between the manifestation of a desire and the pathway to its gratification, the more immature the conceptual frame. What do I mean by that? What's a hallmark of maturity? Delay of gratification. It's not the only hallmark of maturity, but it's a major one. It's like, why not get what something in you wants right now? What about tomorrow? Tomorrow is coming. So is next week and next month. It's like, you're just going to let them go for now. Are you going to sacrifice all time frames to the moment? That's what someone who's radically immature does. That's what a two-year-old does. Two-year-olds are trying to get beyond that, but that's their default orientation. Now, now, now. You have to learn to extend your time frame beyond that.
- 4.139** What else? It's all about what something in you wants now. To hell with the future. What about other people? What role do they play in that? They're now the objects of your own short-term desire? That's what Nietzsche is pointing to here. And it's more perverse than that as well.
- 4.140** Human beings have two sources of positive emotion. One is anticipation. That's dopaminergically mediated, neurochemically. That's the chemical access cocaine and

amphetamines, the real addictive drugs, work on. That's pleasure in anticipation of movement towards a goal.

- 4.141** And then there's actually attainment of the goal. That's satiation. Those are different forms of reward. So, sexual consummation is a form of satiation. And you can tell it's satiating, sating, because it brings the motivational frame to an end. Once the sexual act is consummated, the frame within which it constitutes the pursuit of the moment disappears. Just in the same way that if you're hungry and you eat, then you're not hungry. You go off and do something else. So satiation, consummation, brings the frame to an end. And that's a form of satisfaction, more than pleasure even.
- 4.142** It's complicated with sex. It's complicated with eating because there is an element of pleasure in that. Where's the pleasure in the pursuit and the anticipation? This is particularly true for human beings. I think we're perverse in this way that, for human beings, the pursuit is more meaningful than the capture. Always. This is why you want to have a noble goal, let's say, because if the goal is stellar, then the pursuit is maximally meaningful.
- 4.143** What happens if you gain the object of your pursuit? Well, that's the end of that game. Fair enough. And maybe you want the game to come to its appropriate end, but then you don't have the game. One of the things that Nietzsche is pointing to here, we have no idea what the relationship is between love and longing. We have no idea. We have no idea how many barriers there need to be between men and women sexually, before there's any relationship.
- 4.144** I do believe, I believe this to be true—I think the fundamental marker of a woman's social status is her ability to say no. That's the marker. Why? You can imagine a woman who's pursued by men of various status. How are the men going to adjudicate her status, and how are the other women going to adjudicate her status, even herself? The higher the status of man that you can say no to, the higher status you have, obviously. And so, that's a hell of a thing to understand, and I'm certain it's true.
- 4.145** How do you know if you have something valuable? You don't bargain it away lightly. That's how you indicate it to yourself and to others. This is another Nietzschean realization. Free love. That was the '60s mantra. Oh, by the way, if you do personality investigations into free love advocates and their personality, what you find is that the males in particular, the most fervent advocates of free love are Dark Tetrad types—psychopathic, Machiavellian, narcissistic, and sadistic. So, if you set up a society where there are no barriers to sexual gratification, the psychopathic men end up on top.
- 4.146** So there's the result of the sexual revolution. That's a useful thing to know if you're male or female. Why? This is Nietzsche's point: "Sensuality often hastens the growth of love so much that the roots remain weak and are easily torn up."
- 4.147** What do we know about the preconditions for establishing something approximating a lasting relationship? Why would you want one instead of the pleasure of the moment?

How long do you think you're going to be able to bargain for the pleasure of the moment? That's a very short-term orientation. Maybe if you're young and particularly attractive and fortunate and healthy and properly situated, then people will be lining up for one-night stands. But that's not going to last forever; you can be sure of that. And then the question is: who do you attract if that's the orientation? So that's a question worth asking yourself.

**4.148** And then why would you want a long-term commitment? Maybe to find someone who's capable of having a long-term commitment, instead of someone who's immature and playing for the moment, the Machiavellian, psychopathic, narcissistic types. And maybe because it's useful to have someone around, to help you think your way through life.

**4.149** And then, what about a platform for family and children? Is that going to be all integrated, or are you going to forgo all of that, all that contextual relevance, for what? For the gratification of the moment? And then does that destroy all the rest of that? Any love story, like any romantic adventure that we'll watch and become captivated by, is the story of love persisting through a sequence of obstacles. That's the romantic element of it. That's the romantic adventure element. How do we make this work in a manner that's deep and lasting, regardless of opposition?

**4.150** Pornography is the leap to the climax with no context whatsoever, with nothing else given any consideration. And we know what that's doing to us: 35% of internet traffic is pornographic, and now, what, 50% is bots. Welcome to the digital world that maximizes grip of short-term attention. Right? Brutal. God only knows what that's going to do to us, especially as the AI systems learn to optimize the grip of the web on our short-term attention. And they're learning that fast. Scroll, scroll, scroll. Just like you're hooked to a variable ratio reinforcement slot machine.

## Lecture 5: Discipline and Freedom

At a glance — Discipline and freedom.

- 5.1 "When we have"—this is a funny one—"when we have to change our mind about a person, we hold the inconvenience he causes us very much against him." Nietzsche is very funny.
- 5.2 This is true. I noticed when I was a young man, again, that some of my best friends were people I just couldn't stand when I first met them. I think this is not uncommon in the way that primates make their way up the social dominance hierarchy.
- 5.3 You remember in junior high or in high school, a new kid came to class and was— all the kids that were overly eager to be friends were the low-status kids. And they would often congregate around the newcomer first, and then the newcomer would clamber his way or her way up the hierarchy until they found their status match, something like that. A lot of the people that I ended up being friends with, I didn't like at all when I first met them. And I think it was probably because they didn't give a damn, in a sense, whether they were—they weren't desperately seeking for approval, let's say. Was it annoying to me that I had to change my mind? Definitely.
- 5.4 Because, why? Well, we laid that out already. When you have to change your mind, well, at what level did you make an error? It can be deep, so that's an investigation. Then there's that intervening period of chaos. If I made a mistake about this person, how many other people have I made mistakes about, and what other mistakes have I made? "We hold the inconvenience he causes us very much against him." This is why first impressions are also often quite important. I did learn that my sense of first impression was not particularly reliable, however.
- 5.5 "When we have to change our mind"—you could generalize from this—"when we have to change our mind about a situation, we hold the inconvenience caused to us by the situation very much against it." This is the funny thing, because this is the problem with the search for security. If you're searching for security, then what you're trying to do is stabilize what you already think, because that's secure. Then you're going to manipulate, like you're going to avoid people, for example, who would challenge your presuppositions. You're going to avoid situations that would force you to reevaluate who you are. You're going to shrink away, so that you can maintain your perceptual frame.
- 5.6 And no wonder, because to transform that perceptual frame, unless you're an expert at it, requires some contact with chaos and uncertainty, and that's difficult. But the problem with looking for security in that manner is that you forgo transformation. Now, Christ says there's a sin that no one can be forgiven for. That's the sin against the Holy Spirit. What's the Holy Spirit? It's the guide to transformation. Why is the sin against

that unforgivable? Well, if you forgo the process of transformation, there's no hope for you, obviously, because you've killed the thing that would transform you.

- 5.7 So then the question is: How can you reshift your conceptual frame, so that you welcome correction? That's humility. The opposite of pride, that's humility. It's when you understand that certainly the medium- to long-term gain accrued in consequence of practicing admission of error is so overwhelming that there isn't any short-term benefit that can possibly compete. You have to understand that. Where did I make my mistake? You want to welcome that. It's a very hard thing to practice, because you have to get accustomed to that chaos that's intervening.
- 5.8 But it's a different orientation towards security. You could think about it as the security that an alliance with heaven would produce. So, what's the idea? On the one hand, you stick with what you have. On the other hand, you search diligently for correction upward, and you assume the consequence of that is the most stable form of security possible. And that's right, that's right. It's much more sophisticated.
- 5.9 Do you put your faith in who you are or in growth? That's another way of thinking about it. Do you put your faith in what you are already or in the process that develops you? Then maybe when you have to change your mind again about a person or a situation, you won't hold the inconvenience that's caused very much against it. You'll be grateful, grateful for correction. There's a hell of a thing to master. You could imagine practicing that for 10 years.
- 5.10 "A people is a detour of nature to get to six or seven great men. Yes, and then to get around them." Nietzsche always likes to trump himself when he lays out an aphorism. Well, that's a very different vision of the world, and it goes with his emphasis on aristocracy.
- 5.11 There's a rule called the Pareto distribution. I'll give you an example of this. So, I did a series of studies on creative achievement. There's lots of ways you can define creativity. I could measure your creativity by the breadth of the gap between conceptions in your thinking. So, if you're a conventional thinker, the gap between one statement and another, the conceptual gap, is going to be pretty constrained, which kind of means that what you say is going to be predictable. The more creative you are, the more manic, sometimes the more schizophrenic, but certainly the more manic, the bigger the leap between ideas. And you can measure that. How?
- 5.12 Here's one way: you have three minutes to write down as many uses as you can think of for a brick. And then how do you score that? Number of responses, that's just straight fluency. So, the more responses, the better, because it means you can produce a lot of ideas. And then the statistical improbability of the use. So you all write down uses. The uses that everyone writes down, you don't get an extra point for. But if you write down a use that no one else wrote—there's maps of these statistical

improbabilities—then that counts as an additional mark for your creative capacity as a thinker. That's originality, you might say.

- 5.13** Now, it's tricky because the use has to be real and unlikely. So that's a creative response. And that's actually correlated with lifetime creative achievement quite highly. IQ matters a lot, just raw cognitive power, but this fluency is an additional predictor. And that's more a characterization of you as a creative thinker. Now, not everybody who's a creative thinker has accomplished something creative. You see people like that who are creative, but they never go anywhere. They can't implement.
- 5.14** So, another way of defining creativity is creative achievement. And so, we built a scale that broke creative achievement into 13 categories: entrepreneurship, dance, literature, visual arts, culinary production, architecture, music, etc. We tried to cover the relevant domains that people generally bring to mind when they think about creativity, and then we produced a hierarchy of attainment.
- 5.15** Zero would be, "I have no talent or training in this area." And eight would be, if you're a musician, "My compositions have been played multiple times on an international scale." So then we gave this to hundreds of people, and we looked at the results: 70% of people score zero. Zero. And the next most common score is one. And then there's a handful of people who score 150. They're way the hell out. This is an example of how creative production is distributed in the world.
- 5.16** I'll give you some other examples of this. So, a small handful of recording artists record almost all the popular music. If you take all the music that the popular artists record, a tiny fragment of what they wrote and recorded is popular. So, the big five composers, Bach, Beethoven, etc, occupy 95% of the classical corpus, and 5% of the music they wrote is the music that's played. So, the rule is: a very small number of people do everything. Now, it's a little more complicated than that because there's lots of games, but that distribution holds up.
- 5.17** I'll give you an example of that, too, that worked out quite nicely for me. I used this website called Quora. I answered a bunch of questions, like 50. I wrote 50 answers, and I got a Pareto distribution out of the likes. Most of the things I wrote—this was before people knew who I was, really—most of the things I wrote went nowhere. One of them went hyper-viral, and it was a list of rules. I thought, "Well, that's good market testing." I had written 42 rules. I pulled 12 rules out of that, and I wrote my book. But I had to make 50 responses to get one that was the most successful, and this success was exponential, not linear.
- 5.18** This is the case with virtually everything that has many things that have variability. There's normal distributions in variability, but there's this weird Pareto distribution. So, I'll give you some examples of that, and it's not just in the realm of creative production, but it's definitely there. Hardly anyone has all the money. There's no way around that.

There's never been an economic system generated by anyone, anywhere, on any principles, where that didn't happen.

- 5.19 In the Soviet Union, for example, everyone was "equal." It's like, no, they weren't. The inequality was worse in the Communist countries; it was just masked. It was the wealthy who had the dachas. Maybe they didn't have "money." They just had the equivalent of money, privilege and property. And so, no one's been able to come out with a solution that mitigates against unequal distribution of resources.
- 5.20 A small number of rivers have all the water. A small number of lakes have all the water. A small number of planets have all the mass. A small number of stars have all the mass. A small number of blood vessels in your body contain most of the blood. A small number of cities have all the people. A small number of countries have all the wealth. It's very standard distribution.
- 5.21 So what's Nietzsche's point? "A people is a detour of nature to get to six or seven great men." Well, you need a lot of variability and experimentation to get any success whatsoever. And when success comes, it's exponential and not linear. One of the things that's very useful to know in your own life is that most of what you do won't work. But if you do enough, one thing might work, and you only need one thing to work. This is pretty standard wisdom, let's say, among those who study entrepreneurs. Most entrepreneurs have strings of failures. It doesn't matter because they need one.
- 5.22 Now, some people, like Elon Musk is a good—I don't know what the hell is with him: string of success after success. He's positioned so that that's possible as well. There's a principle, the Matthew principle, it's in the gospel: "To those who have everything, more will be given. From those who have nothing, everything will be taken." It's a map of the world and success. Success isn't this, and failure isn't this. Success is this, and failure is that. It feeds back on itself.
- 5.23 This is a useful thing to know, too, because if you're starting something new, you can start very slow. But if you're persistent, the gains don't accrue linearly; they accrue exponentially. So, even if you start like a fool with stumbling steps, if you're on a productive path, you can accelerate extremely rapidly. This is why I wrote—I think it was in 12 Rules—try to do at least one thing—I think that was the rule—try to do at least one thing as well as you possibly can. Yeah, do one thing as well as you possibly can and see what happens. It's a very good thing to know. Pick something, push it as hard as you can. It disciplines you, it gets you to the bottom of things, and it can start that acceleration process.
- 5.24 The people who are hyper-successful—I saw lots of hyper-successful people. It really helps to be smart, really helps to be hard-working. Sheer bloody repetitive persistence, that's pretty useful, too. And we shouldn't be unhappy about this—2% of scientific papers are worth the paper they're written on. Well, you have to do a lot of error to get somewhere that works.

- 5.25 I've thought about this in terms of restaurants. How many bad restaurants do you need so that there can be one good one? Who knows? A lot. A lot. There has to be a lot of trial and experimentation and wastage for anything to make itself manifest. And so, then when you see someone who's attained a stellar degree of success, what's the right attitude towards that, if it's not a corrupt game? Pleasure that that could occur, and thankfulness that that's possible, that that's possible. That's a hallmark of abundant societies. Some people get to be successful. If no one can be successful, you certainly won't be successful.
- 5.26 And success means differential success. Now, I think the way we balance that is that there's lots of ways of being successful. There's lots of games. And if you can't find a game in which you could be successful, you could invent your own game. And if you can invite other people to play, hey, man, maybe that's your creative contribution. And people are very good at that. We're very good at differentiating our games. And so, you can imagine, you could have differential success, which seems unfair, but then you have multiple pathways to differential success.
- 5.27 I think this is right. Most of the people I know who are well constituted are very good at something. They have their niche where they have true expertise. And that's enough status, let's say, well-deserved status, to allow them to be ordinary in other places, and that's okay. And mostly, you want to be ordinary in most places, because you don't want to be extraordinary in every possible way. Jesus, you'd just burn yourself to a crisp. If you're extraordinary in one way and you can manage that, good for you. The rest of it, you could make ordinary and be happy.
- 5.28 "One is best punished for one's virtues." Oh, that's such a vicious phrase. Why should someone be punished for their faults? No. If you want to punish someone, you hurt them for their virtues. One of the things I learned, realized, about the story of Adam and Eve—you know, Adam and Eve wake up, and they realize that they're naked. That means they realize they're vulnerable. To realize your nakedness is to realize your exposure to the world. Animals don't know they're naked; human beings know.
- 5.29 What does it mean to be naked? Vulnerable. What does vulnerable mean? You can be hurt. What happens when Adam and Eve, eyes open, and they realize their vulnerability? They understand the difference between good and evil. Why? Because as soon as you know you're vulnerable, you know other people are vulnerable, and then you can exploit it. And the exploitation of vulnerability, that's evil. That's sadism. It's like the positive delight in the suffering of others.
- 5.30 Unless you know your own vulnerability, you can't do that. And so, that's why knowledge of good and evil enters the world with awareness of vulnerability. And that does make human beings completely different than any other creature. It's because we can make pain into an art. How do you do that most effectively? Do you punish people for their inadequacies? No. You wait till you see them do something good, and you hurt them for that.

- 5.31 That happens in families all the time. You see this terrible intergenerational jealousy between parents and children. It's like the evil queen or the tyrannical father. Someone has misspent their life, and they're jealous of their children because of that untrammelled opportunity that's in front of them. And they see their child make a step in a direction that they determined not to take, maybe at a young age, and they wait till that talent makes itself manifest, and they crush it. Right. "One is best punished for one's virtues." That's the core of the malevolent, sadistic impulse. Killer phrase.
- 5.32 "One seeks a midwife for his thoughts, another someone whom he can help. That's the origin of a good conversation." That's a lovely guide to an interesting exchange. What's Nietzsche's point? Let's straighten something out. Or is there some way that I can configure my conversation that would be of genuine service to you? That's a mentoring relationship, let's say, or a genuine friendship relationship. That's a lot different than combat in conversation or the desire to be right.
- 5.33 I love this one. "When we are awake, we also do what we do in our dreams." This is a precursor to the psychoanalytic insight, the relationship between dreams and the world. Jung, Carl Jung, believed we are dreaming all the time. He's right. That's right. We construe the world from within the confines of a fantasy whose essential nature we're unconscious of. That's exactly right. He got it exactly right.
- 5.34 Now, the way that you perceive the world is dependent on your aim, even if you don't know what your aim is, and that aim is a dream. It's a dream. You're always dreaming. "When we're awake, we also do what we do in our dreams. We invent and make up the person with whom we associate—and immediately forget it." Exactly right. How can you look beyond that? Attention will do that. Inquiry. You start with the assumption that you don't know.
- 5.35 It's funny. I'll tell you a story. My wife had some trouble with her older sister for quite a —repetitive trouble. They hadn't seen each other much when they were adults. My sister-in-law was eight years older than my wife, and my wife was often in some competition with her older sisters. She has two of them— had two; one of them died last year, this particular woman, in fact. And Tammy, my wife, was always getting into trouble with her older sisters. And so, we'd go visit, and there'd be some trouble.
- 5.36 They had a lovely family—this is not a critique of their family. They had a very lovely family. But she would run into trouble, and it was partly because she was trying to make her point known like a younger child. She came to me at one point and said, "I'm in trouble again with my sister. What should I do?" I said, "Well, you should— don't tell her anything. Don't offer any opinions. Watch and listen. Just watch and listen, and see what happens." And so, she did that, and she watched and listened when we were visiting for three days. No opinions. Wasn't after anything, wasn't after any attention, was just presuming she didn't know what the hell was going on, which was why she kept walking into the same hole.

- 5.37 And we went to this Chinese restaurant. It was so remarkable. Horrible, horrible Chinese restaurant on Vancouver Island. Orange and grimy plastic menus and terrible food. It was not a good place. We sat down. We'd gone whale-watching. We sat down, and Tammy's sister told her who she thought she was. She said, "Everything's always come easy to you. My parents did everything for you," and nothing for her; that was the inference. "You never had any real trouble in your life." And admittedly, this woman, Barb, her fiancé had been killed in a car accident when she was about 17, and that was devastating. "You were spoiled, and you've had it much easier than me."
- 5.38 It was a remarkable thing, because none of it was true. It was so not true that it wasn't even insulting. It was like, "I don't know who you're talking about." The person you dreamed up, certainly. And it was obvious, even to Barb, that that was just not true. She dreamed that up, likely when she was 13 or 15 or something, like 20 years before, and never updated it at all. At the end of this, Tammy just sat there and didn't say a word, just listened. She kicked me under the table. She just listened.
- 5.39 Barb came to the end. She said, "But you're a very good mother." And so, it was so interesting because she unrolled this dream, and then at the end of it, she thought, "Oh, those are a bunch of things I just said. Where did that come from? Is that even true?" And then she had a realization, which was: "Tammy's a very good mother," and that doesn't really seem in keeping with this whole selfish, overprotected young person theory. We just left it at that.
- 5.40 Tammy continued not imposing her view, and watching and listening, and then they got along a lot better after that, a lot better. And then about three years later, she did exactly the same thing, exactly the same thing, told the same story, except much shorter. At the end, she said exactly the same thing. She said, "Yeah, but you're a very good mother." And then that was the end of that, and then they got along for 15 years. It was amazing. But that was a perfect example of this.
- 5.41 Maybe the person you're not getting along with is the person you've dreamt up. And maybe the reason you don't notice that is because you treat them in a way that only allows them to manifest what you expect.
- 5.42 Married couples do that to each other all the time. It's like, that's Peter. "Peter, Peter, pumpkin-eater, had a wife and couldn't keep her. So he put her in a pumpkin shell, and there he kept her very well." And so, what does that mean? You get to be who I allow you to be. Right, so what's the price I pay for that? You're kind of dull. Why? Because I won't let you be anything that would be interesting. Why? Because I want security and predictability. Well, there's no development for you. That's a major price to pay.
- 5.43 So, here's a rule of thumb: if you're bored by people, if you're bored by anyone, you're probably not paying attention. I learned this as a clinician. I had a lot of simple people in my clinical practice, a lot of complex and sophisticated people, a whole gamut. I learned pretty early that, if the person wasn't so interesting I couldn't stand it, I wasn't

listening to them. Because if you listen to people, people are very weird. They're very weird. They're as strange as a Dostoevsky novel.

- 5.44 And if they're not interesting to you, it's because you are not listening. You're not attending. Because if you do, they will tell you who they are, and that'll be so interesting. Part of the reason you don't want to listen is because you actually don't want things to get that interesting. It's like, "Whoa, I didn't want to know that." And that's even true about yourself. You're bored by people? You're bored by the dream that you see instead of them.
- 5.45 "Whoever fights monsters should see to it that in the process he does not become a monster. And when you look long into an abyss, the abyss also looks into you." We covered that a little bit in the previous aphorism, so I'll just leave that set. You see that motif in the Mafia-type movies, too; you see these guys who've deviated down the criminal and aggressive path. And the interesting characters that are portrayed in a sophisticated way still have a moral compass, right? And they're battling, they're trying to determine how to take that terrible aspect of them and integrate it back to find the appropriate path forward. That's the integration of the shadow.
- 5.46 "Having a talent is not enough; one also requires your permission for it—right, my friends?" That's a commentary on the same dream issue. This is exactly right, and you see this in families and marriages. You don't want to sacrifice who the people around you could be for your convenience, and partly because it'll take all the spirit out of your marriage, let's say.
- 5.47 I've talked to men who said, "I don't know how you can stay with one woman." Well, I don't stay with the boring dream of that woman. That's how. People are very strange, and they're mutable and complex; and so, if you don't put them in a pumpkin shell, they don't get dull. And you have to learn how to encourage that and see, with the person you're with, what queer, weird quirks do they have? What undiscovered talents could you encourage and foster? Could you overcome your own jealousy with regard to that person's undiscovered talent, so that you could encourage that?
- 5.48 That's a good challenge. And that's a protection against the proclivity to replace the person with your presumptions, and then to punish them every time they deviate. People do that all the time. It's like, "I've got you boxed in, and if you make a move out, I will let you know." Well, then you just reduce each other to these stereotypes over time, and all the dynamism goes away. Predictability—predictability and boredom, those are very similar things.
- 5.49 "Madness is rare in individuals—but in groups, parties, nations, and ages, it is the rule." Kierkegaard wrote much about that. He said that wherever there was a crowd, if a crowd picks up a truth, the mere fact that the crowd reflects it immediately makes it into something that isn't true. That's a very interesting— what—parallel realization to Nietzsche's notion about herd consensus and camouflage.

- 5.50 "The thought of suicide is a powerful comfort; it helps one through many a dreadful night." I had this crazy psychology professor at the University of Alberta when I was a student there. He was a very weird guy. He ended up on a bus going from, many years later, on a bus going from Winnipeg to some little town, and disappeared. And no one ever heard from him again, and no one knew what happened to him. Patrick Thauberger was his name. He was a psychologist at a maximum security prison there and an adjunct professor at the University of Alberta.
- 5.51 I struck up a bit of a friendship with him, and went to the maximum security prison a couple of times with him, which was quite the hair-raising experience. I talked to him about suicide at one point, speaking clinically. He said, "Think about suicide as: 'you can always do it later.'" I thought that was—it's a very helpful little bit of practical advice. Now, what's Nietzsche's point? "The thought of suicide is a powerful comfort." Things could end. "It helps one through many a dreadful night." Is there some utility in the idea of finitude? Well, that's Nietzsche's question there. This could end.
- 5.52 "Jesus said to his Jews, 'The law was for servants—love God as I love him, as his son! What are morals to us sons of God!'" There's many situations in the New Testament where Christ performs something radically good in violation of the rules. So, you see this motif emerge quite continually. He heals on the Sabbath. Now, the rule is, don't work on the Sabbath. It's a good rule.
- 5.53 There's another apocryphal story. I think it's apocryphal. Christ is walking down the road, and it's the Sabbath, and there's some shepherd in a ditch, and one of his sheep has fallen into a hole, and it's going to die in the desert sun. So, the shepherd is trying to get the sheep out of the hole. And Christ says to him, "If you know what you're doing, you're blessed. But if you don't know what you're doing, you're a transgressor of the law and you're cursed."
- 5.54 So, what does it mean? It's like, don't work on the Sabbath. Why? Because then everyone works all the time. And so, if you work and break that rule, then other people are going to do it, and then soon everybody's going to work all the time, which is the situation in our culture. But you've got this sheep and you're responsible for it, and it's in a hole and it's going to die. And if you know the risk you're taking by breaking the rule to serve something higher, and that's actually what you're doing, then you've gone above and beyond the law into the domain of the spirit, and good for you. But if you're doing it casually, then look the hell out. Smart.
- 5.55 "Can you heal on the Sabbath?" Well, that's what Christ asks the Pharisees, and they don't know what to answer, and they're not happy with him for doing it at all. And he indicates that their mindless moralizing with regards to their herd-like following of the rules for the purposes of their own self-display as moralists is sinful. He points that out repeatedly, and they do not like it. That's a major part of the reason why he ends up crucified.

- 5.56 "Love God as I love him." In the Sermon on the Mount, Christ says to his followers: How do you orient yourself properly in the world? Aim at the highest possible good. That's to remember God above all things. Remember that men and women are made in God's image, so that there's a reflection of what's highest in every soul. And then having established that aim and reminded yourself of it, pay attention to the moment. Perfect.
- 5.57 If you do that, what did He say? That pathway is the embodiment of the law and the prophets and the highest possible expression of what's moral—more moral than mere adherence to the rules, even when they're valid. Because the rules can't cover every eventuality. And there might be times when, there will be times when, the best thing you could do would be in violation of an average tradition, but tread lightly— that's Nietzsche's point in this aphorism.
- 5.58 "One does not credit clever people with their follies. What a loss of human rights!" I rephrase that when I remember it. Stupid people—great people are seldom credited with their stupidity. It means in some ways that there's a trade-off in everything. I think I realized this most particularly when I was thinking about my parents, because as your parents get old, in a way, they become more who they are. There's a kind of solidification of their personality. And there's a painfulness in that, to see that.
- 5.59 But the thing about the people that you love is that you might think that, in a way, you would like them to be better. And in a way, that's true, but one of the things you have to also understand is that many of the things that make your love for them particularized are associated with—they're indistinguishable from their limitations. They're the same thing. They're just the other side of it. But what's a good way of making that concrete?
- 5.60 I can give you an example of my father. My father was an immovable person in some ways. If he said no, that meant no. And it really meant—and this was really true with him, I would say, because this was the kind of person he was—it really meant in the final analysis that "you'd have to kill me." He was a hunter, and he liked to be alone, and he liked to be out on the frontier, essentially. And so, that was the sort of character he was. Well, one of the corollaries of that was that he was stubborn about things that weren't helpful. You could hope maybe that you could have one without the other. It's not always so obvious.
- 5.61 My father-in-law, whom I really loved, was a great guy, very different than my father. My father was low in enthusiasm, high in assertiveness, so a strange kind of extrovert. Whereas my father-in-law was like Foghorn Leghorn, that Looney Tunes character, very —my wife thinks she understands Donald Trump because her dad is like him, and he was the small-town version of that. Unbelievably extroverted, party animal sort of character. Very, very amusing. Kind of unforgiving.
- 5.62 I used to tell my kids when we visited my father-in-law, I said, "Don't mess with grandpa. If he has to dislike you for the rest of his life, that'll be no problem. So be on

your best behavior." And they were, and they got along just fine. And he was lovely, but he wasn't the world's most agreeable person, and he wasn't particularly forgiving. And in a positive way, it was like he'd wash his hands of you. That's harsh, but don't muck about. That was the rule, and my kids managed that, and that worked.

- 5.63** And you can see the downsides of such things, but it's something that you can even credit yourself with to some degree. You're going to have a temperament. You have a temperament. Does it have downsides? There wouldn't be variability in temperament across the human species if there weren't pros and cons. Well, you want to give yourself credit for the advantages your temperament bestows on you, and you want to have some understanding for the limitations. That's the same with the people that you know. And it's certainly possible that the good thing wouldn't exist without its shadow; that's exactly it.
- 5.64** "The consequences of our actions take hold of us, quite indifferent to our claim that meanwhile we have 'improved.'" What's the reformulation of that? You think you're done with the past; that doesn't mean the past is done with you. That's Nietzsche's reformulation of karma. There's a terrible—there's this idea, primitive, superstitious, childlike, religious idea, that God has a great book in the sky and writes down every occurrence. It's sort of like the law of consequences: there's nothing you've done or haven't done that you won't pay for. And so, you think, "I've changed." Yeah, but have you made amends? Right, and it will catch up with you. That's a terrifying realization.
- 5.65** Okay, let's stop with that. Oh, that's good. We pretty much got through it, anyways. I'll just read you the last few that I gathered, and we'll turn to the next sections. "There's an innocence in lying which is the sign of good faith in a cause." Yeah, I can get away with it. That's very interesting. "The familiarity of those who are superior embitters because it may not be returned." Dostoevsky wrote a whole short story about that. Yeah. "The familiarity of those who are superior embitters because it may not be returned."
- 5.66** Here's a one-sentence statement of the genesis of trauma. "Not that you lied to me, but that I believed you, that's shaken me." That's a very interesting way of conceptualizing betrayal. Someone betrays you, what's the catastrophe there? That they were that malevolent or that you were that naive? Which is the more catastrophic realization? If you want to set your children up for trauma, make them naive, and then wait till they encounter someone malevolent. What's the trauma? The malevolence or the violation of their naivety. They're the same thing, but that's Nietzsche's point.
- 5.67** "'I don't like him.' 'Why?' 'I am not equal to him.' Has any human being ever answered that way?" These are questions of conscience. Yes. He has hundreds of these, and they're littered through all of his books, and the books are worth reading, just maybe mostly for these one-line aphorisms. They're so punchy, and they're so much worth contemplating. I don't think anyone—I've never read anything like this from anyone else, not with this degree of continual depth, novelty of formulation, and sheer punch.

- 5.68** Part Five: Natural History of Morals. "Just because our moral philosophers"—what does he mean by the natural history of morals? What's the developmental sequence of the emergence of morality? That's his question. "Just because our moral philosophers knew the facts of morality only very approximately in arbitrary extracts or in accidental epitomes, for example, as the morality of their environment, their class, their church, the spirit of their time, their climate, and part of the world; just they were poorly informed and not even very curious about different people's times and past ages, they never laid eyes on the real problems of morality, for these emerge only when we compare many moralities."
- 5.69** This is why I think Rome collapsed. This may be why the West will collapse. Rome collapsed from indigestion. For a culture to be unified, it has to commit to a single view of the world around which everyone congregates. That's the shared corpus of stories. This is Nietzsche's comment here. So, what happens if you're an expansionist empire?
- 5.70** First of all, you're secure in your belief in the foundation of your civilization. Why? Because you're surrounded by people who believe exactly the same thing, and it's working. So now you expand, and maybe your ethos is solid enough to provide impetus to that expansion. The Europeans had enough confidence to engage in the colonial enterprise. Modern people can't even imagine what that must have been like. We can't even put ourselves in the shoes of the Victorians. And we think we're morally superior, when the truth is, we're just cowardly.
- 5.71** The Victorians, especially the English, had this unshakable conviction in the rightness of their own ethos. It was unquestioned. So, the expansion occurs. Well, what's the problem with the expansion? "They never laid eyes on the real problems of morality." Not what is the moral path; what is the essence of morality? That's a deeper question. Not what is the right path within a morality; what constitutes morality itself? When does that question arise? When we compare many moralities.
- 5.72** So what happens when you expand into the world? You find that there are other cultures, there are other people who think from radically different first principles. And maybe they're more successful than you are in some ways. That certainly was the realization, let's say, of the Europeans when they went to Japan, which was an elevated society in comparison to European society in many ways.
- 5.73** But no matter where you go, there's these radically different ways of construing the world, and so you run into the problem that you thought you had the only game in town and that it was the best game; and it turns out, there's a lot of games in town, and it isn't necessarily obvious which of those is the best, but it's worse.
- 5.74** "In all 'science of morals' so far, one thing was lacking, strange as it may sound—the problem of morality itself." What is this moral framework? When you're in it, you don't even think about it as a moral framework. It's just the way the world is. The medieval Christians didn't believe in Christianity the way modern people do. That's how they saw

the world. That was their explanation for the world. They didn't believe it. You don't believe it until you've run into the problem that Nietzsche is describing here. It doesn't become a matter of belief; it's just how people see the world.

**5.75** "In all 'science of morals' so far, one thing was lacking, strange as it may sound—the problem of morality itself. What was lacking was any suspicion that there was something problematic here. What the philosophers called 'a rational foundation for morality' and tried to supply was, seen in the right light, merely a scholarly variation of the common faith in the prevalent morality." Morality unites everyone. That's the culture. You explain it post hoc and give it a rational justification. That's the realm of philosophy within that culture, what happens when cultures mix.

**5.76** "What the philosophers called 'a rational foundation for morality' and tried to supply was, seen in the right light, merely a scholarly variation of the common faith in the prevalent morality." It's like a post hoc justification. "A new means of expression for this faith, and thus just another fact within a particular morality; indeed, in the last analysis, a kind of denial that this morality might ever be considered problematic, certainly the very opposite of an examination, analysis, questioning, and vivisection of this very faith."

**5.77** So, what Nietzsche would say is that the European ethos, let's say the British-English-Victorian ethos, was a dream. The philosophy that emerged within it was a rationalization for the dream. What's the consequence of the expansion out into the world? There are many dreams. What's the problem? Maybe your dream isn't paramount. What's the worst problem? If your dream isn't paramount, and there are many dreams, maybe no dream is paramount.

**5.78** That's the fundamental question of morality. That's the sinkhole of nihilism. Were we right? There's lots of different viewpoints. Is a different viewpoint right? That's a problematic question. Here's a worse one: Is any viewpoint right? Then you're done. I think that's what happened to Rome. That's likely what's happening to the West. What makes us think we're right? Okay, what are you going to do with that? Well, you either rediscover the foundations or God dies. You have hedonistic disintegration. You have nihilism. You have a turn to nationalism. You have the rise of ideology. That's exactly where we're at.

**5.79** "Every morality is, as opposed to letting it go, a bit of tyranny against 'nature', also against 'reason'; but this in itself is no objection, as long as we do not have some other morality, which permits us to decree that every kind of tyranny and unreason is impermissible." It's a useful conceptual investigation starting place, even there.

**5.80** Are you opposed to slavery? Why? The answer to that is, you don't know. It's self-evident. It's like, it wasn't self-evident for most of history. Why is it self-evident now? What stance have you taken that makes that self-evident? What place do your perceptions exist within that makes that so obvious that it isn't even questionable?

That's a stance. I would say that's straightforward. "Men and women are made in the image of God." Do you believe that? Maybe you're atheistic. Are you opposed to slavery?

- 5.81** If you don't understand that your opposition is grounded in the metaphysics of the identity between the divine and the human soul, then your objection to slavery is what? What is it? Why can't I just say, "If I can make you, why shouldn't I?" And maybe you might say that if you're lost enough, and I'm the person who comes along and says that, you're perfectly happy to go along with it. And then you have that dynamic interplay between tyrant and slave.
- 5.82** What's the ground, what's the foundation, for the presumption that enslavement is wrong? Well, it's self-evident. Yeah. Why? Why is it self-evident? And why are you so convinced of that? "Every morality is, as opposed to letting it all go, a bit of tyranny against 'nature', also against 'reason'; but this in itself is no objection, as long as we do not have some other morality which permits us to decree that every kind of tyranny and unreason is impermissible." You have to have a stance; that's his point.
- 5.83** This is great. This is great. "What is essential and inestimable in every morality is that it constitutes a long compulsion to understand Stoicism or Puritanism. One should recall the compulsion under which every language so far has achieved strength and freedom—the metrical compulsion of rhyme and rhythm. Every artist knows how far from any feeling of merely letting himself go his 'most natural' state is—the free ordering, placing, disposing, giving form in the moment of 'inspiration'—and how strictly and subtly he obeys thousandfold laws precisely then, laws that precisely on account of their hardness and determination defy all formulation through concepts.
- 5.84** "How much trouble the poets and orators of all people have taken—not excepting a few prose writers today in whose ear there dwells an inexorable conscience—'for the sake of some foolishness,' as utilitarian dolts say, feeling smart—'submitting abjectly to capricious laws,' as anarchists say, feeling 'free,' even 'free-spirited.'" But the curious fact, this is such a radical proposition for those who believe that creativity is equivalent to anarchic freedom. Nietzsche is making exactly the opposite point, construing this realm of rules.
- 5.85** Imagine a great musician. Imagine how disciplined his approach to improvisation would be if he's a master. Imagine how many rules he's following and how much compulsive practice has been at the basis of that freedom. It's freedom in consequence of the imposition of order. This is something so necessary to understand when you're raising children: don't interfere with your child's creative expression. Every parent, every modern parent, is terrified of that. It's like, principles enable. They're not boundaries, rules, let's say. They are to some degree. You can break the rules. What are the rules for? So the game can be played.

- 5.86 What's Nietzsche's point? Complex, sophisticated, harmonious rules. That's how creativity flourishes. There's not an antithesis between creativity and this underlying principled order. The proper creative expression is the highest form of ordered freedom. When Moses faces the Pharaoh, he doesn't say what the civil rights leaders said he said, "Let my people go." That is not what he says. He says, "Let my people go, so they may celebrate me in the desert." That's a completely different—that's Nietzsche's point. Freedom is not freedom from; it's freedom within.
- 5.87 And so, you want to play an exacting game. Think about a pianist. That's an exacting game. You can even break the rules. You can bend and play with the rules, but you have to know them, and you have to be a master of them. And then what's the consequence of all that compulsion, that apprenticeship, that slavery to the dogma and the doctrine, is that you produce your masterpiece and then you're a master. And then you have the freedom, but not before the compulsion.
- 5.88 That's so useful to know, especially if you're young: enslave yourself voluntarily to something until you master it. And then you become a master of that, and then you can expand from there. It's no different than the presupposition that human beings have to be socialized. Obviously. And is freedom, freedom from? No, that's anarchic, nihilistic, chaotic, counterproductive hedonism aimed at immediate gratification and failure.
- 5.89 This is something that, maybe this is since the '60s. We have this terrible idea, maybe it's since Rousseau, that there's an opposition between principled order and creative expression. It's quite the contrary. They have to be aligned. The more tight the alignment, the more magnificent the creative expression. Everyone who's a master at their craft knows that. Everyone knows that. It's only the pretenders who clamor otherwise because they don't want to do the work. They want to have the freedom, the creative expression, and then they'll destroy merit to get it. "All people's art is the same." That's what everyone who has nothing says.
- 5.90 "But the curious fact is that all there is or has been on earth of freedom, subtlety, boldness, dance, and masterly sureness, whether in thought itself or in government, or in rhetoric and persuasion, in the arts just as in ethics, has developed only owing to the 'tyranny of such capricious laws'; and in all seriousness, the probability is by no means small that precisely this is 'nature' and 'natural'—and not that letting go (with them, not free of fluctuation, multiplicity, and ambiguity). What is essential 'in heaven and on earth' seems to be, to say it once more, that there should be obedience over a long period of time and in a single direction."
- 5.91 You could think of that as—what?—honoring your mother and father. You could think about that as respect for tradition. You could think about that as gratitude for the fact of the patriarchy despite its tyrannical proclivity. We have nothing of that in our culture. To say it once more, "that there should be obedience over a long period of time and in a single direction." The direction could even be arbitrary in the sense that

you can invent a game that's principled, and you can concentrate on playing that, and you can become a master.

- 5.92** It could have been a different game. It doesn't matter because the real action is in the acceptance of a set of limiting principles and the discipline that is developed in consequence of adhering to that. So it's like a meta-stability. Many games. That's even a form of moral relativism. There's many games. There's one meta-game: play some game well. That's the fundamental command: play some game well.
- 5.93** You see this in the story of Buddha. As Buddha moves towards enlightenment, he undergoes a series of disciplinary trials, including asceticism. He starves himself to the point of nothingness before he attains enlightenment. He withdraws from the world. These are disciplinary routines. Why? If you discipline yourself in one direction, you become disciplined. Once you're disciplined, then you can switch your aim, but you've got the discipline at hand. That's the apprenticeship idea.
- 5.94** "Given that, something always develops, and has developed, for whose sake it is worthwhile to live on Earth; for example, virtue, art, music, dance, reason, spirituality—something transfiguring, subtle, mad, and divine." And then Nietzsche does one of these profound reversals that he's always doing. This whole book is a screed, an anti-Christian screed, at least in part. And then he says this.
- 5.95** "The long unfreedom of the spirit, the mistrustful constraint in the communicability of thoughts, the discipline thinkers imposed on themselves to think within the directions laid down by a church or a court or under Aristotelian presuppositions, the long spiritual will to interpret all events under a Christian schema and to rediscover and justify the Christian God in every accident, all this, however forced, capricious, hard, gruesome, and anti-rational, has shown itself to be the means through which the European spirit has been trained to strength, ruthless curiosity, and subtle mobility, though admittedly in the process an irreplaceable amount of strength and spirit had to be crushed, stifled, and ruined (for here, as everywhere, 'nature' manifests herself as she is, in all her prodigal"—prodigal? prodigal—"in all her prodigal and indifferent magnificence, which is outrageous but noble).
- 5.96** "Slavery is, as it seems, both in the cruder and in the more subtle sense, the indispensable means of spiritual discipline and cultivation, too. Consider any morality with this in mind— what there is in it of 'nature' teaches hatred of the letting go, of any all-too-great freedom, and implants the need for limited horizons and the nearest tasks — teaching the narrowing of our perspective, and thus in a certain sense stupidity, as a condition of life and growth.
- 5.97** "You shall obey—someone, and for a long time—else you will perish and lose the last respect for yourself. This appears to be the moral imperative of nature, which, to be sure, is neither 'categorical' as the old Kant would have it (hence the 'else'), nor

addressed to the individual (what do individuals matter to nature?), but to people's races, ages, classes—but above all to the whole human animal, to man."

- 5.98** That had a huge impact on me when I was young, when I read that, because I didn't understand that. I didn't understand that dynamism between discipline and freedom. I didn't understand that principles are enabling principles, if they're properly formulated, more than fences and limitations. You think, "I want to be free." Well, freedom through what? Freedom through discipline, slavery, towards a noble goal. How about that? That's a very different idea than "let it all hang out, baby." That's the '60s mantra. "All" is a lot, and it isn't obvious at all that you want to see it "hang out" in the least. Brilliant.
- 5.99** "Our eye finds it more comfortable to respond to a given stimulus by reproducing once more an image that it has produced many times before, instead of registering what is different and new in an impression." It took psychophysicists, like, 100 years to figure out that this was true. Your visual system, at its lowest level, has more input from your memory than from your eyes. Most of what you see is memory. Why? It's efficient. What's the cost? You see what you expect, instead of what's there.
- 5.100** What's the downside? You replace the wonder, the infinite wonder of the transcendent world, with the narrowness of your own presuppositions. Is it efficient? Yes. Why is it so delightful to have children? Because they remind you of how the world appeared when it was new, and that's the payment they give you for the care that you delivered to them. You can see through their eyes beyond your memory. So he nailed that: "Instead of registering what is different and new in an impression." The latter would require more strength, more morality.
- 5.101** That's why it's so hard to listen. Carl Rogers, a famous clinician, has a great exercise for listening. It's very practical. It's very much worth learning this. It's quite simple. Here's the rule: you listen to someone till they've had their say. Then you tell them what they said, and they have to agree. And so, what's the utility in that? Well, you show you listened, and so that's so good. They're so happy about that because you actually listened. And if you did well, you got it.
- 5.102** But then it's better than that even, because if you talked to me for half an hour, and I tell you what you said, I'm not going to talk to you for half an hour. I'm going to talk to you for, like, six minutes or five minutes. I'm going to sum it up. And that means I'm going to compress everything you said and capture its gist and give it back to you. And if I do that accurately, I've replaced that whole meandering pathway that you took with something efficient, and it's delivered. People love that. There's much less entropy in it. You got to the heart of the matter. You got to the gist.
- 5.103** That also shows that you attended, and they're very happy about that, because when you listen to people, it allows them to unfold and to reconfigure, and they need that desperately. And if you summarize it and they agree, then you've understood what they have to say, and that will also change you. Because the alternative proclivity is,

you're going to say some things I don't agree with, and so, what I'm going to do is, I'm going to bend my interpretation of what you say so that everything that you said that I don't agree with, I paint with the presumption of malevolence or ignore. And that means that I'm not grappling with the essence of what you had to say.

- 5.104** Now, if I require that I represent it to you in a manner that you find acceptable, then I've actually got it. I'll change, and you'll be happy. This is a great thing to do in your negotiations with people, especially with people that you love. "You've got something to tell me? Let's hear it. This is what I think you said. Did I get it right?" Maybe not. Maybe it needs some adjustment. But if I did, at minimum, you understand that your concerns were taken by me with sufficient care, so that I could at least reflect on what you told me.
- 5.105** It doesn't matter; it's not that I necessarily agree, even. But the mere fact that I indicated to you that your concerns were worth my attention, it's going to dispense with, like, 80% of the argument right there. It's great for knowing with regards to, say, customer service. Your customer has got a problem? Try listening. You don't have to defend yourself. You don't even have to agree. If you listen, first of all, they might have a point, and maybe you should know it. Just the fact that you let them tell you will usually, even if they're upset, they'll walk away thinking, "That person tried to address the problem."
- 5.106** The real problem isn't the problem. The problem is that there's a problem and no one's addressing it. If there's a problem and someone's addressing it, maybe it's not even a problem. You can trust that person. That's very much—it's such a good exercise, that listening exercise. "Here's what you said. Do you agree? Did I get it right?" Man, that'll just transform your relationships.
- 5.107** "Hearing something new is embarrassing and difficult for the ear; foreign music we do not hear well. When we hear another language, we try involuntarily to form the sounds we hear into words that sound more familiar and more like home to us; thus the German, for example, transformed 'arcubalista,' when he heard that, into 'Armbrust.' What is new finds our senses, too, hostile and reluctant; and even in the 'simplest' processes, the 'simplest' processes of sensation, the emotions dominate, such as fear, love, hatred, including the passive effects of laziness." I can't tell you how brilliant that is. It took physiologists and psychologists of perception literally 100 years. They really still haven't figured that out. It's so brilliant.
- 5.108** "Just as little as a reader today reads all the individual words (let alone syllables) on a page, rather, he picks about five words at random out of 20 and guesses at the meaning that probably belongs to those five words, just as little do we see a tree exactly and completely with reference to leaves, twigs, color, and form."
- 5.109** This is why we have artists. It's because what do you see when you see a tree? You see a tree that would be on South Park. A stem and a round ball, like a child draws. What

does an artist do? Shows you what's there. Why? To remind you that every phenomenon, that which shines forth, every phenomenon is worthy of attention. That's what artists—that's literally the function they serve. Remember. Remember what's there, instead of what you assume. Much of what we construe is beautiful. We see it because an artist at some point revealed that as beautiful to us, and that became a culturally accepted notion of what constitutes beauty. A landscape, for example. An impressionist landscape, for that matter.

- 5.110** "It is very much easier for us simply to improvise some approximation of a tree." It's exactly how your brain works. "Even in the midst of the strangest experiences, we still do the same. We make up the major part of the experience." That's the dream that Nietzsche was talking about. "And can scarcely be forced not to contemplate some event as its 'inventors.' All this means, basically and from time immemorial is, we are accustomed to lying."
- 5.111** This is why you have to be pristine in your aim, you see. Because if your aims are deceitful, you will automate the perceptions that go along with that deceit, and then you will see the lies that you told yourself in the world. That's literally how it works. When you understand this, you will be much more careful with how you construe your thoughts and your speech. If you practice to deceive, you perceive the world as a domain of lies. I mean perceive. You automate the lies, and then you see them, and then you're done. You're done.
- 5.112** Now, Nietzsche—what?—there's a bit of an incompleteness here. This is not a criticism because what he did was so brilliant. If you automated your perceptions in relationship to the highest of all possible goals, then the increase in efficiency wouldn't come at the cost of deception. So that's why you have to be pristine in your aim, especially if you practice the aim, because you become an expert at it. And as you become an expert at it, you start to see it and not just think it. So, be careful what you practice.
- 5.113** "All this means, basically and from time immemorial, we are accustomed to lying." In a place like the Soviet Union, what was the old joke? "They pretend to pay us. We pretend to work." Every single thing was a lie. Everything people saw, everything they thought, everything they felt, everything they talked about, everything. That's the totalitarian state. A totalitarian state exists when everything has become an automatized lie.
- 5.114** "Or to put it much more virtuously and hypocritically, in short, more pleasantly, one is much more of an artist than one knows. In an age of disintegration that mixes races indiscriminately, human beings have in their body the heritage of multiple origins, that is opposite, and not only merely opposite, drives and value standards that fight each other and rarely permit each other any rest." This is a commentary on the earlier point that Nietzsche made about the problem of morality as such, the question about what constitutes morality as such, if there is even such a thing as morality that occurs when

many moralities are compared, when they make themselves manifested and are compared.

- 5.115** "Opposite, and not often merely opposite, drives and value standards that fight each other and rarely permit each other any rest. Such human beings of late cultures and refracted lights will on the average be weaker human beings; their most profound desire is that the war they are should come to an end. Happiness appears to them, in agreement with a tranquilizing (for example, Epicurean or Christian"—Nietzsche's formulation—"medicine and way of thought, pre-eminently as the happiness of resting, of not being disturbed, of satiety, of finally attained unity, as a 'sabbath of sabbaths,' to speak with the holy rhetorician Augustine, who was himself such a human being."
- 5.116** What's Nietzsche's diagnosis for neurotic suffering? The unresolved war of many competing moral frameworks. Now, there's a bit of pessimism in this, I would say, that's perhaps unjustified. If you can consume and digest that much material and integrate it, so much the better. And so much of what happened in the 20th century has been an attempt not merely to diversify and make a plethora of moral positions, but to compare multiple moralities and integrate across them to approximate some transcendent ideal that unites all of the work of the Jungian school, Carl Jung and his—Mircea Eliade, all of those Joseph Campbell pursuers of the meta-myth, let's say; that's what they were trying to do.
- 5.117** The universities sided with the nihilistic postmodernists and made the assumption that the Nietzschean nihilistic catastrophe was inevitable and correct. Multiple competing moralities, no possibility of higher-order unity. The definition of postmodernism: uniting meta-narratives do not exist. That's the defining characteristic of postmodernism. What does that mean? It can mean the worship of diversity. How diverse do you want to be? You want to be confused about everything? That is not the way forward. That's lost in the desert, that's for sure. That's Nietzsche's point.
- 5.118** Now, he's a little hard on Augustine here, and I think that the Christian solution, voluntary self-sacrifice, the Judeo-Christian solution to the problem of unity, is the correct solution, not the will to power. But Nietzsche certainly got the problem right.
- 5.119** "The highest and strongest drives, when they break out passionately and drive the individual far above the average and the flats of the herd conscience, wreck the self-confidence of the community, its faith in itself, and it is as if its spine snapped. Hence, just these drives are branded and slandered most. High and independent spirituality, the will to stand alone, even a powerful reason, are experienced as dangers. Everything that elevates an individual above the herd and intimidates the neighbor is henceforth called evil; and the fair, modest, submissive, conforming mentality, the mediocrity of desires, attains moral designations and honors."
- 5.120** Eventually, under very peaceful conditions"—the opportunity is the pathology of wealth. That's a useful way of thinking about it. "Eventually, under very"—problem

with being rich when you have children is, how do you provide them with optimal deprivation? When you can say yes to everything, then there's no struggle left. When no is merely arbitrary, how do you impose proper disciplinary boundaries? It's a real conundrum with regards to wealth and abundance. How much privation do you need? The answer to that is: certainly not none. It needs to be optimized. It's a difficult thing to manage under conditions of abundance.

- 5.121** "Eventually, under very peaceful conditions, the opportunity and necessity to educate one's feelings to severity and hardness is lacking more and more; and every severity, even in justice, begins to disturb the conscience. Any high and hard nobility and self-reliance is almost felt to be an insult and arouses mistrust; the 'lamb', even more the 'sheep', gains in respect. There's a point in the history of society when it becomes so pathologically soft and tender that among other things it sides even with those who harm it, criminals, and does this quite seriously and honestly."
- 5.122** That's that extension of pity beyond its proper purview. That's Eve's sin. Eve clutches even the poisonous serpent to her breast. Not wise. Everything can't be brought into the tent. And some fruits are not only inedible but poisonous. "Whoever examines the conscience of the European today will have to pull the same imperative out of a thousand moral folds and hideouts—the imperative of herd timidity. 'We want that some day there should be nothing anymore to be afraid of!' Some day—throughout Europe, the will and way to this day is now called 'progress.'" It's a hell of a thing to write in the 1860s.
- 5.123** "Morality in Europe today is herd-animal morality—in other words, as we understand it, merely one type of human morality, beside which, before which, and after which many other types, above all higher moralities, are or ought to be possible. But this morality resists such a possibility, such an 'ought,' with all its power. It says stubbornly and inexorably, 'I am morality itself, and nothing besides is morality.' Indeed, with the help of a religion," back to the anti-Christian doctrine, "which indulged and flattered the most sublime herd-animal desires, we have reached the point where we find, even in political and social institutions, an ever more visible expression of this morality; the democratic movement is the heir of the Christian movement.
- 5.124** "They are at one in their involuntary plunge into gloom and unmanly tenderness under whose spell Europe seems threatened by a new Buddhism. They are at one in their faith in the morality of shared pity, as if that were morality itself, being the height, the attained height of man, the sole hope of the future, the consolation of present man, the great absolution from all former guilt. They are at one, the lot of them, in their faith in the community as the savior, in short, in the herd, in themselves."
- 5.125** I think his diagnosis with regards to the morality of shared pity was exactly right. That's the idea that compassion is the proper unifying ethos, indiscriminate compassion as the ultimate unifying ethos. That's a form of extreme pathology. I saw this with Nicola Sturgeon, the F Minister of Scotland, when she announced that any man who

proclaimed that he was a woman was a woman. And I thought, "Any man, eh? Any man?" And of course, the first people who took advantage of that were serial sexual sadists. And why wouldn't they?

**5.126** If you're that person repeatedly, and all you have to do is proclaim a new identity and you get untrammelled access to women, you're not going to do that? Why would Nicola Sturgeon not take that into account? Because all criminals are victims. It's like, some criminals are victims. Some are not the people you want to find under your bed. And if you don't know the difference between them, the worst kind will find you out, and then you will have the shock of your life.

**5.127** "The overall degeneration of man down to what today appears to be the socialist dolts and flatheads as their 'man of the future'—as their ideal—this degeneration and diminution of man into the perfect herd animal (or as they say, to the man of the 'free society' ), this animalization of man into the dwarf animal of equal rights and claims, is possible; there's no doubt of it. Anyone who has once thought this possibility through to the end knows one kind of nausea that other men don't know—but perhaps also a new task!"

**5.128** That's a good place to stop. At the end of Part Five, we've got four more parts to go through. We should be able to manage that tomorrow, given that the aphorisms are—what?—rich enough in their singularity to bear whole paragraphs of discussion. And so, we're two-thirds of the way through Beyond Good and Evil, and we'll continue our gazing into the philosophical abyss tomorrow.

**5.129** Dr. Peterson, to what degree, if at all, do you believe that Friedrich Nietzsche's philosophy was directly or partially influenced by Christianity?

**5.130** Well, there's no escaping that influence, because as we discussed yesterday, the Judeo-Christian ethos is coded into the structure of the language, into the structure of perception itself, into the presumption that, of even what constitutes good or what constitutes evil, even that that constitution exists. There's no escaping from it. Now, you can still be unconscious of it and you can be critical of it and you can deny your explicit faith in its presuppositions. But what do they say? No one spends more time thinking about God than a committed atheist. Right, right, right.

**5.131** And there's just no escaping from the problem of good and evil. Unless you're going to, say, forgo any attempt at being social, at treating other people properly, at attending to your own conscience, which is shaped by forces that are way beyond you, hopefully, hopefully— that's the whole point of socialization, so that your conscience is shaped by forces that are beyond you. Man, if you ever run into someone who isn't like that, it's time to get far away from them quickly.

**5.132** And so, I think a large part of the problem is that—and this is part of the problem that Nietzsche was grappling with—is that we don't really understand what it means to believe. It doesn't mean to state a set of propositions. That's a trivial part. Trivial—

that's only a small fragment of what believe means. Believe means "sacrifice for." That's a much better definition, that believe means "act out." Believe means "see through that frame." None of those are propositional. None of that's explicit. And that's a much deeper understanding that indicates much more profoundly what believe means. Believe means to "act out" and to "see with," and we don't understand that well.

- 5.133** When our scientific theories became propositional, we could state them. We assumed that our religious theories were like that. They're not; they're not like that. It's not the same thing. First of all, they're stories and not objective accountings of the nature of the world. They're very different. And a story is, first and foremost, something we enact. A story is the recounting of a drama that we enact; that's what a story is. And the story is primary. And the Western story, "Western," is Judeo-Christian. It's not exactly Western. It came from the Middle East, so it's not exactly Western, but there's no escaping from it.
- 5.134** There's a story at the end of the Exodus adventure where the Israelites are still slaves, and they're bitchy, and they're whining about the tyranny, and about how it was so good back under the thumb of the Pharaoh, and that Moses is nothing but a mad patriarchal powermonger who's only acted in service of his own privilege. That's actually what happens. They get rabby and victimy, and that happens a lot because they're slaves. So they construe themselves as victims continually.
- 5.135** And God gets sick and tired of this, and he sends a bunch of poisonous snakes to bite them. People look at that story, and they think, "That's pretty cruel." It's like, you're missing the point here, people. If you have a bad situation and you have the wrong attitude, you'll make it worse, and there's no limit to how much worse you can make it: all the way down to hell. That's exactly what happens. The situation is kind of dire. The Israelites take the worst possible tack on it, and so things fall apart further. Poisonous snakes.
- 5.136** And so, they're pretty intransigent. They don't learn, which is why the snakes multiply, but finally, they've had enough being bit. And they think, "Moses, he's a pain. He's led us through this bloody desert, and it's all his fault, plus God. But he's got a pipeline to the divine, so we don't have much choice here. We'd better go talk to the prophet and see what's up." So they go to Moses, and they say, "Do you think you could have a chat with God and get him to call off the damn snakes?"
- 5.137** Moses is not very happy with the Israelites, deservedly so. God's thinking about wiping them out, but he decides not to. And Moses goes and intercedes, and he says, "They've learned, your chosen people. Fractious and useless as they are, they've learned. You think you could call off the snakes?" And God says, "Yeah, I don't think so. I don't think I'll call off the snakes, but I'll tell you what I'll do." This is an amazing thing. This is an amazing story. "Get the Israelites to gather up all their bronze and then cast this image." It's a staff. Cast a staff. It's a tree. It's a cross. It's the staff of authority. It's the

magic wand of Gandalf. It's the healing symbol of the physicians, the staff of tradition. It's what you plant when you make a center place around which a cosmos is organized.

- 5.138** "Plant the staff, make it in bronze, and wrap a serpent around it, a poisonous serpent around it." And Moses' magic staff, when he goes to the Pharaoh's court, transforms into a serpent because it's alive, and the serpent can die and be reborn, and it's the serpent that eats all the serpents of the Pharaonic magicians. And so, it's the staff of living tradition. It's a staff, a tree, on which a poisonous serpent is hung.
- 5.139** Now, that's the same symbol that the Greeks used for Asclepius, who's the physician of healing, the staff with the serpent wrapped around it. It's the same symbol that modern physicians use. It's a reference to the word "pharmakon," which means "a little of the poison that kills you makes you resilient," and that's the principle of healing: a little of the poison that kills you makes you resilient, the core of the idea of healing. That's what a vaccine does, when pharmaceutical companies aren't gerrymandering the data.
- 5.140** That's learning because you learn in the face of an obstacle, and what you learn is how to face the obstacle, and simultaneously, how to face obstacles. It's the core of adaptation. And God says to the Israelites, to Moses, "Make it big, and get all the Israelites to line up and look at it. And if they look at it, they'll be immune to the poison." So that's quite the story. It's a very unexpected twist because God could just get rid of the snakes, and it's deep beyond imagining.
- 5.141** But that's not where it ends, that story. And this is impossible to account for, as far as I'm concerned, but it's definitely true. So, Christ says in the Gospels, thousands of years later, that unless he's lifted up like the brazen serpent in the desert, there'll be no hope for the redemption of man. Now, first of all, that's a very weird thing for anyone to say, and it's a very weird reference, and it's not obvious why anyone would apply that to themselves. And it's certainly not obvious across that gap of time. So there's something to account for there.
- 5.142** So why? Why, why, why, why say that? What does that mean? So now you imagine that there's a poisonous serpent. And then imagine that you wanted to understand the most poisonous of all possible serpents. So you wanted to make that into a principle, not a poison snake as such, but the principle of what's poisonous itself, and you wanted to immunize yourself against that. Well, the way the Exodus Israelites did that was by looking at the snake. OK, that's how exposure works in psychotherapy. By the way, that's how we learn; we expose ourselves to things we're afraid of, and we adapt.
- 5.143** What's the worst of all possible poisonous serpents? The answer to that question was partly thought through by the association of the serpent in the Garden of Eden with Satan. What's the worst of all poisonous serpents? It's not a snake. It's not a poisonous snake. Maybe it's the class of all poisonous snakes. No, it's the class of all predators. No, it's the predator in your enemy's heart. No, it's the predator in your heart. Down

the rabbit hole. So if you want to deal with the class of all that's poisonous, that's where you start with. That's lurking in the background, that idea.

- 5.144** What's the crucifix? The crucifix occupies the same place in Judeo-Christian culture as the brazen serpent did for the Israelites. It's an image to gaze upon. Why? Because it's the sum total of everything that's poisonous. It's the sum total of everything that's poisonous. And so, what did we do unconsciously in our dream? We took the most unjust and violent conceivable death, and we made it the central figure of our attention, and we put it at the middle of our towns, not knowing why. Predicated on the idea that if you gazed voluntarily on the worst of all possible sights, it would transform you and make you resilient.
- 5.145** Try escaping from that. Once you understand that and you see that connection, the first thing you think is: Who made that connection? That's just—with a 3,000-year gap. And then when you understand the logical association there, and you understand that that's the conceptual web behind that utterance, and you see how that was enacted in—what?—the transformation of pagan Rome and Greece, the whole pagan world, into the Christian world, that voluntary acceptance of the necessity of contending with what's most poisonous as the basis of community, there's no escaping from that, not that I can see.
- 5.146** Are even those who oppose Christianity shaped by it? There's something so deep there that it defines humanity itself. Community is a sacrificial process, obviously. You give up something to be part of a community. You're not part of a community if you're not giving something up. If it's about you, it's not a community. The sacrifice is the foundation of the community. What's the highest form of sacrifice? That's the next question. The sacrifice of everything upward. What's everything? Everything, eh? Brutal. There's no escaping from that. That's why I think, fundamentally, Nietzsche was wrong.
- 5.147** Now, interestingly, wrong; wrong in a way that wouldn't have allowed this sort of knowledge to emerge, had the questions not been posed, and posed like—I always thought of Nietzsche, it's a terrible analogy, but he's like maggots in a wound. That's part of the process of cleaning. It's a terrible process, but he was a very useful critic. Try another question?
- 5.148** What, if anything, do you think Nietzsche would be pleased by or surprised by today?
- 5.149** I think he'd be certainly pleased by the fact that his writings lived. I don't remember how many copies of *Beyond Good and Evil* he distributed. It was like dozens, none. He had been radically successful as a young scholar, but he hadn't been radically successful as a writer. And so, I'm sure it would be a miraculous revelation to him, how much impact his work had and how much it spawned. He knew he was onto something, and that must have been terrible, but pleased?

- 5.150 All the catastrophes that he thought were likely have not yet come to pass. I mean, there was a totalitarian wave, and it still exists, but it hasn't dominated. The nihilistic tendency hasn't got the upper hand. We haven't degenerated completely into hedonistic idiocy. There's a counterposition that still exists, and so I think he would be pleased about that.
- 5.151 I think he would probably be pleased, too, to see that so much of what he predicted was accurate and supported by deep investigation, like his theories of perception, for example, his theories of motivation. They're head and shoulders above. They were so far ahead of their time—they're still ahead of their time. It's so remarkable.
- 5.152 And I think maybe he would be pleased that his central presumption, that the will to power was the proper uniting force, was wrong, and that there were scholars, who certainly aren't mainstream scholars; they certainly don't dominate the universities. Camille Paglia, that literary critic, Camille is a very smart woman, she told me that had the academy turned to Jung and Eliade and that school instead of the postmodernists, that the whole culture war would have—well, there wouldn't have been a culture war. The postmodernists had it wrong, and the psychoanalytic heirs of Nietzsche had it right, have it right still.
- 5.153 Would he be pleased about that? I think so. Because you see this weird ambiguity in Nietzsche where he's viciously anti-Christian. You see that continually in his criticisms of, especially, this strain of Christianity, so to speak, that valorized pity. He was right about that. But then he wrote things that we read, about the fact that the insistence upon interpreting everything within the unified Christian framework was part of what disciplined the modern mind and made it flexible and able to pursue other pathways of truth. I think he'd be pleased that there's a reconciliation pending with regard to that conundrum. That's my sense.
- 5.154 Jung, Carl Jung, who solved a lot of the problems that Nietzsche put, that's really what Jung did, I would say. Jung, although he was very influenced by Freud and the notions of the unconscious, Jung spent his whole life trying to address the question that Nietzsche posed. Is it possible to transvalue all values, and on what basis would a higher-order morality be founded? I think he got it fundamentally right.
- 5.155 And he was struggling toward—clearer than Nietzsche, still opaque, clearer than Nietzsche—that the principle of voluntary self-sacrifice is the proper foundation of the world. It's never formulated that clearly, but you can see it struggling upward toward realization in image in dream. That's part of the hero myth.

## Lecture 6: Thinking and Action

At a glance — Thinking and action, after five parts of the book.

- 6.1 So, we've walked through five parts of this complex book, this complex, dense book, *Beyond Good and Evil*, full of paradoxical commentary on human beings and psychoanalytic insights and revolutionary groundwork laid for revolutions in psychology with regard to perception. We have four more parts to wander through.
- 6.2 So, part of the mythology of evil is the strain that you might regard as Luciferian. You see this in the Judeo-Christian tradition with the association of the serpent who tempts Eve to usurp and establish moral predominance. You see that with the association between that serpent, which is a snake, clearly, in the Old Testament story, or a symbolic snake, and Satan, which is a very weird association. Why those are the same thing is not obvious.
- 6.3 But we talked about that a little bit yesterday, about the fact that the human mind has been attempting to calculate, you could say, the essence of malevolent predation. And so, some of that manifests itself as actual predators in the world, poisonous snakes being perhaps the cardinal symbolic element of that. But then there's a metaphysic of malevolent predation that requires a more in-depth philosophical analysis. What is it? And how do you position yourself, so that you're immune to its temptations? Insanely complicated problem.
- 6.4 You see the same thing occurring in the metaphysical realm with the problem of the unknown as such. The unknown is the domain of danger as such. And you could imagine making strategic plans to deal with a particular danger, but you could imagine making a meta-strategic plan that deals with the class of all possible dangers. And hero mythology is really an attempt to formulate a permanent solution to the problem of the unknowable as such. So the religious enterprise, one of the ways of conceptualizing it, is that it attempts to go to the bottom of a problem to lay out the universals of the problem and then the universals of the solution.
- 6.5 The representation of malevolence as Luciferian has a very specific meaning. So, Lucifer is the light-bringer, and in the Miltonic representation, Lucifer is the heavenly spirit who flew the highest and went most wrong. And so, the idea there, the poetic idea, Milton tried to write his great poem, *Paradise Lost*, to justify the ways of God to man. That's an unbelievable high-level ambition. We talked yesterday about Nietzsche's notion that a great man was the actor of his own ideal. That was Milton's goal, and so what does that mean, to justify the ways of God to man? It means something like, to provide a poetic justification for the catastrophe of life, for all of life's suffering, to put that in a frame that makes it make sense or more, become acceptable. No higher goal than that, really, and Milton nailed it.

- 6.6** Now, Lucifer is the light-bringer, and so he's the spirit of illumination, and that associates him with the intellect. It's the intellect—you could say that these fundamental subpersonalities that characterize human beings have the proclivity, as Nietzsche said, to philosophize in their own spirit, but also to emerge as dominant. And as soon as they emerge as dominant, they're pathological. If you're dominated by aggression, the aggression is pathological. If you're dominated by sexuality, the sexuality is pathological. If you're dominated by your intellect, the intellect becomes pathological.
- 6.7** So, when the intellect attempts to usurp, which is how Milton conceptualized the rebellion of Lucifer in heaven, it's the attempt of the intellect to usurp. You can see echoes of that in the Genesis story. Eve wants to extend her knowledge. She wants to master the domain of good and evil. She wants to establish the moral order. And so, the underlying symbolic notion in Genesis is that something tempts her in that direction—and it's not exactly her. Your intelligence isn't exactly you. It's not like you created it.
- 6.8** There's an association of it with pride as well. I saw this in my clients often. It was very characteristic, and you can see this in our culture at large. There's nothing more resentful than someone who's intelligent and who's been celebrated for that intelligence, maybe particularly when they were a child, who hasn't managed to transform that into true status and accomplishment, because there's this resentment that goes along with it. "I'm so smart. Why aren't people—why isn't everything coming to me in consequence of that?" Well, smart is one thing, although that's a gift and a talent and nothing to be proud about, like it's something that you've been granted.
- 6.9** But intelligence alone isn't sufficient to make you successful. It's a good predictor of success. But conscientiousness, the ability to work hard, creativity, honesty, reputation, there's lots of other—luck, social connections, there's lots of other things that matter. But there's this pride. It's like, intellect has this immense tendency to become possessed by pride and to assume a kind of moral, like a right to moral and social predominance. That's partly what Nietzsche is going after in relationship to the academics.
- 6.10** It's also something that makes the universities pathological. One of the things I really noticed when I worked for the University of Toronto, for example, I had a fair bit of dealings with the business school, and I taught there, part of their executive MBA program. My colleagues were not happy with me because I was working with the business school. I thought, "What the hell is wrong with you people?" What—are these people your enemies because they're in the business school? What's going on here? It took me a long time to dig to the bottom of that. There was a malicious envy in it. What was the envy?
- 6.11** Part of the reason that university professors tend to be radicals and to promote that among their students is because they're annoyed that they don't make as much money

as investment bankers. "We're so smart. Why don't we have all the money?" Well, it's because you have a completely protected career with many walls around you, allowing yourself the freedom to pursue your intellectual pursuits. That's a pretty good deal. You want more than that? "Well, those other people have more."

**6.12** I've been reading some psychological research that's been published lately on support for income redistribution. So that's like the core of, you might say, the socialist ethos. They looked at various predictors: concern about fairness; we could measure psychometrically whether people are actually concerned about fairness as part of their ethical structure. Compassion, whether they're compassionate. And then three kinds of envy, one of which is malicious envy.

**6.13** Malicious envy is like sadism. It's the delight I would take in someone I regard as privileged in a manner that I'm not failing. Malicious envy. Malicious envy is the best predictor of support for income redistribution. Fairness doesn't even enter into it. Compassion does to some degree, and I think that's the proclivity of the naive compassionate, to assume that the oppressed are victims in consequence of their lower status and that victims are moral, like infants are moral. It's naive foolishness. Some people who are struggling at the bottom of the socioeconomic hierarchy have had terrible circumstances. Obviously, there's some compassion that's necessary in those situations, but as Nietzsche points out continually, don't be thinking that misplaced pity is a virtue. It's not.

**6.14** That's Ursula in *The Little Mermaid*. Ursula is the dark witch that usurps the king and traps his soul and deprives the young woman of her voice. That's misplaced pity. Jesus, brutal. We know this symbolically. We can portray it in movies like *The Little Mermaid*, for example, or in *Snow White and Sleeping Beauty*, but we're not wise enough to make it fully somatic. Now, Nietzsche was an astute observer of the resentful intellect, the resentful, narrowed, herd-like intellect. And so, his commentary is very relevant for understanding the situation in today's universities.

**6.15** "Indeed, the crowd has for a long time misjudged and mistaken the philosopher, whether for a scientific man and ideal scholar or for a religiously elevated, desensualized, desecularized enthusiast and sot of God. And if a man is praised today for living 'wisely' or 'as a philosopher,' it hardly means more than 'prudently and apart.' Wisdom seems to the rabble a kind of escape, a means and trick for getting well out of a wicked game. But the genuine philosopher—as it seems to us, my friends—lives 'unphilosophically' and 'unwisely,' above all imprudently, and feels the burden and the duty of 100 attempts and temptations of life. He risks himself constantly; he plays the wicked game."

**6.16** So what's Nietzsche's point here? The practice of philosophy is something more like an aesthetic drama, rather than an abstracted intellectual exercise, something that's lived out as a drama. Socrates would be a good example of that because Socrates went to his death in consequence of pursuing his philosophy. And so, this is part of the romantic

attractiveness of the Nietzschean perspective, and also his insistence that the idea that the world of abstraction in itself was insufficient to constitute proper philosophy, that it was something that had to be embodied and acted out and dramatized.

- 6.17** That's part of the ground out of which the notion of existentialism emerged, the philosophical notion of existentialism, the pursuit of meaning in action, rather than in mere abstraction. So, this is philosopher-as-artist, I suppose, or as dramatist. Well, Nietzsche is really the poster boy for that, and he attracts people of a romantic temperament because of that.
- 6.18** "Compared to a genius—and that is to one who either begets or gives birth, taking both terms in their most elevated sense—the scholar, the scientific average man, always rather resembles an old maid. Like her, he is not conversant with the two most valuable functions of man. Indeed, one even concedes to both, to the scholars and to old maids, as it were by way of a compensation that they are respectable— one stresses their respectability—and yet feels annoyed all over at having to make this concession."
- 6.19** You see actually a temperamental contradiction here. So, Nietzsche was a very strange person. He was, I think, the earliest—so the German universities were dominant at the time of Nietzsche, around the world. They were the preeminent universities. Nietzsche was the youngest full professor that was ever hired. Very young, 23, 24, something like it, unheard of, unheard of. And he's a very strange academic.
- 6.20** I did a series of studies at the University of Toronto, looking at what predicted graduate school performance, and then later, scientific eminence, tracked by number of citations, essentially. We talked about that before. The more cited you are by other people, the more impact your work has. We don't really know a better way of measuring the quality of scientific contribution than citation count.
- 6.21** Now, it's tricky because the world's most cited scholar is Michel Foucault, so that tells you something about the state of the world. More than anyone else, more than Darwin, more than Freud, Michel Foucault. My god, a malevolent Satanist, Michel Foucault. And there's a man whose motivational drives shaped his philosophy, the man who raped young boys in graveyards. That's bloody Michel Foucault. If you don't think that colored his philosophy, you haven't read him very carefully or thought much about those who admire him.
- 6.22** We found that openness, which is trait creativity, was correlated negatively with graduate school and early scientific eminence. Negatively. And we found, too, that at the University of Toronto, openness, creativity, had zero relationship with grades. Zero. Now, we took into account IQ, which predicts grades, because grades and IQ are both a measure of general cognitive ability. And conscientiousness mattered. So if you're smart and you just grind away, that gets you a long way, virtually everywhere.
- 6.23** Openness is a weirder dimension. It's the creativity dimension, and Nietzsche is staggeringly open. That's why his thought flashes in so many diverse directions. He's

not a systematic thinker. And so, the academic enterprise seems to be defined by—there's the herd mentality aspect, the camouflage in the herd that Nietzsche talked about. There's the Luciferian pretension. That's a terrible thing. But then there's also the proclivity of the academic enterprise to push out anyone who is, let's say, the radical genius, and to replace that with a kind of incrementalism, like a managerial incrementalism.

**6.24** Now, there's some advantage to that. It's worth understanding this. Part of the advantage of science is that people who aren't geniuses can do it. It's a method, and so you can apply it as a method. Basically, the essence of the scientific method is to lay out a problem and to formulate two solutions to the problem, each of which differs only by one thing, and then systematically test the effect of that thing. And so, that's the essence of the scientific method, and you can get a long way with that method without being a genius. And so, the fact that it's been routinized and industrialized in a way has some advantages, but it does put people like Nietzsche, who are creative beyond comprehension, into a very odd position.

**6.25** But the other thing you've got to understand, too, to give the devil his due, is that it's very hard for institutions to deal with creative people. How do you evaluate someone who's creative? You can't. If your evaluation system captures what they're doing, they're not very creative. The creative person, almost always by definition, stands outside the institutional enterprise, because everything within the institutional enterprise has been automated and regularized and instrumentalized and laid out as an algorithm.

**6.26** And so, how the hell do you get an institution that values creativity? I don't think it's possible. The artist, the philosopher, in Nietzsche's terms as well, is always going to have to stand outside. Now, the advantage to that, the disadvantage to that is, try making your way alone. That's hard. The advantage is, you're outside, you're free. So openness, creativity, is a high-risk, high-return strategy.

**6.27** Now, Nietzsche wasn't very happy about that because he was an uneasy fit with institutions. And his thought was so prolific and so creative that academia, they just had no idea what to do with him. And he makes a case for this like a dancing genius, and fair enough, but there's something to be said for routinization as well. It's a balance always in an institution, because you need the managerial types, you need the conscientious types to systematize and to evaluate and to keep track of and to note.

**6.28** And that works all well and good when the pathway is laid down properly. But the underlying environment shifts with time, and so then you need creative people to say, "That was working, but now it doesn't." And of course, that's very annoying to all the systematizers. But it's not like the systematizer types, the managerial types, are wrong. It's just that they're wrong sometimes. And so, again, that's why free speech is so necessary. It's like, we've routinized this, but it isn't working. We have to talk about at what level this has to be shifted. Every organization has to negotiate this tension

between the algorithmic processes that make it predictable and routine and implementable, and the leaps that keep it new when things have changed.

- 6.29** Mostly, that happens by having institutions die. The typical Fortune 500 company lasts 30 years. The typical family fortune, three generations. Generally, what happens is it's creative destruction. You just have to let things die, and then new things emerge. Part of the reason the United States is such a remarkable place is because you've got these 50 states, all of which are running little local experiments, and American capitalism will let failed institutions die. Can they be saved? Sometimes, not often.
- 6.30** "If love and hatred are wanted from him—I mean love and hatred is God, woman, and animal understand them—he will do what he can and give what he can." This is the modern scholar again. "But one should not be surprised if it's not much— if just here he proves inauthentic, fragile, questionable, and worm-eaten."
- 6.31** You can understand why he might not have been that popular with his academic colleagues. Although Nietzsche, in the town he lived in near the end of his life, they called him "the saint" because he treated everyone he came into contact with so well. It was a marked part of his reputation. And he had a very complex love life. It was never very successful. And so, now and then in his writing, you can see some peevishness, so to speak, emerge in relationship to women. But he was a very lonely person and very ill, and so a little understanding is probably in order.
- 6.32** "His love is forced, his hatred artificial and rather 'un tour de force,' a little vanity and exaggeration. After all, he is genuine only insofar as he may be objective. Only in his cheerful 'totalism' he is still 'nature' and 'natural.' His mirror soul, eternally smoothing itself out, no longer knows how to affirm or negate." He can't say no or yes, really. Yes is full commitment. No is like, I'm not moving. And anything that's just abstracted, especially as a show or part of herd camouflage, has no natural force or charisma in it. "He does not know how to affirm or negate. He does not command, neither does he destroy."
- 6.33** I think part of the tension between the working class, especially working-class men, and intellect, is this exactly, this tension between what's abstracted and what's embodied. The intellectual men are often leery of working-class men and also afraid of them; and the working-class men have a certain amount of suspicion and contempt for the intellectual types. I think it's because of a separation of embodiment, in part.
- 6.34** One of the things I heard about Trump, which was quite interesting—I don't remember who said this—is that Trump can talk to soldiers. Very few politicians can do that because the soldiers make them nervous. It's like, the politicians live in this world of abstraction, whereas the soldiers put their lives on the line for their commitments, and so they're really in that. And so, they get—what?—they feel insecure, the politicians, insecure around the soldiers, and then they mask that with a façade of intellectual superiority. That's a very common thing for intellectual men to do to working-class

men, and it doesn't work out well. The working-class men, they can see through that in a second, and they're not happy about it.

- 6.35** Trump spent a lot of time on construction sites and actually involved in the details of construction, and so he doesn't have that barrier with the working class. It's also partly what makes him very popular with working-class people. It's very interesting to see, because it's so funny, too, because the Labour leader types like Keir Starmer, you see this in Canadian socialists, too, it's like, there's nothing more contemptible to the typical working-class man than a middle-class intellectual socialist, something George Orwell commented on as well. There's definitely truth in that.
- 6.36** You saw this, too, with the student radicals in the 1960s, when they were trying to formulate an alliance with the hard hats, with the working-class types. That just never went anywhere because the working-class guys—this included the bikers, because the lefties tried to make an alliance with the bikers, too. That didn't go very well. That caused the death at Altamont, at the Rolling Stones concert. But that's where they say the 1960s died, at Altamont. It's because the rough working-class guys can see through that intellectual pretension in a second and have nothing but contempt for it.
- 6.37** "After all, he is genuine only insofar as he may be objective." Nietzsche didn't exactly like this notion of objective, partly because it's abstracted, and it's in subjectivity that there's commitment. And so, he thought of that stance of objectivism as kind of bloodless, and there's definitely something to that. "Only in his cheerful 'totalism' he is still 'nature' and 'natural.' His mirror soul, eternally smoothing itself out, no longer knows how to affirm or negate." No will to stupidity; that's the lack on the affirmation side. "He does not command, neither does he destroy. 'I despise almost nothing,' he says with Leibniz; one should not overlook and underestimate that *presque*."
- 6.38** Yeah, see, Nietzsche was trying to speak here to something like an integrated commitment to basic principles, that it wasn't merely an intellectual enterprise, it was an enterprise that should involve the emotions, that should integrate the emotions. That's part of what makes it romantic and compelling. But then that the integration between the intellect and the emotion should find its expression in embodiment, so that it's—that philosophy, the philosophy of true commitment, makes itself manifest in a pattern of life and not a system of thought.
- 6.39** I think the problem with that, as far as I'm concerned, is that, first of all, it can get warped and demented into something like a pursuit of social justice as an intellectual enterprise. That happens. The problem with the notion of intellectual enterprises embodied is that, if it's not funded on the right principles, then that goes badly astray, as well; and then you have the spectacle, for example, of the universities deviating from their intellectual enterprise and turning into propagandistic social justice, promoting full religions. That's really the right—Nietzsche's perspective is correct, but the aim has to be right, and will to power, so to speak, it's not the right aim.

- 6.40 "Our Europe of today, being the arena of an absurdly sudden attempt at a radical mixture of classes, and hence races, is therefore skeptical in all its heights and depths." This is a reflection, again, of what we talked about yesterday, the fact that a culture that's united in an ethos has a confidence and a power that is a reflection of that union. When it expands and attempts to integrate more than it can digest—and this is the conservative objection to too-rapid immigration—then what happens is, you get fragmentation at the social level because no one knows what anyone else is up to.
- 6.41 We know that relatively homogenous societies—let's say, culturally, ethnically, racially—relatively homogenous societies are much more likely; they're not all high-trust societies, but most high-trust societies are relatively homogenous. Now, you don't want them to be entirely homogenous because then they stultify, and we don't exactly know how to compute the right balance. Some novelty should be introduced into the system continually.
- 6.42 Canada, at the moment, let in 800,000 immigrants in the first three months. They're on track to bring in as many immigrants into Toronto this year as there live in Canada's biggest city, in Toronto. And these are immigrants, generally speaking, from radically different cultures, including Communist China, which is not only a radically different culture, but one that's pathological to the core. It's like, some novelty is good. At what point do you get—this is what Nietzsche was concerned about, "being the arena of an absurdly sudden attempt at a radical mixture of classes"? I'm sure this is what happened to Rome. "Is therefore skeptical in all its heights and depths." What should we believe? There's no uniting central ethos. Justin Trudeau announced that Canada had no national identity.
- 6.43 The Europeans are playing with exactly the same idea. I've been to the Netherlands. The Dutch intellectuals that I met, not particularly progressive or radical, the intellectuals I met, they proclaimed, along with their countrymen, that the Netherlands had no real culture. It's a shocking thing for someone from Canada to see. When I go to Amsterdam, you people have no culture? I don't know where that leaves us in Canada. But the reason that that's—and you see this in the UK, too, in this post-empire malaise that possesses the UK. This intermingling of too many ideas, undigested ideas, confuses.
- 6.44 "Sometimes with that mobile skepticism which leaps impatiently and lasciviously from branch to branch, sometimes dismal like a cloud overcharged with question marks—and often mortally sick of its will." The postmodernists, I told you yesterday, the postmodernist claim is there's no uniting meta-narrative. That's the defining characteristic of postmodernism. It's a very weird claim because unions exist at multiple levels.
- 6.45 There are ways that you're united as a body. There's the ways that you're fragmented as a warring ground of motivational states. There might be a way that you're united with your family, but also a way that that family is fragmented. Everything that we

perceive as an entity is united by an identity. So, to make an—to decide arbitrarily that there's some level in the hierarchy of unity where no unity exists is a pathological claim. The idea that there's no uniting meta-narrative means that there's nothing that beckons on the psychological front except an internal conflict, and there's no way of bringing people together socially.

- 6.46** Now, if you were naive and foolish, you'd think, "Diversity reigns." But if you had any wisdom at all, you'd note that there's no difference between diversity and war. War is diversity taken to its logical conclusion. And so, I'm saying that, knowing that some novelty is good. The question is how much? Nietzsche's warning is that if you bite off more than you can chew and you're unable to digest it, then you're going to be confused, and that will fragment your will.
- 6.47** I've noticed this with people, and something very worthwhile thinking through. My ability to stop you from what you are intending is proportional to the doubts that war within you. If you're fragmented, imagine that you're fragmented enough so you've made a decision to move forward, but 55% of you is on board, and 45% isn't. This happens in families, too. It's like, we'll do it, but begrudgingly. If it's 55-45, I just have to apply 5% of pressure to you, and you're stopped. And so, if you're not united in your—this is part of Nietzsche point with regards to the fragmented academics—if you're not united in your aim, it takes very little external opposition to stop you. Because all you have to do is, if it's 51-49, and that's the basis on which you're moving forward, plagued with doubts, all I have to do is add a few more doubts, and you're done.
- 6.48** That isn't what you want. You want everything in you aimed in the same direction. That's that unity that the postmodernists deny. How is it that you could unite everything within you in the same direction? A very difficult, very difficult question. But the alternative is "paralysis of the will—where today does not one find this cripple sitting? And often in such finery!" The other thing that's very much worth knowing is that if you have opinion A and opinion B and opinion C, and they're warring within you in relationship to a goal, so you're possessed by doubt and confused, the emotional consequence of that confusion is anxiety.
- 6.49** Anxiety actually indexes, you could say, unresolved complexity. Anxiety is a measure of entropy. Anxiety is the emotion that indexes uncertainty. And so, if you're in internal war because you haven't sorted out the conflicts between the puppet masters behind the scenes, you might say, then that will make itself manifest in an excess of negative emotion. That's an exaggeration of trait neuroticism.
- 6.50** We can see this in popular culture now. What is it—55%, it's something like that—55% of liberal women, progressive, let's say, between the ages of 18 and 34, have at least one diagnosed mental disorder. Why? Well, diversity, let's say, is a plethora of possibility, but how much diversity can you cope with? When you're going to make a decision and move forward, if there's six ideas competing in relationship to that goal,

you're weak, you're confused, you're anxious, your enthusiasm is attenuated, you're a house divided against itself.

- 6.51** "Paralysis of the will—where today does not one find this cripple sitting? And often in such finery! How seductive the finery looks! This disease enjoys the most beautiful pomp—and lie—costumes; and most of what today displays itself in the showcases, for example, as 'objectivity,' 'being scientific,' 'art for art's sake,' 'pure knowledge, free of will,' is merely dressed-up skepticism and paralysis of the will; for this diagnosis of the European sickness, I vouch."
- 6.52** That's the other thing to understand. This research that I just described, that lays out the role of malicious envy in—what?— the radical insistence for wealth distribution, is camouflaged with the façade of concern for the poor. It's moral covering, shadow pathology underneath, malicious envy actually driving the requirement. And so, what's Nietzsche's point here?
- 6.53** Unresolved pathology will camouflage itself in the highest order of morality. Yeah, that's exactly it. That's the Phariseism that Christ pointed to when he criticized the Pharisees in particular for being whitewashed sepulchres, for proclaiming moral virtue while pursuing nothing but their malicious self-interest. And if you're naive, the thing is, if you're naive, you believe the cover story, even if you're telling it.
- 6.54** "The sickness of the will is spread unevenly over Europe. It appears strongest and most manifold where culture has been at home longest; it disappears to the extent to which the 'barbarian' still—or again—claims his rights under the loose garments of Western culture. In France today, the will is accordingly most seriously sick, which is as easy to infer as it is palpable." It was France that the postmodern movement emerged. "And France, having always possessed a masterly skill at converting even the most calamitous turns of its spirit into something attractive and seductive, now really shows its cultural superiority over Europe by being the school and display of all the charms of skepticism."
- 6.55** Yeah, he definitely got that right. "It disappears to the extent to which the 'barbarian' still—or again—claims his rights." Just after World War I, Jung had a series of visionary dreams about the return of the spirit he described as Odin or Wotan. It's like the spirit of Germanic barbarism. He had a dream that Europe was flooded with blood. This was just before the dawn of the Nazi movement. It's so interesting because the Nazi movement, which was extremely motivationally potent, aesthetically as well, because the Nazis were masters at fascist aesthetics, masters, something that George Orwell commented on and warned against, there was a style to it.
- 6.56** From Jung's perspective, that was the reemergence of the barbarian, the German barbarian, who was—what would you say?—had an attractiveness. It's like the attractiveness of the mafia don in movies. There's this attractiveness of that willingness to use force, let's say, in the service of a goal that was—what? It was something

unconsciously admired by the weak-willed, pitying hedonists who confused their cowardice with morality. "I would never use force." It's like, no, you can't. You're too afraid.

- 6.57** There's a great movie, *Cabaret*, that's very much worth watching. It was filmed in the 1970s, and it's about this Cluster B woman, narcissistic and borderline to the core. Liza Minnelli played her, a quasi-prostitute who ends up suicidal, purposefully suicidal by the end of the movie. She's pursuing fame and hedonistic self-gratification. She works at this cabaret that's full of trans displays, interestingly enough. It's the Weimar Republic in the 1930s, when Berlin was ridden with sexual display, hedonistic sexual display.
- 6.58** And it's such an interesting movie. It's so well done because you have these hedonistic narcissists on the one hand at the cabaret, celebrating their sexual licentiousness and freedom. And then you have the Nazis peppered in the audience. And you can see the Nazi rise throughout the movie. And you can see this character. There's a character who plays the Master of Ceremonies. The Master of Ceremonies is like the director. He's the behind-the-scenes director. Joel Grey is the actor. He's a Luciferian character, orchestrating things behind the scenes.
- 6.59** You can see these weak, hedonistic, resentful hedonists, radically immature, inviting the Nazis in, because there's part of them that wants—they're so anxiety-ridden as a consequence of their excess diverse tolerance, let's say, too many things going on in too many directions, there's a part of them that's crying out for a hand that says, "One thing only." And you can see in this movie, *Cabaret*, this dance between the hedonists and the tyrants, and the mutual attraction that each of them has for each other.
- 6.60** Not least because part of the reason the tyrant wants power is to allow his hedonistic whims full rein. "The only reason I need power over you is to get you to do something you wouldn't do voluntarily for me." And so, there's always a dance between the tyrant and the hedonist. That's all part of that malaise out of which the Nazi movement grew, that longing of the utterly unconstrained for the iron-fisted hand of the uni-dimensional tyrant. Whenever you go too far in one direction, the other direction beckons; and the farther you've gone in the wrong direction, the more what beckons is the worst manifestation of the other extreme. Terrifying.
- 6.61** "Genuine philosophers, however, are commanders and legislators. They say, 'Thus it shall be!' They first determine the whither and why of man, and in so doing have at their disposal the preliminary labor of all philosophical laborers, all who have overcome the past. With a creative hand, they reach for the future, and all that is and has been becomes a means for them, an instrument, a hammer. Their 'knowing' is creating; their creating is a legislation. Their will to truth is," there we go, "will to power. Are there such philosophers today? Have there been such philosophers yet? Must there not be such philosophers?"

- 6.62 Nietzsche's insistence that a human being should be integrated in thought, emotion, and action is a valid point, and his criticism of the bloodlessness of the abstracted intellectual is accurate. But there was a branch of Nietzschean philosophy that got pulled up and utilized by the fascists. And it's not that surprising, because this will-to-power idea is the wrong uniting ethos.
- 6.63 And you see this—I mentioned this before, but I'm going to mention it again: Tolkien's work, *The Lord of the Rings*, he has this idea that there were a sequence of rings of power—or rings of magical capacity, and that they were united under the ring of power. The ring of power was seductive and warping and was the magical uniting ethos that could pull together. But what it pulled together was everything that was dark. That's the problem with the will-to-power philosophy. What exactly do you mean by will to power?
- 6.64 That's what the fascists used. Soon after Nietzsche's death, his sister took over his writings. She had a pronounced fascist leaning. It was through his sister's work that the Nazis pulled elements of Nietzsche's thought and used it to undergird the fascist movement, but the seeds of it were there. With Nietzsche's emphasis on nobility and aristocracy, and his insistence that the democratizing proclivity of Christianity was nothing but slave morality, and with his insistence that we had to create our own values, there's something very Luciferian about all that. That was what made itself manifest, at least in part, in the ability and willingness of the Nazis to use the Nietzschean philosophy for their own purposes—and the romanticism that went along with it as well, that integration of art and spectacle.
- 6.65 Hitler was really the first politician who had a magnified electronic voice. That's something very interesting to contemplate. He was a human-machine hybrid of the first sort. And they were remarkable at spectacle, and that's part of that integration of philosophy with emotion and action, but you can see the danger in that when it goes sideways. At Nuremberg, they built these huge grounds where hundreds of thousands of people could gather in perfect order, these square arrays of people, these massive political displays. And Hitler was on stage at night with the anti-aircraft lighting, those spotlights that the air force used to identify planes in the sky, arrayed behind them, a curtain of light like half a mile high behind him. Fire everywhere. The uniforms designed by Hugo Boss, the Nazi uniforms. This incredible spectacle.
- 6.66 That's part of the union of this philosophy, this intellectual philosophy, with emotion and with action. But if it's the wrong uniting ethos—that would be the ring of power, let's say, that Tolkien warned against— that goes very dreadfully wrong. There's great danger in Nietzsche's thought, as well as great possibility.
- 6.67 "Today, conversely, when only the herd animal receives and dispenses honors in Europe, when 'equality of rights,'" this could be written today, "could all too easily be changed into equality in violating rights, I mean, into a common war on all that is rare,

strange, privileged, the higher man, the higher soul, the higher duty, the higher responsibility, and the abundance of creative power and masterfulness—"

- 6.68** So, that's a prediction of the emergent war on merit. If you want to usurp, if you want to gain privilege and power for yourself without making the sacrifices or doing the work, the most effective way to do that is to criticize the idea of merit itself, to muddy the waters so that merit becomes oppression and that success becomes theft. That justifies a theft that benefits yourself and the destruction of everything that's meritorious. That's what Nietzsche is pointing out.
- 6.69** This is the part of Christianity that he was afraid of, that valorization of resentful victimhood that's part of malicious envy. He was very afraid of that. And there was a strain of Christianity—I think it's a heresy, essentially. It's a deviation or—what? It's an inversion of genuine Christianity that has that Marxist element, all the liberation theology that possessed the southern hemisphere, for example, and the Marxist influence in the Catholic Church. You could see that to a great degree in the last Pope, who is also a nature worshiper.
- 6.70** "Today, the concept of greatness entails being noble, wanting to be by oneself, being able to be different, standing alone and having to live independently. And the philosopher will betray something of his own ideal when he posits, 'He shall be greatest who can be loneliest, the most concealed, the most deviant, the human being beyond good and evil, the master of his virtues, he that is overrich in will. Precisely this shall be called greatness, being capable of being as manifold as whole, as ample as full.' And to ask it once more—today, is greatness possible?"
- 6.71** Nietzsche, if I attempted to characterize him temperamentally, I would say two things. He's unbelievably high in openness, off the scale, and very conscientious, very diligent, and very careful and painstaking. It's a rare combination: high openness and high conscientiousness. I would also say the same personality characteristics typified Hitler. He had artistic interests. He wanted to be an artist. He applied to the Viennese art school a number of times and was rejected because his art was conventional and, I would say, is it reasonable to say average? Competent, but average.
- 6.72** He was obsessed with architectural detail. He knew the floor plans of many of the world's great buildings. He spent much time determining how he was going to rebuild the cities of Europe into aesthetically—there was a Nazi aesthetic—into aesthetically pleasing places. He thought of the rebuilding of Paris as an example of that.
- 6.73** He was very orderly—that's conscientious—very, very. Worshiper of will. Hitler would stand in the back of a truck for hours with his hand outstretched—now I'm in trouble because that's recorded. You can do that if you're a Democrat, apparently, but not if you're a Republican. And so, he worshiped will. He bathed four times a day. He was obsessed by disgust. He had a very orderly temperament. And so, I do think it's

reasonable to say—it took me a long time to think this through and to accept it— that Hitler in many ways was the shadow side of the Nietzschean vision.

- 6.74** I really think that's right. They're very similar in temperament. Now, Nietzsche was a—I don't know what Nietzsche's IQ would have been; it's off the scale. He was unbelievably open, but. " Today, the concept of greatness entails being noble, wanting to be by oneself, being able to be different, standing alone and having to live independently. And the philosopher will betray something of his own ideal when he posits, 'He shall be greatest, who can be loneliest, the most concealed, the most deviant.'"
- 6.75** The other thing that's very interesting to note about this: Nietzsche said that every philosophy was an unconscious revelation of the character of the philosopher. This is exactly what you'd expect for someone who's off the charts in openness, because if your fundamental temperamental structure is creative—I had a lot of clients like this. Carl Jung had a lot of clients who were creative as well, which is why he derived the particular brand of psychoanalytic philosophy that he developed.
- 6.76** I used to teach physicians and business people, and I would teach them practical psychology and psychoanalytic symbolism. Some of them loved the psychoanalytic symbolism. And some of them, most of them, liked the practical philosophy, but some of them really liked the psychoanalytic symbolism a lot. Some of them just had no idea what that was for at all, at all, at all, at all, and they were people who were low in openness. The high openness people are very interested in the symbolic world and aesthetics.
- 6.77** Nietzsche, being hyper-open, he is putting forward a philosophy that valorizes that temperamental characteristic. If you're extremely creative, you're never inside a system, by definition. And Nietzsche is pointing out the utility of that high-order creativity. It's like, fair enough, fair enough. And it's terrible when it's squelched by institutions, but institutions squelch creativity. That's partly what makes them institutions. It's so complex when you watch institutions, because they tend to get hidebound at the top. And then that's why they die after 30 years. They can't shift directions.
- 6.78** Why? Because they chase out everybody who switches directions. Why? Well, if I hire you in an entry position, the last thing I want from you is revolutionary thought. Even if you're great at it, you're not going to be a good fit for an entry-level position. You're going to be a square peg in a round hole, and you're going to feel that, too. It's going to make you annoyed. You're going to think, "I have all these great ideas." It's like, I don't want your great ideas. There's lots of great ideas. I want you to do your job.
- 6.79** Well, then maybe you see people starting to rise up the ranks, but you chase all the creative people out. And then by the time the people get to the top, there's no creativity left, and the company dies. But that doesn't mean that it's easy to figure out what to do with creative people. You can't figure out what to do with creative people.

What are you going to do with them? You can't even measure what they do. "What are you doing?" "Well, not what you told me to do." "What are you doing?" "I'm chasing some crazy idea."

**6.80** How the hell am I supposed to evaluate that? First of all, likely it's going to fail, because most ideas fail, even if they're good. And second, say I'm not creative. How the hell am I going to evaluate you when you're wandering off in ten different directions? You should be out there starting your own company. That's pretty damn hard when you're junior and you have no capital and you have no connections.

**6.81** So, openness is a very weird personality dimension. When it hits, you get everything, but the probability that you'll fail if you're creative is super high. So, it's a winner-take-all, high-loss, high-risk enterprise. It's absolutely necessary. Without creative people, things ossify, but trying to integrate that with machine-like regularity and managerial sensibility, that's very difficult.

**6.82** Nietzsche is complaining about that. It's like, who is going to put someone like Nietzsche in a university? He's just running around; he says he's running around, smashing everything with a hammer. Well, he would say it needed to be smashed. It's like, well, that doesn't mean that the people who you're smashing are going to be happy about it. So, if you're creative, you have to understand this: the gift of creativity is the ability to transform. But the curse is: you're going to be outside.

**6.83** I'll give you another example. This is how cities rejuvenate. So, open people are frontier dwellers, always. So where's the frontier? "Well, the whole world is settled. There's no frontier." It's like, there's frontiers everywhere. You go to a city that's kind of decaying, and you're high in openness. Maybe you want to start a gallery or coffee shop or something, and so what do you look for? You look for somewhere there's cheap real estate that's— what?—cool, interesting, edgy. And so, you go somewhere maybe that's got some architectural— even if it's degenerated—some architectural uniqueness; there's something about it that makes it cool. And then all the open people flood in, and the real estate prices are low and they can thrive there. They can make their art and they can have their coffee shops, and then it gets cool.

**6.84** And then what happens? Then, the slightly less open people with a bit of money start to buy the property. And then the corporations flood in, and then it gets gentrified. Well, then the open people have to leave because they can't afford the damn rent, and they go find another place that they rejuvenate because they're frontier dwellers. That's what open people do. They're outside. You just have to accept that, if you're high in creativity.

**6.85** I've watched my creative clients. It's so interesting watching them because if they try to shoehorn themselves into a predictable enterprise, it just kills them, because their vitality, like that temperamental proclivity—if you're orderly and industrious and you don't get to work, you'll just die. If you take someone who's hyper-conscientious and

you put them anywhere, if you put them in a forest, they'd start sweeping up the dirt and cleaning up the sticks. They're going to work. They work. That's what they do.

**6.86** And if you're temperamentally agreeable, you're going to find someone to take care of. And if it isn't a person, it'll be a dog. You'll find something to take care of, because that's where your interest makes itself manifest. And if you're extroverted, even if you're a psychopath, you're going to find people to be social with, and that's where your vitality is; that's a living part of you. It's definitely the same with creative people. So, if you're cursed with openness, you have to pursue what's creative. Too bad for you, too bad for Nietzsche. It's necessary, but there's a tension between—a terrible tension between normality, security, even this issue of the herd and openness. You can't only be on the side of the open people.

## Lecture 7: Rethinking Virtue

At a glance — Rethinking virtue.

- 7.1 His investigation into the structure of virtue. It's funny, that's a word that's become anachronistic. You don't hear—there's two classes of words that have become anachronistic. One of the things I noticed about the personality literature is that this temperamental trait, agreeableness, the way it's conceptualized, it's mostly a feminine trait, agreeableness. Empathy, compassion, politeness. But disagreeableness is also a trait, and it's more masculine.
- 7.2 There are no positive words for being disagreeable in the modern psychological lexicon. So I looked them up, and they're all archaic. They haven't been used since 1850, all the masculine virtue words. Stalwart, for example. When was the last time you heard that word used? Well, what constitutes a virtue? That's a word that we don't use. We don't even use the word itself anymore, virtue. Well, that's his investigation here. What's the nature of virtue, and how is it properly conceptualized?
- 7.3 "Moral judgments and condemnations," cancel culture, "constitute the favorite revenge of the spiritually limited against those less limited." A lovely observation. It's like, why are you being canceled? Is it because you're immoral? No, it's because the manner in which I justify my own cowardly uselessness to myself is to define your actions as immoral. That gives me an excuse for continuing with my herd-like consensus and my false compassion, and a way of extracting malicious envy-related revenge against the people who are doing what I wish I would do.
- 7.4 It's exactly what happens in the story of Cain and Abel, because Cain is bitter, because he fails and he kills his ideal, who's his brother Abel—the oldest story we have about the first human beings who existed after the fall. "Also a sort of compensation for having been ill-favored by nature—finally an opportunity for acquiring spirit and becoming refined, malice spiritualized. It pleases them deep down in their hearts that there are standards before which those overflowing with the wealth and privileges of the spirit are their equals; they fight for the 'equality of all men before God' and almost need faith in God just for that."
- 7.5 It's a reasonable criticism. There's something very fundamental about the notion that all human beings are made in the image of God. There's something very deep about that, and there's something correct and necessary about that. It's a proclamation of the intrinsic value of human existence. It's an axiomatic proclamation. We're going to assume that there's something integral about every human consciousness that we're going to define as fundamental or pinnacle. It's an agreement. It's a kind of game. That's another way of thinking about it. It's a statement of axiomatic faith.
- 7.6 And without that, what do you have? One thing you have is: if I can make you do it, then I get to. Because if there's no intrinsic worth to you that I have to utilize as a limit

case for my own expression of will, what stops me from— what stops me? Maybe your ability to resist. What if that's absent? Well, that's the ultimate expression of the uniting ethos of power. If I can, I will. And so, there's a danger.

- 7.7** What's the danger in the equality before God proposition? It can be warped into the claim that there are no differences; there are, and should be, no differences in rank between people in any particular game. So, equality before God and equality of outcome are not the same thing at all. They're not the same thing. They're different metaphysical presuppositions. The first one is something like: regardless of circumstance or position, there's a fundamental value about each human consciousness. The second is: any difference in rank in any given game—so any form of expertise or merit—is a violation of the principle of equality. Those aren't the same thing at all, and Nietzsche is pointing out the danger of utilizing the first proposition and overextending it to cover the territory of the second, of the second requirement.
- 7.8** "Where pity is preached today—and if you listen closely, this is the only religion preached now—psychologists should keep their ears open. Through all the vanity, through all the noise that characterizes these preachers (like all preachers), they will hear a hoarse, groaning, genuine sound of self-contempt. This belongs to that darkening and uglification of Europe, which has been growing for a century now. This man of 'modern ideas', this proud ape, is immeasurably dissatisfied with himself. That is certain. He suffers— and his vanity wants him to suffer only with others, to feel pity."
- 7.9** Nietzsche's warning about the danger of placing indiscriminating and totalizing compassion at the pinnacle of the moral order and worshiping it as the prime deity. And I always hear echoes of what happens in the story of the Garden of Eden. I do believe that that's why the story is set up the way it is, that just like the intellect has a proclivity to that Luciferian usurpation, that tendency to compassion and caretaking, that is characteristic of the feminine by definition, has a commensurate proclivity, which is to proclaim itself supreme. And that's a form of pride, the maternal as the source of all virtue. Some virtue, that's different than all virtue.
- 7.10** "The discipline of suffering, of great suffering—do you not know that only this discipline has created all enhancements of man so far? That tension of the soul in unhappiness, which cultivates its strength, its shudders face to face with great ruin, its inventiveness and courage in enduring, persevering, interpreting, and exploiting suffering, and whatever has been granted to it of profundity, secret, mask, spirit, cunning, greatness—was it not granted to it through suffering, through the discipline of great suffering?"
- 7.11** "In man, creature and creator are united. In man, there is material, fragment, excess, clay, dirt, nonsense, chaos; but in man, there is also creator, form-giver, hammer hardness, spectator divinity, and seventh day. Do you understand this contrast? And that your pity is for the 'creature in man,' for what must be formed, broken, forged, torn, burnt, made incandescent, and purified—that which necessarily must and should

suffer? And our pity—do you not comprehend for whom our converse pity is when it resists your pity as the worst of all pamperings and weaknesses?"

- 7.12** It's statements like this that make me— what? There's a sorrow in that presumption Nietzsche made that the Christian foundation of Europe valorizes victimization. I told you the story yesterday, when we had our question period about the brazen serpent in the desert and God's insistence that those who face the worst of all poisons will be immunized against it. Nietzsche didn't make that connection in relationship to Christianity.
- 7.13** His insistence here is that we should not regard ourselves as weak victims in the face of our vulnerability and our suffering. It's the wrong—and you can understand that, because if that becomes your predominant consideration, you're going to search for security and you're going to live a life of terror. But it is the case that, as Nietzsche points out, "in man, creature and creator are united." So, that catastrophe of existence is a genuine conundrum. The question is: What do you do with it?
- 7.14** Nietzsche's point here is that you don't conceptualize that vulnerability as something that fundamentally requires pity. Now, that has its place, compassion; it has its place in relationship to infants because they can't fend for themselves, let's say. But what should your attitude towards suffering be? Nietzsche is struggling towards it here. "In man, there's also creator, form-giver, hammer hardness, spectator divinity." So, we can see this amalgam of the divine and the material that's symbolically represented, let's say, in the incarnation of Christ, because that's the problem that's trying to be solved there.
- 7.15** And what's the solution? Well, it's not pity. Nietzsche is clear about that. He posits will to power. What's lurking in this statement is the idea that—is it not the idea that you voluntarily accept that, that you voluntarily face it, and that that's the pathway out? That's the story of the brazen serpent, is that you can transcend anything you're willing to voluntarily face. That's the promise.
- 7.16** Now, it's so—I think I told you about Edna Foa. Edna Foa is a very good psychologist. There are some very good psychologists. She studied exposure therapy as treatment for post-traumatic stress disorder. She dealt with a lot of women who had been violently raped and traumatized by it, and she had them relive the experiences in as much detail as she could in their imagination, and she measured their psychophysiological responses. The women who got most stressed while they were reimagining the experiences were the ones who healed fastest and most permanently.
- 7.17** Why? The original hypothesis was something like, you habituate to it, you bring up the dangerous situation in a safe situation, and nothing happens, so that you learn the danger isn't there anymore. That was wrong. That theory was wrong. That was often paired with relaxation: bring up what terrifies you and relax. If we pair the relaxation with the terror, then it will attenuate the terror. But then it was soon learned you didn't

have to get people to relax; it didn't make any difference. All you had to do was get them to voluntarily face it.

- 7.18** And then it wasn't that they got more afraid—or sorry, less afraid. They got braver. That's not the same thing. It wasn't that their anxiety attenuated. It was that they learned that there was more to them than they thought, that they thought they had to freeze and run away, and they didn't have to. They could approach and attend, no matter how challenging the catastrophe. Well, that's a hell—and there's no difference between that and learning that, "in man, there is creator, form-giver, hammer hardness, spectator divinity, and seventh day."
- 7.19** So, what's the idea? This is how things work. The more you expose yourself to the catastrophe of the world, the more the part of you that contends with that catastrophe will make itself manifest, and that there's no real limit to that. There's no limit to that. And that's really something to understand. And you kind of know this already, because you know if you weight-lift, you push yourself to the edge, that's where you develop. Why would it be any difference? Why would anything you do be different than that?
- 7.20** And Nietzsche talks about the fact that it's like brute necessity, even suffering that's necessary for development. The best of you will not be called out unless it's called forth. You have to put yourself in a situation of necessity before the transformation will take place. And you have to do that first. You have to face the thing that's terrifying before you know you can manage it.
- 7.21** And then that's the promise, you might say; that's the notion that God walks with people, even while you're suffering. What does that mean? Maybe it means that if you're grateful for the suffering and you face it unflinchingly, then the spirit that allows you to withstand it and prevail makes itself manifest within you. That's the promise. And Nietzsche is so close to that realization.
- 7.22** "Things still stand today as they have always stood. I see nobody in Europe who has (let alone, promotes) any awareness that thinking about morality could become dangerous, captious, seductive— that there might be any calamity involved. Finally, consider that even the seeker after knowledge forces his spirit to recognize things against the inclination of the spirit, and often enough also against the wishes of his heart, by way of saying no, where he would like to say yes, love, and adore—and thus acts as an artist and transfigurer of cruelty. Indeed, any insistence on profundity and thoroughness is a violation, a desire to hurt the basic will of the spirit, which unceasingly strives for the apparent and superficial— in all desire to know, there is a drop of cruelty."
- 7.23** That's partly why people are afraid of creative people. Every time you learn something, something that you once knew dies. There's no learning without death, never. And maybe you can become expert enough at learning, so that the positive impetus of the transformation outweighs the calamity of the death. But you always reconfigure a previous preconception when you learn something. So, that means there's always

something that—that's always the desert after the tyranny. It's always that. It's always the collapse.

- 7.24** It's something like this: no matter how superficial your understanding, you have the world completely mapped. Now, some of the pieces that you use in the map are very big and very vague; they're just placeholders. But as long as you don't need detailed knowledge, you don't even notice that it's a placeholder. It's a place you haven't gone. It's a place you maybe won't go. Your superficial knowledge is sufficient so that nothing unexpected happens when you apply it.
- 7.25** But then you go there. You try to master something new, and you realize that your knowledge is tremendously superficial in that given area—and then the superficiality has to crumble. And when the superficiality crumbles, you understand that there's tremendous complexity underneath what you've mapped. And then that's an exposure to—that's an exposure to the basilisk in the Harry Potter story, the second Harry Potter story, that lives under the magic castle, that freezes you into stone when you look at it. It's the chaos that's underneath anything.
- 7.26** Whenever you learn something, the limits of your previous knowledge are exposed. This is a very useful thing to understand, too, because it makes— I tried to learn for decades why people were so committed to their preconceptions that they would kill and die to maintain them. The answer to that is: when you violate a preconception, and it vanishes, the complexity of the territory makes itself manifest, and that's terrifying. And that happens in small ways as well as large.
- 7.27** If it's a major presupposition that's been violated, everything collapses into chaos. Well, that can kill you if it's intense enough, or age you; that's post-traumatic stress disorder. A tremendous amount of your map is demolished, and there's nothing there but malevolence and chaos, and you're in a constant state of hyper-stress, and it's unbearable emotionally, and it ages you, and it can drive you to suicide. It's awful, worse than death, because people will risk death to maintain their presuppositions. So, there's an impediment to learning; and the impediment to learning is the necessary encounter with the intermediary chaos before stability is reestablished.
- 7.28** Now, if you understand that, if you do that voluntarily, that's the most stable solution across transformations. That's like the religious solution to the problem of intransigence. Why should I learn? Because identifying with the process of transformation is the most stable strategy that offers the highest degree of stability, not only when things are stable, but when they're also unstable. And that's the identification with the hero, because the hero is, of course, the person who voluntarily faces the dragon—that's the dragon of chaos—and gathers the treasure.
- 7.29** And that's what the religious enterprise compels you to identify with, rather than with, let's say, the tyrant, like the Pharaoh in Egypt who says, "What I say goes, no matter what." It's not a stable solution. That's the problem with the search for security. The

search for security is not a secure solution. What's the secure solution? The search for optimized transformation. Why? Because you have to deal with certainty and uncertainty. And so, the meta-strategy for dealing with chaos and order, uncertainty and certainty, is voluntary transformation in the face of the unknown. Right.

**7.30** So, what is Nietzsche saying here about the artist or the creative person? Well, there is a cruelty there. It's like, oh god, I could see this as a therapist or in my own family, because I could see things pop up in people's lives, stumbling blocks. It's like, here's a problem you keep having, and it's disrupting your life. Why does this problem—imagine that you decided, for some pathological reason, that there was no such thing as white vans that approached you from the left. You'd be going away happily most of the time, but now and then you'd step off a curb and, man, you're flattened. Maybe it only happens once every three years, and you think, "Why does this keep happening to me?" Cruel fate and the viciousness of God in the world. Well, that's one explanation. It's like, no, you've got a blind spot, buddy.

**7.31** And that's a useful thing to know, too. If you have your recurrent pathological experience, either the world is set against you in some arbitrary and unfair manner, or you've got a blind spot. Okay, so let's say now you assume that the person has a blind spot, and then you think, well, I'm going to get to the bottom of this. It's no wonder that people avoid discussions of that sort because it's so painful. That's a trip down Dante's inferno. You often find something like a betrayal at the bottom of it. Why do you have this blind spot? What characterizes it? Let's delve into that. Oh, my god, it's a messy enterprise.

**7.32** I mean, first, the people, if you're doing that with someone, even if they want to do it, first, they get defensive, then they attack. They say, "What are you doing? Why are you picking on me? What's motivating you? You're just being cruel. Why don't you leave me alone?" Then they'll get angry, and then they'll turn red. Then they'll cry. And then even if you don't stop, which is a kind of cruelty, but then you can get to the bottom of it, and it's brutal. And then maybe you can solve the problem, but it's like surgery. And so, that's the cruelty.

**7.33** What would motivate that if you weren't cruel? You could do that cruelly, for sure. You can use the truth as a weapon, that's for sure. What would motivate you to do that, but not cruelly? It's like, I'd rather see you suffer once than a hundred times. And that's the thing you start to understand, when you start to move beyond cynicism towards wisdom; it's like, why don't we just get this over with? And then it'll be done, and it's not going to be pleasant. You wouldn't have the blind spot if it wasn't protecting something. It's protecting something. And before that can be fixed, it's got to be torn away. Brutal, brutal.

**7.34** If you know, I don't like conflict. I'm a very agreeable person. I really don't like conflict. It bothers me a lot, and I have a lot of conflict. Why? It's because I'd rather have it once than a hundred times. I think, no, we're going to sort this out. And it makes me

nervous. I hate it. But better once than a hundred times. That's a good thing, you know, if you're trying to sort out little kids, and there's a problem in the family, you're going to have to dig in and find out what the hell the problem is. There's going to be a lot of crying, and there's going to be trouble and often resistance from the mother who's protecting the child, and rightly so. It's like, no, this has got to be sorted out. Same in a marriage, same with yourself, especially if it's a recurrent problem. It's like, something's going on here.

- 7.35** It's a good clinical rule of thumb. When do you say something? Not the first time. You just look. Not the second time. You think, "That's twice." The third time, now you've got a case. It's like, "I noticed you did this." "No, I didn't." It's like, "Yeah, I noticed. You did it here, you did it here, and you did it here. Got an explanation? What the hell is going on?"
- 7.36** And so, that's good, too, because it means you don't fly off the handle with every little molehill, right? If you're living with someone or yourself, there's going to be deviations that will annoy you. When should you intervene? Well, not with once. It's a weak case. Twice? Then you should be on alert. Three times? Probably time to have a chat with yourself or with the person. And then is it cruel? Not if the goal is to solve the problem.
- 7.37** "That commanding something which the people call 'the spirit' wants to be master in and around its own house and wants to feel that it is master; it has the will from multiplicity to simplicity," that's the monotheistic will, "a will that ties up, tames, and is domineering and truly masterful. Its needs and capacities are so far the same as those which physiologists posit for everything that lives, grows, and multiplies."
- 7.38** Nietzsche thought that unifying proclivity that brings multiplicity to simplicity—I said that that was the movement from monotheism to, or from polytheism to monotheism—you can think about that as the developmental proclivity within the human being to pull the multiplicity of all those underlying motivational subpersonalities into something that is single in its direction. Nietzsche thought about that as will to power.
- 7.39** In the Abrahamic story, it's the call to adventure. In the story of Elijah and in Jonah, it's the voice of conscience that works as a unifying force. Those are very different conceptualizations than will to power. And the pillar of fire at night—the pillar of light by night and the pillar of shadow by day that guides the Israelites across the desert when they're lost, that chaos, that's that interplay between—the best way to conceptualize that is the interplay between calling and conscience, between what invites and what constrains.
- 7.40** That's an orienting function that unifies, that unifies. That's what's proclaimed and defined as the divine in the biblical corpus. And it's associated—so interestingly, it's so interesting—it's associated with that Abrahamic call to adventure, the impetus to go beyond your zone of comfort. But then it's associated with the brazen serpent, and then it's associated with the crucifixion. And the idea there is that the unifying spirit—

and you can see that this has to be the case—the unifying spirit, the proper unifying spirit, is that that calls you to adventure and that constrains you by conscience.

- 7.41** But more, the unifying spirit is that which calls you to expose yourself voluntarily to all the conditions of life and accept them. Obviously. How could it be different than that? How could it be that the developmental impulse that's attempting to unite you, and maybe unite you with other people, if you're adapted, it has to be the same impulse that calls you into the world and that invites, encourages, compels you to face everything, because you're going to have to.
- 7.42** What's the alternative to facing everything? What's the alternative? You're going to master something that you haven't faced? Obviously, no. And so, then what can you get away with not facing? Only those things that are terrible. Oh, good. So, what are you going to do when the terrible things come along? Because they're going to. And so, the alternative would be: prepare for the worst. And you think, "I can't because I'm just a creature. I'm too vulnerable. I'm too naked. I'm too immature. I'm in need of pity and protection." If you believe that, that will be true. But if you don't believe it and you move forward and you face the brazen serpent, let's say, then the new you makes itself manifest. Obviously.
- 7.43** That's the same as saying that, if you extend your reach, you'll grip more. It's the same thing. We know that the pattern of learning is that you move into what's unknown and master it. And maybe if you were very careful, you could do that in a spirit of play, and it wouldn't be traumatic. And that would be optimized; it would be an optimized, meaningful pursuit. But the goal would still be the same.
- 7.44** This is the problem with Joseph Campbell. Joseph Campbell said, "Follow your bliss." It's like, no, no, that's not right. It's the dragon story that's right. Find the dragon. That's where the treasure is. What's the biggest of all possible dragons? We already answered that question. You have the brazen serpent, the poison serpent on the staff that's poisonous itself. It's not the full manifestation of all the poisons of the world. I told you that Christ's proclamation is, that Christ's reputation was the savior who took the sins of the world onto himself. What does that mean?
- 7.45** When I studied Auschwitz, I studied the guards. I didn't just study the guards, I studied the guards that enjoyed their work. And I thought, "That's me." Right. That's a terrible thing. But if you know that, if you actually know it, then maybe it wouldn't be you. When push came to shove, and the opportunity came along, maybe you'd say no because you'd already figured it out. And you didn't say, "Well, that's someone else."
- 7.46** There are psychopaths and there are sadists, and I'm not saying that everyone falls into that category, but we do know that in totalitarian states, in the Nazi regime, it was pretty much everybody. The people who said no, there weren't very many of them. Everyone else said yes. That means you would have. So, that's worth thinking through.

It's like, what does that mean? What does that mean? "It's someone else." Okay, it's not.

- 7.47** In the Abrahamic story, when the angels come to visit Abraham—angels or God—they tell Abraham that God's going to destroy Sodom and Gomorrah, the pathological city. That's because cities that become weak and hedonistic, they demolish themselves; it's inevitable because they lose that self-sacrificial ethos that is the maturity that allows civilization to maintain itself. They lose that. That's what happens in Sodom and Gomorrah. Everyone's radically inhospitable, out for themselves.
- 7.48** Abraham bargains with God. He says, "It's not fair that you wipe out a whole city." And God says, "What do you mean, it's not fair? They deserve it." And Abraham says, "I'm not so sure. What if there's 40 good men in the city?" And God says, "I don't think there are. But if you can find 40, I'll spare the city." And Abraham is pretty pushy by this time because he's gone through a lot. He bargains for 30, and then he bargains for 20, and then he bargains for 10. And God says two things. "Enough. Ten, I'll allow."
- 7.49** And so, Abraham goes to Sodom and Gomorrah to see if he can find 10 good men, and he can't. What does that story mean? It means, if there are 10 people who will stand up when things degenerate, that's enough to spare the city. And it also means that you need to be one of those 10, and not the other—what?— 100,000, 200,000, million, 10 million. And then the question is: Could you be? What would you have to be like? How would you have to think?
- 7.50** This is what happens in the story of Jonah, too, because God comes to Jonah in the voice of conscience and says, "There's a corrupt city north of you, Nineveh. I want you to go there and tell them that they've wandered off the path and I'm going to wipe them out." And Jonah, being a sensible person, thinks, "I don't think I'm going to do that. There's 150,000 of them. They're my enemy," because the Ninevites were the enemies of the Jews, the Israelites. So he leaves. He goes and jumps on a boat and makes tracks away from Nineveh, as far as—he goes to Tarshish, I think it is—farthest away you can get from Nineveh at that time. He runs away from his conscience.
- 7.51** And then a terrible storm comes and threatens the ship. It's like, "Don't say what you have to say. Threaten the ship of state." And so, that's what happens, and the sailors try to make for shore, and they can't. And Jonah finally convinces them—well, he's at fault because he's running from the voice of conscience, and they throw him overboard. And you think, "That's pretty bad. Now he's going to die." That's a hell of a punishment for running away from your conscience, and that isn't even the worst.
- 7.52** After that, as soon as he's in the water, drowning, so he's dying, you think that's as bad as it gets—that's nowhere near as bad as it gets. So then this terrible beast, the whale, this dragon, comes up from the bottom, from hell, takes him in his jaws, brings him to the bottom of the world, to hell, where he suffers for three days until he decides that

maybe he had something to say. And he remembers that, and the whale comes—the dragon—spits him out on shore.

**7.53** And he goes to Nineveh, and he tells the Ninevites—I guess he's very convincing by this time, having just about died and gone to hell. So, he goes there in his insanity, and they think, "Man, this guy's either crazy or right, because who would do that?" And they listen, and they repent. And the king dresses in sackcloth and ashes, and they put their city straight, and then it's not destroyed. Listen to that. That's the unifying spirit.

**7.54** "The spirit's power to appropriate the foreign stands revealed in its inclination to assimilate the new to the old, to simplify the manifold, and to overlook or repulse whatever is totally contradictory—just as it involuntarily emphasizes certain features and lines in what is foreign, in every piece of the 'external world,' retouching and falsifying the whole to suit itself. Its intent in all this is to incorporate new 'experiences', to file new things in old files—growth, in a word—or more precisely, the feeling of growth, the feeling of increased power."

**7.55** This is a precursor to Jean Piaget's entire theory of assimilation and accommodation. The first thing you do when you encounter something new is to assimilate it to old categories, to see if you can put the new material in old boxes; and that's part of that imposition of a dream, and it's part of this proclivity to simplify. It's necessary because the world is complex. Now and then, things are so radical that the old boxes don't work, in which case, that's the Pandora situation, that the box itself has to be destroyed, and everything in it flies out, and then it has to be boxed up again. That's a creative act.

**7.56** "In no age has the weaker sex been treated with as much respect by men as in ours. That belongs to the democratic inclination and basic taste, just like disrespectfulness for old age." There is something in this paragraph to offend virtually everyone. "No wonder that this respect is immediately abused. One wants more, one learns to demand, finally one almost finds this tribute of respect insulting. One would prefer competition for rights, even a genuine fight; enough, woman loses her modesty. Let us immediately add that she also loses taste. She unlearns her fear of man, but the woman who 'unlearns fear' surrenders her most womanly instincts."

**7.57** Feminists have plenty of trouble with Nietzsche, and it's no wonder. "That woman ventures forth when the aspect of man that inspires fear—let us say more precisely, when the man in man is no longer desired and cultivated—that is fair enough, also comprehensible enough." So, what's his point there? "That woman ventures forth when the aspect of man that inspires fear is no longer desired and cultivated."

**7.58** In the story of Adam and Eve, Eve is tempted first and falls, and then she goes to Adam. And instead of him standing firm and straightening out the situation, he immediately capitulates to her request, putting no boundaries up whatsoever. Then the fall happens. Then men and women realize that they're naked and they're afraid. Then the

next morning, God comes along to walk with Adam—Noah walks with God, by the way—to walk with Adam as he's accustomed. So that means that it's man and the divine, linked arm and arm.

**7.59** Adam is nowhere to be found. What's he doing? He's hiding behind a bush, which is cowardly and stupid. First of all, God can see through bushes. And second of all, why are you hiding? And God immediately asks Adam, "Why are you hiding?" And Adam says, "Because I'm naked, because I'm vulnerable, because I'm self-conscious." And God says, "How did you come to that conclusion?" And Adam says, "You know that woman that you made for me? It's her fault."

**7.60** And so, the feminist reading of Genesis is that it's very hard on Eve. It is, but it's also very hard on Adam. He's as contemptible and cowardly as you could possibly imagine. His response—and you might say, why does the man blame his self-consciousness on the woman? Well, if you think about that for about an hour, you can figure that out. Do women make men self-conscious? Yeah. Women made men self-conscious. Why? By rejecting them, obviously. Human females are sexually selective, and mostly, they reject. What's the consequence of that? Self-consciousness.

**7.61** And so, what does Adam do? Well, he's not happy about the woman. He didn't stand up when she fell. He didn't do what he was supposed to do. He didn't establish the proper order. He was completely craven. And then when God calls him on it, he blames the woman, which is cowardly beyond belief and ungrateful. And then he blames God for making her. If you understand that, you understand a fair bit of the pathological dynamism between men and women. Women push forward, not least on the basis of their compassion. Men step backwards because they're cowardly and weak. That makes them undesirable and self-conscious. That makes them bitter and resentful. They blame the woman and they blame God, and then everyone suffers. Yeah, that's for sure.

**7.62** "What is harder to comprehend is that, by the same token, woman degenerates. That is what is happening today; let us not deceive ourselves about that." It's so complicated. So, there's this proclivity among human beings worldwide. Women like men four years older on average. And women are— how do women choose their partners? They're very sneaky about it, very brilliant about it. They let men arrange themselves into hierarchies of competition and sort themselves out in terms of status, and then they peel from the top. It's a brilliant strategy.

**7.63** Women are hypergamous. What does it mean? They mate across and up status hierarchies, across and up. So what does that mean? To optimize sexual desirableness, a woman is going to choose a man who's of a higher status than she is, no matter how high status she is, because that keeps the dynamism of attraction alive. What's the consequence of that? Women are going to push men to assess their status, in the hope that they find someone who can withstand the pushing. And if they don't— this is Nietzsche's point—they usurp.

- 7.64 What does that do? He says: "That woman ventures forth when the aspect of man that inspires fear is no longer desired and cultivated. That's fair enough, also comprehensible enough. What is harder to comprehend is that, by the same token, woman degenerates." And then you might say: What's under that? Why would that hypergamous tendency be there? Well, why would you want to take care of someone? If you have to take care of infants, why wouldn't you try to find someone who could help, rather than someone who you had to take care of yourself? And so, can you think of that as economic? You can think about it just as intelligent.
- 7.65 "What inspires respect for a woman, and often enough even fear, is her nature, which is more 'natural' than man's, the genuine, cunning suppleness of a beast of prey, the tiger's claw under the glove, the naïveté of her egoism, her uneducability and inner wildness, the incomprehensibility, scope, and movement of her desires and virtues. What, in spite of all fear, elicits pity for this dangerous and beautiful cat 'woman' is that she appears to suffer more, to be more vulnerable, more in need of love, and more condemned to disappointment than any other animal."
- 7.66 What does that mean? Women are higher in trait neuroticism than men. That emerges at puberty. They're more prone to depression and anxiety. Why? It's very stable; it's cross-culturally stable. And the biggest differences are in the most egalitarian societies, not the least egalitarian societies. So, as you flatten out the socioeconomic hierarchy and the—what?—the forum of opportunity? The genetic differences between men and women maximize. They don't minimize.
- 7.67 The biggest differences between men and women in the world in temperament are in Scandinavia. The biggest difference is in interest, people versus things. The biggest difference is in agreeableness. The biggest difference is in the trait negative emotionality. Women are alarm systems. That's a good way of thinking about it. Why? Let's lay out the reasons. They're smaller physically at puberty, so there's reason to be more afraid in relationship to physical threat—number one. Number two: they're much more vulnerable sexually. Number three: they have to take care of infants.
- 7.68 So, here's a hypothesis. In the Judeo-Christian tradition, the image of woman is woman and infant. It's not a woman; it's a woman and an infant. Why? Because if you're a mature man, that should be your image of a woman, first of all, rather than the whore of Babylon, let's say, which is the alternative symbolic representation.
- 7.69 Why a woman and an infant? Why would we assume that a woman's emotional system is optimized for her? Why would we assume that? Why wouldn't we assume that it's a balance of optimization between her and the protection of her infant, who's vulnerable? And so, then why wouldn't we assume that a tilt towards alarm detection, although painful personally because it's associated with negative emotion, is exactly what you'd need, if it was you plus something extremely vulnerable for a minimum of three years, so.

- 7.70** "Fear and pity. With these feelings man has so far confronted woman, always with one foot in tragedy, which tears to pieces as it enchants. What? And this should be the end? And the breaking of woman's magic spell is at work? The 'borification' of women is slowly dawning? O Europe!" I could tell you there's something in Nietzsche to annoy absolutely everyone. "We know the horned animal you always found most attractive. It still threatens you. Your old fable could yet become history. Once more, an immense stupidity might become master over you and carry you off. And this time no god would hide in it, too; no, only an idea, a modern idea!"
- 7.71** What the hell is he at there? One of the things that we've tried to deal with in the 20th century, and now in the 21st century, is the integration of women into the broader cultural space. There are immense advantages to that and immense dangers, and Nietzsche is pointing to some of the dangers. It's like, how do we manage the maintenance of the attractiveness between men and women at the local level and the integration of women into the broader cultural endeavor, the broader organizational endeavor? Part of what he's pointing to here is the danger that that integration poses to attraction itself.
- 7.72** I think now, in Japan, 30% of those under 30 are virgins in Japan. It's something similar in South Korea, birth rates plummeting way below replacement in both of those places, more than anywhere else in the world, although that's the proclivity all the way around the world. Marriage has catastrophically collapsed, and increasingly so over the last 10- to 20-year period.
- 7.73** That happened first in the black population in North America, then in the Hispanic population, then in the Caucasian population. But the curves are the same; they're spaced out about 10 years different, but that's the proclivity. How is that all to be sorted out? We don't know. And what are the consequences of that, too? The breaking of the intimate relationship between men and women; that's a huge part of it. The rise of pornography.
- 7.74** Part Eight: People and Fatherlands. "What does Europe owe to the Jews? Many things, good and bad, and above all one thing that is both of the best and of the worst—the grand style in morality, the terribleness and majesty of infinite demands, infinite meanings, the whole romanticism and sublimity of moral questionabilities—and hence, precisely the most attractive, captious, and choicest part of those plays of color and seductions to life, in whose afterglow the sky of our European culture, its evening sky, is burning now, perhaps burning itself out. We artists among the spectators and philosophers are grateful for this to the Jews."
- 7.75** What does he mean by that? I talked to Stephen Fry. Stephen Fry is a very interesting person, very urbane, witty, civilized, hyper-intelligent, extremely open person, an atheist, very interested in mythology; even though he's atheistic, he's studied Greek mythology, Roman mythology; he's written books on mythology. He's very interested in narrative. He's very contemptuous of the biblical narratives, which is very surprising to

me, because the biblical narratives at minimum are myths. And he told me in our conversations that they were inferior in his regard to, say, the Roman and the Greek myths. I don't believe that. I've read them, and I don't see how that's the case.

**7.76** And then there's another thing—and Nietzsche has touched on this here. The Protestants distributed literacy all around the world. The reason the world's literate is because of the Protestants, the Protestants and the printing press. The Chinese had the printing press. That didn't make the world literate. You needed the printing press plus this evangelical—what?—religious impulse to spread the fundamental book everywhere. That happened really fast. I think within the next 10 years, something like that, the Bible will have been translated into every extant language. And that's only—how long has the printing press been around? Not very long.

**7.77** The Protestants, by doing that, codified languages. They provided people whose language had no written form with written forms. They classified all the languages which hadn't been classified before, and they brought literacy to the world. And that literacy was based on the biblical writings, and a huge chunk of them are obviously Jewish writings, obviously. And the Jews have been literate forever. They're "people of the book," and that was their kingdom. And it turned out to be something that was more lasting than the monuments of Rome, by a lot. A book is more foundational than a kingdom. It's more foundational than anything built of stone. It lasts. They wrote a book, and they made their own culture literate, and then that distributed itself everywhere. And those stories, those ancient Jewish stories, those ancient Old Testament stories, they are unbelievably profound.

**7.78** It makes a certain amount of sense, if you think about it, even biologically. The Jews organized their culture so that literacy conferred status. And that's been going on for 10,000 years. And so, what does that mean? It means at minimum that the Jews established a society where the hierarchy of competence was associated with the hierarchy of literacy. God only knew what that meant, both culturally and biologically, that 10,000 years of assortative mating in relationship to literacy—plenty of time to produce biological transformation.

**7.79** The depth? We still haven't exhausted the impetus that's part and parcel of the biblical corpus, including the Old Testament. And that's all to be laid at the feet of the Jews. That insistence, for example, that a culture should be predicated on a book, what a crazy idea that is. Who would ever come up with a notion like that? Something as apparently abstracted and evanescent as writing, as the foundation of a culture. That's what Nietzsche is trying to point to here.

**7.80** "That Germany has amply enough Jews, that the German stomach, the German blood has trouble (and will still have trouble for a long time) digesting even this quantum of 'Jew,' as the Italians, French, and English have done, having a stronger digestive system." It's a hell of a thing to write in the late 1800s, before all hell broke loose in Germany. "That is the clear testimony and language of a general instinct to which one

must listen, in accordance with which one must act. Admit no more new Jews! And especially close the doors to the east (also to Austria)! Thus commands the instinct of a people whose type is still weak and indefinite, so it could easily be blurred or extinguished by a stronger race.

- 7.81** "The Jews, however, are beyond any doubt the strongest, toughest, and purest race now living in Europe. They know how to prevail even under the worst conditions." Yeah, are God's chosen people precisely the people fated to suffer most? "They know how to prevail even under the worst conditions (even better than under favorable conditions), by means of virtues that today one would like to mark as vices, thanks above all to a resolute faith that they need not be ashamed before 'modern ideas.'
- 7.82** "They change, when they change, always only as the Russian Empire makes its conquests, being an empire that has time and is not of yesterday—namely, according to the principle, 'as slowly as possible.' A thinker who has the development of Europe on his conscience will, in all his projects for this future, take into account the Jews as well as the Russians as the provisionally surest and most probable factors in the great play and fight of forces."
- 7.83** That's a hell of a thing to write at the end of the 1800s with nothing that's yet occurred in the 20th century having made itself manifest, even when Russia at that point was still essentially a feudal society. The Russians didn't abolish serfdom until about the time that Nietzsche was writing. It was still a completely feudal place. For Nietzsche to see that coming is stunning.
- 7.84** Part Nine. This is the conclusion of Beyond Good and Evil. "Refraining mutually from injury, violence, and exploitation, and placing one's will on a par with that of someone else, this may become, in a certain rough sense, good manners among individuals if the appropriate conditions are present (namely, if these men are actually similar in strength and value standards and belong together in one body). But as soon as this principle is extended, and possibly even accepted as the fundamental principle of society, it immediately proves to be what it really is—a will to the denial of life, a principle of disintegration and decay."
- 7.85** So, what is he grappling with here? It's a reflection, another reflection, and Nietzsche's work is littered with this, on the paradox between the proposition that all human beings are made in the image of God, which confers a certain fundamental, inviolable, baseline worth that even the state is not allowed to transgress against, the basis of natural right, and the clear indication, as far as Nietzsche is concerned, that wherever you look in the games that human beings play, there are clear gradations of rank and ability.
- 7.86** Now, his concern is that if those gradations in rank and ability are not valorized, if they're not valued, appreciated even, then the proclivity to flatten out destroys

everything. Because Nietzsche could see that there has to be that tension between having and not having in order for anything to be. That's basically it.

- 7.87 Then he's extending the presumption of equality. If you are with people of rough ability, and your agreement is to treat each other as equals, then that's a reasonable proposition, given your equality of rank. But if the presumption is that, despite differences in ability, equality of rank is going to be assumed, that flattens everything out so terribly that everything ends up destroyed. That's what happened in the Soviet Union, essentially.
- 7.88 I'll give you an example of that. So, it was quite late in the development of Europe that Russia emerged from feudalism, let's say at the end of the 1800s; it was really among the last societies to experience the sweep of the Enlightenment, the dissolution of the old religious forms, etc. And then when it happened, it happened very fast. The same thing happened in Quebec, by the way, in the 1950s, by the way, that late. So, Russia was protected from the anti-religious Enlightenment ideas that swept across Europe for the longest possible period of time, but when they swept across, they just demolished everything instantly.
- 7.89 So the serfs were freed in the late 1800s. I think it was in the 1860s, if I remember correctly. And then by the 1920s, some freehold farmers, so those would have been freed serfs, had become prosperous enough as individuals to have some property, to hire some people, and to know how to grow food, and so that's how Russia fed itself. And then in the '20s, especially in Ukraine, the Soviets swept in and collectivized all the farms. Now you have to understand what this meant, practically. It meant "property is theft," so let's start with that presumption.
- 7.90 But this is what it meant on the ground. Imagine you have a village, a pretty isolated out-of-the-way village, not very many people in it, and there's a hierarchy of economic rank. There's a bunch of— there's a few people that have a house and a few cows and some land, and they're farming the farms and making the food.
- 7.91 And then there's a bunch of useless scoundrels in town who are alcoholics and bitter and malicious and envious and resentful and jealous and cruel. And then the intellectuals come in, and they have a little chat with the local malicious, envious, useless sadists at the bar. And they say, "You know those people down the street who own the house? They took that from you; they stole that from you. We're here to free you from their enslavement. We think you could gather up a nice mob, and we'll go have a visit with those people."
- 7.92 That happened in all of the villages and towns. That was "dekulakization." The kulaks were the successful farmers who had stolen everything from the true and natural inheritors of—what would you say?—the natural resource wealth. So, they raped, killed, and burned out all the successful farmers in this unbelievably cruel manner all across, particularly, Ukraine. And they also shipped a bunch of them to Siberia, where

there was absolutely nothing, dumped them there in the middle of the winter, and they either died—and most of them did, froze to death or whatever had you—or they built what you could build where no one could live. And then six million Ukrainians starved to death in the 1930s. What's that an indication of? The extension of the principle of equality of rank, where it clearly should not be extended.

- 7.93** It's really worth imagining this, because if you know anything about small communities, you can imagine exactly how this would have played out. Because in a small community, there's a hierarchy of success, obviously, and there's a fair bit of resentment in consequence of that, especially at that really pathological end, where you have the drunken, psychopathic, criminal ne'er-do-wells who believe that they're victims, who exploit everyone, and who are looking for some avenue for their bitterness and resentment. Then you bring the intellectuals in from the cities and tell them that they're on the side of the right. Brutal, brutal.
- 7.94** Nietzsche's warning against that. And it's so tricky because it isn't exactly obvious how you balance this insistence that each person has intrinsic value with the equal realization that distribution in ability and rank is a precondition for any abundance at all. You have to not interfere with the productive people.
- 7.95** It's even more complex than that because sometimes people get wealthy, let's say, and have opportunities because they're productive. But sometimes people are wealthy and have opportunities because they are, in fact, criminals. Every polity, even in the West, which is pretty productive and abundant, and mostly the wealth here is generated by merit, that doesn't mean that 10% of it isn't the consequence of criminal exploitation. It is. So, that makes separating the wheat from the chaff even more difficult.
- 7.96** Some wealthy people are criminals. Fair enough. That's very different than all wealthy people are criminals. And it's really different than everyone who has something you don't is a criminal. Oh, yeah. As soon as you make that principle fundamental, then you punish; then you do exactly what Nietzsche said earlier. You punish people for their virtues. It's like, the fact that you're successful is proof you're a criminal. You couldn't find an equation that would drag your society to hell faster than to define productive success as criminal.
- 7.97** It's funny. There's this conundrum, anthropological conundrum. There's been modern human beings of our form for 350,000 years, and nothing happened till after the last Ice Age. No real evidence of civilization. Why? What's the "noble savage" like? When the Bushmen in Africa were first discovered—they're more genetically similar to Asians, by the way, than to the black Africans; that's just an aside—the "noble savage," Rousseauian types thought that they were egalitarian, communitarian, peaceful. They're not peaceful. They're not heavily armed, but the men kill each other at quite a radical rate, and it's partly because they don't really have any complex mechanism to mediate disputes.

- 7.98** The Bushmen, they have these little bow and arrows; they look like kids' toys, but they're not. They're hyper-light, and the Bushmen hunt with these little poison darts. So, they'll hit an animal, it just kind of pokes them, and then they run the animal to death. That's how the Bushmen hunt, and that's how they kill each other.
- 7.99** It turned out that, when the black Africans came into Bushmen territory, I think it was the Bantu, the Bushmen used to bring—the Bantu had a more sophisticated civilization, including a judiciary, and so the Bushmen who had a dispute, because they were sick of killing each other, they would go to the Bantu and have their disputes mediated by this more sophisticated system.
- 7.100** In any case, anthropological investigations around the world have shown that, in tribal societies, homicide rates are unbelievably high, unbelievably high, by modern standards. And so, there's no "noble, peaceful savage." You can bloody well forget about that. And more—this was mostly discovered, I would say, in South America, but it's also characteristic to some degree of our chimp relatives and of tribal people all around the world— there's constant intertribal warfare, constant intertribal warfare.
- 7.101** And so, what mitigates against the development of civilization, let's say, the provision of abundance, is like, if you have something I don't, I can always kill you and take it. You don't need very much of that before no one has anything. Now, India was in that state to a large degree under Muslim rule before the Brits came along. If you were a peasant in India, in these thousand kingdoms, and you had anything, you'd better hide it, because someone would take it.
- 7.102** And if the situation is that, if you have something, you'll die, it doesn't take much of a genius to figure out why nothing develops under those conditions. If you have anything that anyone jealous would be jealous of, and they can kill you, you're a fool to have anything. So, why did we have nothing for 330,000 years? One of the fundamental commandments, one of the Ten Commandments, is, do not covet your neighbor's belongings. Do not envy. Why? Because if there's envy, no one gets anything. Right.
- 7.103** "Here we must beware of superficiality and get to the bottom of the matter, resisting all sentimental weakness; life itself is essentially appropriation, injury, overpowering of what is alien and weaker, suppression, hardness, imposition of one's own forms, incorporation, and at least, at its mildest, exploitation. But why should one always use those words in which a slanderous intent has been imprinted for ages?"
- 7.104** This is another indication of how Nietzsche's will to power philosophy has this pathological, I would say, proclivity towards fascism based into it. "Life itself is essentially appropriation, injury, overpowering of what is alien and weaker, suppression, hardness, imposition of one's own forms." "Essentially" is the problem with that phrase. Is it essentially that?
- 7.105** I'll tell you a story from the end of Exodus. Moses has led his people away from the tyranny, through the Red Sea of chaos—that's the collapse of the tyranny—and then

through the desert. That period of doubt before things sort themselves out again in the Promised Land makes itself manifest. So, it's been three generations in the desert, because the Israelites are slaves and they haven't abandoned their slavish habits, even though they're away from the Pharaoh. And now they're right on the edge of the Promised Land.

**7.106** And Moses sends scouts into Canaan. That's the Promised Land. Now, Canaan is a strange place biblically, because you could think of Canaan as the place that's inhabited by the faithless. Canaan is the place that's inhabited by the faithless and those who sacrifice to the wrong gods. So it's like a metaphysical place; it's the place where the wrong ethos rules. That's Canaan. And you can think about Canaan as the future in that regard. It's like, the future is always the place where different systems of value war. That's the future.

**7.107** So now Moses and his people are on the cusp of the future; they want to get a lay of the land. And so, Moses picks a scout from each of the twelve tribes of Israel and sends them to Canaan to generate a report. They all come back, and ten of them bring a negative report. They say, "We should have never left the tyranny. Your leadership was self-serving and exploitative, and all that time we spent in the desert was for naught. Giants inhabit the new land. If we move forward, there's going to be apocalyptic devastation." They tell their people that, and there's widespread despair.

**7.108** But two of them, Caleb and Joshua, don't say that. They say something different. They say, "It's going to be difficult, but if we maintain our alliance with the transcendent and we continue to implement the appropriate ethos, there's no enemy that can stand before us, and there's no desert we can't make bloom." And so, God gets wind of this, and He tells the ten faithless scouts of the future that they will not move forward into the Promised Land, and neither will their people. He elects Joshua and Caleb to replace Moses and bring the Israelites to the Promised Land.

**7.109** So, what does it mean? It's complicated and it's germane to this proposition of Nietzsche. I've had a hard time with this idea of natural resource. I don't like that idea. I think it's Marxist and materialist to the core. I don't think there's any such thing as a natural resource. Maybe air. Because water, let's say, fresh water, that's not a natural resource. It's very hard to come by. Human beings drank alcohol forever because that's how they purified their water. Fresh water is not a natural resource.

**7.110** So, what does fresh water depend on? Think about your taps. How much work, especially here, how much work does it take to get you fresh water? And in what way is that a natural resource? And then you think: What's the work dependent on? You could say it's dependent on the technology. But then you could say: What's the technology dependent on? Some appreciation for creative endeavor, some private enterprise, some engineering ability.

- 7.111** How about this? How about the social contract that ensures that whenever there's a break in the water main, whenever, someone fixes it right now, just like they fix whatever's wrong with the power right now. And then doesn't that depend on the social contract, fundamentally? And then what's the basis for the fundamental social contract, so that things actually work?
- 7.112** This is what this story in Exodus is trying to lay out: if you want to make the desert bloom, if you want to make the future abundant, then you have to establish the foundation properly, and you have to get the ethos right. Because if you can get people to actually cooperate voluntarily, there's nothing they can't do, and that's the natural resource. That's the only—and I think this is true: honesty and trust are the only natural resources. If people do what they say they'll do, and you can work with them, there's nothing that people can't accomplish.
- 7.113** Israel is a good example of that in relationship to the desert. I mean, a more barren and wasted land you could not possibly imagine. It's a high-trust society. They desalinate the water. They make earth where there was none. What's the precondition? It's the social contract. What's the precondition for that? The ethical conduct of the individual. That's the critical issue. That's not the same as this.
- 7.114** "Resisting all sentimental weakness. Life itself is essentially appropriation." That's true of marriage? That's true of the relationship between parents and children? Really? That's true of how you conduct yourself in relationship to your colleagues and your customers? It's all exploitation and appropriation?
- 7.115** How about it's this? There's things you can do, and there's things I can do. And if we put our heads together and we forged a proper contract, whatever that means, a proper contract, a proper covenant, then there are things we could do together that we couldn't do apart. We wouldn't be social if we didn't believe that. And so, then what's the foundation of the social ethos? Nietzsche's point is, "Life itself is essentially appropriation." The postmodernists took a page from this.
- 7.116** "Injury, overpowering of what is alien and weaker, suppression, hardness, imposition of one's own forms, incorporation and exploitation." He wants to revalorize some of that hardness, to incorporate it into what's useful about life. But there's still an overstatement and an error here.
- 7.117** One of the things Jean Piaget discovered, pointed out when he was analyzing how children organized their little societies, was that, if you're a child, you can impose a game on another child with force. But it's not a good solution. You don't have a friend. You have a friend when you both want to play the game. And that's Piaget; brilliant, it was brilliant to understand that voluntary fiction construction—that's a good way of thinking about it—as the basis for the most abundant society.
- 7.118** Piaget pointed out that, if you took two societies—imagine you and I decide to cooperate voluntarily, so we work on an endeavor. And then I force you to do the same

thing. I could force you. Why not do that? Well, I have to expend some energy forcing you. And then it would depend on how much you don't like being forced. It might be a lot of energy on my part. And then it might also be that—and the psychoanalysts noted this in relationship to even advice in therapy—you're going to resist, not necessarily with force, but why would you bring your best to the table if you're going to be forced?

**7.119** Maybe if I forced you, you'd burn the whole goddamn game to the ground, even at the cost of your own skin, just to stop me. Highly likely. So, force— I could make you a slave, and you would work, or vice versa. But if we entered into a voluntary partnership, and you were on board as much as me, then I don't even have to pay any attention to you, because I can just assume that, given that your perceptual frame and emotional structure is now the same as mine, and we're aiming at the same goal, I can go do something else, and you'll thrive in the absence of my effort.

**7.120** So, now if we put those two systems head to head in a competition—that's what happened with the Soviet Union and the United States—who's going to win? Well, the system based on force is not as motivationally efficient by any stretch of the imagination. So, this is distasteful.

**7.121** I know what Nietzsche is trying to do. He's trying to, at least in part, point out the necessity for hardness and conflict and to not assume reflexively that that should just be eradicated or that it's unnecessary. But the idea that the fundamental social contract is "essentially appropriation, injury, and overpowering what is alien and weaker," that's what the bloody French intellectual postmodernists say, when they make the claim that everything fundamentally is about power. That's a confession on their part; that's that unconscious confession of their own— what?—character and temperament, rather than a description of the manner in which the world actually works.

**7.122** And then you can go deeper than that, too, which is what Nietzsche should have done with Christianity. I'll give you an example of this. There's a trading game that showed that people weren't self-centered maximizers. Here's the game: I'm going to give you \$100, but you have to share it with her. And you have to offer her the sharing contract, and if she rejects it, neither of you get anything. Okay, so you have \$100. How much are you going to offer her?

**7.123** I know this one.

**7.124** Yeah. But what's the offer?

**7.125** I would do 50 bucks.

**7.126** Yeah, okay. So, this game has been played around the world, and it's been played with rich people and poor people, and with people from all different cultures. And the default offer is 50%.

- 7.127** Now, the classical economic view is—that isn't the prediction from the classical economic view, because the classical economic view is that human beings are individual self-maximizers. So here's the rational solution: you get to make the decision. You offer her \$1. She takes the \$1, because do you want \$1 or you want nothing? Because why would you pick nothing? Because then you have nothing and not a dollar. And you get \$99, and she gets \$1. Nobody does that.
- 7.128** Now, even more to the point: radically poor people won't take the \$1, so poverty has no effect on the willingness—in fact, from what I remember, from the literature, poor people are less likely to take an unfair offer, even though they need the money. Why? It's because classical economists are not very sophisticated; that's really why.
- 7.129** It's like, so you two make a deal, but you know what the deal was, and so do you, and you remember. But also, now all of you know what the deal was, too. And so, if your deal was \$99 for you and \$1 for you, and your deal was 50-50, and you heard about that, and then you got to decide who you're going to make a deal with, it wouldn't be him. It'd be the person who was fair, who sacrificed half of the winnings.
- 7.130** What's the utility of the sacrifice? Well, you store it up in reputation. "You're fair. He plays fair." It's not one game. This is the problem with classical economics. It's not one game.
- 7.131** You might say that if you never saw each other again, you could take the \$99 and you could take the one, and you could both be ashamed of yourselves and leave, and that would work. But the problem is that you don't know how many times you'll run into each other again. You don't know. There's no finitude in the game. It iterates. And so, the proper strategy is an iterating strategy across a game of indeterminate scope.
- 7.132** So what's the best way to play that game? It might be that the best way to play that game is to offer her 60% and make sure that you know you did that and everybody heard, because then, even though it wasn't exactly a fair shake for you, everybody knows that you'll err on the side of generosity.
- 7.133** And maybe if you have a reputation for erring on the side of generosity—that's what little kids say when they say something like, "He's really fun to play with." What do they mean? You get to pick the game now and then if you're his friend, and the game's set up so that you have a reasonable chance of winning. The other little kid can take the loss gracefully and gratefully and have the game continue. That's reputation.

## Lecture 8: Freedom Through Responsibility

At a glance — Freedom through responsibility.

- 8.1 You don't want victory in a negotiation. You want victory in the sequence of all possible negotiations across the broadest possible span of time. I don't think there's any difference between that and character. And there's no difference between the record of that and reputation. You should never sacrifice your reputation for a local victory.
- 8.2 That's what you do when you're a poor sport in a game. You sacrifice the future game, you sacrifice your teammates, you sacrifice your reputation. You do everything you can to win that game. And the little kid will ask, "Why shouldn't I do that? Isn't it about winning?" Yeah, but it's about winning the longest possible sequence of multitudinous games, and how you play that is different than how you play a given game.
- 8.3 You can think about the religious enterprise as exactly the analysis of that broader space. It's like, how should you conduct yourself in relationship to the largest possible number of interactions with other people, over the longest possible span of time, so that that expertise is made manifest in every moment? That's how you get an abundant society. You'll do what you say you'll do.
- 8.4 When I grew up, I used to go to this little town called Naicam in Saskatchewan, and I used to go there in the 1960s. It was kind of a thriving farming community. There was about 600 people there. At that time, the little towns in North America were doing very well. They've all dried up and become ghost towns now, but then it was—these little towns, they'd have a butcher store, they had a theater, they had a pool hall and a bar. They were little communities and pretty self-sufficient. And it was doing quite well.
- 8.5 And they had a place there that sold milk and butter and eggs, but it was a place; it was in the theater lobby. And it was just a refrigerator where the milk was, and the cream and the butter and the eggs. And beside the refrigerator, there was a jar, and that's where you put your money. And you took whatever you needed, and you put your money in there. No one took the money, and no one took the dairy. That's why that place was rich.
- 8.6 I've gone to Italy, to Florence. Florence is a very interesting place to go, because you can go to all these— there's churches, great buildings everywhere in Florence. Wherever you go, there's these treasures. There's these insane paintings and sculptures that are worth God only knows how much money. They're just sitting there. No one takes them. You think Italy is full of treasure. Yeah, the biggest treasure is that no one takes the treasures.
- 8.7 So, why is that? Because, by and large, the people are honest, or they're honest enough so they can have that. That's not this. That's not "appropriation, injury, overpowering of what is alien and weaker." And I understand why Nietzsche is not celebrating

weakness and pity, but this is wrong. This is wrong. That's not how things work, not if they're going to be productive. This is a pointer to the notion that property is theft and that success is exploitation.

- 8.8** "Wandering through the many subtler and coarser moralities which have so far been prevalent on earth, or still are prevalent, I found that certain features recurred regularly together and were closely associated, until I finally discovered two basic types and one basic difference. There are master morality and slave morality. I add immediately that, in all the higher and more mixed cultures, there also appear attempts at mediation between these two moralities, and yet more often the interpenetration and mutual misunderstanding of both.
- 8.9** "And at times, they occur directly alongside each other, even in the same human being, within a single soul. The moral discrimination of value has originated either among a ruling group whose consciousness of its difference from the ruled group was accompanied by delight, or among the ruled, the slave and dependents of every degree."
- 8.10** So that's his division of the world. Master morality—tyrants, pharaohs; slave morality. That's the landscape. If Nietzsche is going to pick between those two moralities, he's going to pick master morality, and he's going to lay the valorization of slave morality at the feet of Christianity. So that's the game.
- 8.11** I want to tell you another story. This is from Exodus. Remember now, Nietzsche in principle is grateful to the Jews, so this is the greatest Jewish story. The landscape is set up as Nietzsche proclaimed. So, after Moses encounters the burning bush and becomes a leader, because once he takes something seriously, something that calls to him, he takes it seriously, he gets to the bottom of it, and the ground of being reveals itself to him and transforms him, and he becomes a leader. And God says, "You're a leader now. That's your destiny."
- 8.12** And Moses said, "I can't lead. I'm slow of tongue. I can't speak." And God says, "I don't care what your insufficiencies are. What are they to me? You're not going to use that as an excuse. This is what you're going to do." And then He gives him a hint. He says, "You can't speak. That's not a big problem for me because I made the heavens and the earth, so relax. But here's a hint. Find your brother, Aaron. He can speak. He's fluent. Ally yourself with him, and the two of you can manage this."
- 8.13** And so, that's a good piece of advice. When you're thinking about what you could do with yourself, you think there's a bunch of reasons it can't be me. It's like, first of all, it doesn't have to just be you. And maybe you're good at this and not so good at this. Find someone else who's good at this other thing and partner with them. And then you've got something to do, and they've got something to do. And maybe you need a few other people, too. And there's plenty for everyone to do. There's no shortage of responsibility or opportunity.

- 8.14** So, Moses gets that sorted out. Now he has Aaron. That's the separation of church and state. Moses is the pipeline to the divine; he's the prophet, and Aaron is the political arm. They're both necessary and they have to work in harmony.
- 8.15** So, God tells Moses he has to go back to Egypt and talk to the Pharaoh and free the Hebrews. But what's the situation in Egypt? It's the situation that Nietzsche describes. It's like master morality: the Pharaoh, the aristocrats, the Egyptians; slave morality: the Israelites. And so, that's the landscape.
- 8.16** And so, you think Nietzsche is right. It's like, no. There's a third variable that he missed. This is a crucial third variable. So, Moses goes back to Egypt, and he confronts the Pharaoh with his staff, and he tells the Pharaoh that God sent him and that God said—and he says this nine times, "Let my people go, so they may worship me in the wilderness." That's the phrase. The Pharaoh refuses, and the plagues come.
- 8.17** Why? If you're wrong and you double down, then things get worse. And they get worse and worse and worse with the successive plagues until the future is destroyed. That's the death of the firstborn. Not just the present, but the future. And then the Pharaoh has had enough, hypothetically, and he sends the Israelites packing. And then he repents and sends his army after them, and they have to cross the Red Sea, and that's when the Egyptians' army is destroyed.
- 8.18** So, you see this dynamism between the master morality, the Pharaoh, the aristocrats, and the Israelite slaves. And you think Nietzsche got it right: here's masters and there's slaves, and you're one or the other. But that statement that God tells Moses to lay at the feet of the Pharaoh has the roots of the solution. "Let my people go, so they may celebrate me in the desert."
- 8.19** What is that? That's a vision of ordered freedom. So, it's freedom, but under the rubric of an ethos. And that ethos is whatever it means to celebrate the proper divine unity. To worship that, to celebrate it, to put it in the highest place. That's what worship means, to put it in the highest place.
- 8.20** So, eventually, the Israelites get out to the desert, and they're slaves. Like Nietzsche points out, that's not good. They're whiny, they're bitter, they're resentful, they can't govern themselves, they're jealous and envious of anything that's successful, they're little, and they lack vision. They're just as bad as the tyrants, or worse. And so, you could say, well, Nietzsche was right there, too.
- 8.21** What happens is that, because the Israelites can't govern themselves, and they're bitching and whining and at each other's throats all the time, and they want to turn back and they lose faith and they curse God, and then Moses leaves at one point, and, under the sway of Aaron, who's the political wing, they immediately become hedonistic populists. As soon as Moses leaves, as soon as the divine vanishes, they're all naked and drunk and partying like mad, worshiping the golden calf, which is exactly what they

do; it's a drunken orgy. They make themselves foolish in the eyes of their enemies. That's the Israelites. Not good.

- 8.22** And they can't get along, so they make Moses their judge. And then he sits like for forever, from dawn till midnight every day, listening to the Israelites bitch about how they can't solve their own problems. He builds up a huge corpus of knowledge about how to make very astute moral judgments that hold.
- 8.23** If you two have a dispute, and I mediate it, and the mediation is going to hold, it has to follow something like a principle of natural justice. Because if I favor you over you, and you think that, and maybe you think that, you might say you'll accept it, but you won't. The fight will just continue. And so, I have to come up with some judgment that satisfies you both, so it's just, or nothing's going to be solved. So, Moses builds this huge corpus of knowledge about what constitutes ethics in the back of his imagination. That all happens before he gets the Ten Commandments. The Commandments reveal themselves to him as the foundation of judicious peace. Mind-boggling, the fact that the story is set up that way is mind-boggling.
- 8.24** So, Moses is judging the Israelites, morning to night, for, like, a decade. And his father-in-law shows up. His father-in-law is this guy named Jethro. Jethro is a wise foreigner. Jethro was the man for whom Moses worked as a shepherd. Jethro's daughter is Moses' wife, and they parted, they separated. But Jethro came to see how the Israelites were doing in the desert, and they weren't doing that great.
- 8.25** So, he comes to Moses, and he says, "You've got to stop doing this. You've got to stop doing this." And really, he says there's two reasons. One is: it's too much. It's too much for you. Nobody can do that. You're taking all the weight of the idiocy of these people on your own shoulders. You're just going to die. You can't do that.
- 8.26** But worse, you're depriving the Israelites of their own responsibility and keeping them enslaved, and they're trying to make you into a new Pharaoh. Moses, who's a leader, that's his temptation. His temptation continually throughout the voyage is to misuse power, continually. In fact, he misuses power right at the end of the voyage, and God says, "You're going to die, and you don't go to the Promised Land," because he uses force when he's supposed to use invitation. So, this is Moses' big temptation, to become the new king.
- 8.27** The question is: What's the alternative to the tyrant and the slave? That's the question. They're all slaves. They want a new tyrant. They want Moses. They want to elevate him up. If it's only tyrant and slave, if it's only master and slave, there's no alternative.
- 8.28** So, Jethro tells Moses what to do. He says this is what you do: take your people, 150,000 or whatever they are, and divide them up into groups. Divide them into groups of 10, and then have the 10 elect from among their members their representative, the person they find most worthy. And when any of those 10 people have something to bitch about, they go to that person. And then, if he can't adjudicate the dispute, then

get those people together, the representatives, and get them to elect a representative of their own. And so, if the first representative can't adjudicate the dispute, then maybe the meta-representative can. Do that all the way up to groups of 10,000. And then, if that whole hierarchy can't adjudicate the dispute, then and only then, you step in. So, that's what's left for the king. The king does what everyone else can't or won't do, and that's all. That's called a subsidiary structure.

- 8.29** Now, God tells the Israelites that if they do that properly, they don't need a king. Later in the story, they get all whiny because they don't have a king, and then they end up with a king, and that doesn't go very well. But there's an idea here. It's a great idea, which is that you distribute the responsibility for sovereignty down a hierarchy of merit, meritorious responsibility, and you push all the decision-making you can to the lowest possible level.
- 8.30** So, what you would hope is that in the initial groups of 10, that all of those 10 people act like responsible people. And if they do, there's nothing for the representative to do. If they act like responsible, upward-aiming, God-fearing people pursuing ordered freedom, then there's no disputes, and the representative has nothing to do. But if that doesn't work perfectly, then you have the first representative and then the second. It's like the court system, all the way up to the Supreme Court. It's this hierarchy of responsibility.
- 8.31** So, what's the idea? The idea is that a hierarchy of responsibility is the antithesis to the tyrant and the slave. Nietzsche missed that completely. And so, that's not good; that's clearly not good. This also, in a way, reconciles the issue with regard to the equality and value of human beings. Because if you realized and then acted out the proposition that you were made in the image of God, and then had the capacity, let's say, to take full responsibility for your life, and you did that, there'd be no reason for tyrants and slaves.
- 8.32** So, there's a rule. This is a rule. I like this formulation: all responsibility that you avoid will be taken up by tyrants and used against you. So, what do you do? You take maximal responsibility at the local level; and if you do that, there's nothing left. There's no need for a tyrant; there's no tyrant, no slave. That whole dichotomy goes away. And what is that? That's the bearing of voluntary responsibility. And then you might think, what if you extend that and you find the principle?
- 8.33** Well, what's the principle? You take responsibility for your life. What's the extension of that? Well, what's your life? Vulnerability, subjugation to death, existence in the face of malevolence, all of that. It's all that opportunity, obviously. It's all the terror. It's all the catastrophe that goes along with that, all death and hell. And so, the responsibility is also taking responsibility for that.
- 8.34** Why? There'll be two reasons. You don't need a tyrant. How's that? That's a pretty good deal. You're not a slave. That's a pretty good deal, unless you want to be a slave.

And the Israelites liked to be a slave: "Someone's telling me what to do. How convenient." Yeah. Who's telling you what to do? That's the problem. And what are they up to? And what makes you think they have your best interests in mind, or your children, or the future?

- 8.35** And then you might say, too—and I think this is the existential element of that. People look for meaning in their lives, the meaning that sustains them through suffering. That's really what you would want if you were wise. That's better than happiness. This is something Solzhenitsyn pointed out: happiness, that's the principle by which you guide your life. What are you going to do when you're unhappy? Because that's going to happen. Then what? "Well, I never want to be unhappy." Then, you have this security-seeking issue that Nietzsche is trying to deal with. That doesn't work.
- 8.36** It's like, no, I would like to be able to prevail in spite of my misery. How about that? You could imagine that that might be possible. Well, that would mean that you would need a sustaining meaning that was profound enough, so that when suffering came, you could bear it. Where would you find that? Well, how about in responsibility? And you know that, too, because when you're looking at yourself autobiographically, and you're trying to find some memory that you can cling to with a shred of— what?—a shred of genuine self-regard, what you really search for is some evidence that, when things were tough, you—what?—conducted yourself admirably, despite the catastrophe. Right, and that'll keep you going through a very dark time. And so, what if that was the principle of your life? Where do you find that?
- 8.37** There's no difference between meaning and responsibility. There's no difference. There's no difference between opportunity and responsibility. They're the same thing. And if you take responsibility, you're not a slave; and if you take responsibility, you don't need a tyrant. That's why that principle, that people are made in the image of God and of intrinsic value, is correct, because if that was made fully manifest, so that you were capable of taking full responsibility for your life, then everyone would have the glorious Abrahamic adventure of their life. And there would be a kind of—what?—divine equality. That's the alternative to master and slave morality.
- 8.38** Now, I get Nietzsche's point. When he construed the world this way, which is how the people who think the world runs on power construe it—this is an oppressor-oppressed narrative; this is the postmodern insistence that this is how the world is constituted—Nietzsche said, the weak tend to take the side of the slave, and the strong take the side of the master. Fair enough. There's something to be said for that. But he missed the creative solution: How about neither of those? How about neither of those? What's the alternative? You conduct yourself like you're the sovereign of your own territory. Why? Because you should be and you are.
- 8.39** "In the first case, when the ruling group determines what is 'good', the exalted, proud states of the soul are experienced as conferring distinction and determining the order of rank. The noble human being separates from himself those in whom the opposite of

such exalted, proud states finds expression; he despises them. It should be noted immediately that in this first type of morality, the opposition of 'good' and 'bad' means approximately the same as 'noble' and 'contemptible.' (The opposition of 'good' and 'evil' has a different origin.)"

- 8.40** He's speaking historically here. He's speaking of societies like Rome, where there was a clear distinction between the aristocrats and the rabble. There was in Greece as well. Nietzsche is on the side of the aristocrats and contra the rabble, and that puts him in opposition to the prevailing spirit of pity that he finds contemptible and to the herd mentality that he finds mediocre. And as I said, fair enough. But the third solution is absent from the pattern of his thinking, and that's a terrible catastrophe.
- 8.41** He overlooks, like the postmodernists do, the proper uniting meta-narrative and the solution to the problem that he poses. His proposition is that "good" and "bad" in these aristocratic societies meant, like it did, let's say, in pre-Victorian England, aristocratic meant "noble" and "good," and rabble meant "bad." There was no ethic underneath that that was more sublime or profound, like good and evil. And Nietzsche is actually quite happy about that, because he's so appalled at the contemptible leveling capacity of the victim slave morality.
- 8.42** "One feels contempt for the cowardly, the anxious, the petty, those intent on narrow utility; also for the suspicious with their unfree glances, those who humble themselves, the doglike people who allow themselves to be maltreated, the begging flatterers, above all the liars. It is part of the fundamental faith of all aristocrats that the common people lie." The aristocrats lie, too. "'We truthful ones'—thus the nobility of ancient Greece referred to itself."
- 8.43** Even there, there's such a miss. What does Christ say? The truth will set you free. And he says, "I am the truth and the life and the way." I think that's right. What's the truth in that situation that Nietzsche misses in his conceptualization? The fundamental truth is the ability to look—the fundamental truth is the ability to look at hell directly without flinching. That's truth. That's something embodied in the way that Nietzsche wanted truth embodied. That's the truth that sets you free.
- 8.44** That's why Christ harrows hell, and that's to descend like Jonah into the depths after death, because it isn't only the confrontation with mortality and suffering, it's the confrontation with malevolence, the voluntary confrontation with malevolence. I think that's the worse problem, when you see people who are traumatized. They're rarely traumatized by suffering; they're virtually always traumatized by an encounter with malevolence—someone else's, but often their own.
- 8.45** This often happens to soldiers in battle. They find themselves in battle, especially if they're naive, let's say. And they watch themselves do something they cannot possibly imagine they could do, and enjoying it. And then everything crumbles, and that's the encounter with the Auschwitz guard who enjoyed his work. You think, how could that

be possible? It's like, think about it for a month. It's a terrifying thing to do, to do that to yourself, to think, okay—

- 8.46** When I went—I told you this story about this crazy psychologist that I met in the University of Alberta, who took me out to this maximum security prison. The first prisoner I met, this bloody psychologist, left me in this gym. I had this cape on that I bought in Portugal, and these boots, which I wore to the prison, which wasn't a good idea. I was in this gym, it looked like a high school gym, which I thought was very telling. The whole bloody prison looked like a high school; it's like, that figures.
- 8.47** And there's all these monsters in there that had been lifting weights, including this guy with a scar from here to here. It looks like someone had chopped him with an axe. This bloody psychologist left, and all these prisoners surrounded me in their orange uniforms, and they were offering to trade their clothes for mine, which was—I didn't know really exactly what to do about that. And this little guy came up and said that the psychologist had told him to bring me along, and so we started walking out in this yard. It was like the exercise yard. I thought, "Better him than these 30 monsters."
- 8.48** So, I was wandering out in the yard. And then the psychologist finally showed up on the door that went to the yard and motioned me back, and so I came back. This little guy, who's about this high, just a nondescript sort of character. He took me to his office, and he said, "You know that guy that you went for the walk in the yard with?" I said, "Yeah." "You know, he got stopped by police one night, and he was armed. And he took both of them, and he shot them in the back of the head while they were begging for their life and telling him that they had family." That was him, this little nondescript character. And so, that was very interesting to see that and to see what he was like. He was one of these, like, begging, flattery sort of people.
- 8.49** And then, another guy I met there, a week or two later, he'd taken a third prisoner, him and his crony had taken a third prisoner, and they took his leg, and they pulverized it with a lead pipe because they thought he was a rat, and I'd met him. And I spent a month thinking, "How could someone do that?" And it wasn't an abstracted question. I was trying to reconfigure myself so that I can understand how I could do that. If that was me, how could I do that? What would I have to be like to do that? Could I even be the person who could do that?
- 8.50** And so, I imagined that and realized, after a month, that I could do it, that I was a lot different than I thought. Did I dare to imagine I could enjoy it? There's a lot of dark nooks and crannies at the bottom of things, and they're worth knowing about, not least so you can avoid them. That was really, I would say, it was right around that time that my conscience really started to become undeniable. I told you the story about this voice that emerged in my head that was commenting on what I was saying, that almost everything that I was saying was some kind of instrumental lie, some desire for victory, rather than just a description of what was there.

- 8.51** "'We truthful ones'—thus the nobility of ancient Greece referred to itself." It was the nobility of ancient Greece that put Socrates to death. So there's a naïveté in Nietzsche's formulation here, which is the reverse of the naïveté of the postmodern, victim-victimizer narrative people. "All the oppressed are moral." No, definitely not. Nietzsche: "All the aristocrats are moral." No, I don't think so.
- 8.52** "It is different with the second type of morality, slave morality. Suppose the violated, oppressed, suffering, unfree, who are uncertain of themselves and weary, moralize. What will their moral valuations have in common? Probably, a pessimistic suspicion about the whole condition of man will find expression, perhaps a condemnation of man along with his condition. The slave's eye is not favorable to the virtues of the powerful. He is skeptical and suspicious, subtly suspicious, of all the 'good' that is honored there. He would like to persuade himself that even their happiness is not genuine.
- 8.53** "Conversely, those qualities are brought out and flooded with light, which serve to ease existence for those who suffer. Here pity, the complaisant and obliging hand, the warm heart, patience, industry, humility, and friendliness are honored. For here these are the most useful qualities and almost the only means for enduring the pressure of existence. Slave morality is essentially a morality of utility."
- 8.54** I think he's careless here, too. We're going to throw the warm heart out, are we? And we're going to throw out patience, industry, humility, friendliness? That seems like a bit much to me. And to replace that with what, the hard hand of the noble aristocrat? You can see how that philosophy degenerates into the Nazi worship of power pretty rapidly.
- 8.55** "Wherever slave morality becomes preponderant, language tends to bring the words 'good' and 'stupid' closer together." Jesus. Witty, brutally witty, brutally witty. That's a good line, man, that's for sure, and true. And the thing is, again, he didn't take his biblical lessons seriously enough. Like Cain, who's rebellious and murderous, Cain is not a slave, exactly. He's bitter and resentful, and he allows his oppression and failure to make him bitter and resentful. It's not even a direct consequence of the failure and oppression; it's a consequence of his decision to become resentful and bitter as a response to his failure. That's not slave morality, and it certainly has nothing to do with difference in status.
- 8.56** It's funny that this—I started reading Nietzsche when I was 17, so that's a long time ago. It's 45 years ago, a long time ago, and I've been thinking about it that entire time. I've been much more critical in this go-through of Beyond Good and Evil, this and the intro to Nietzsche, of course, than I expected to be and that I remember being. There's things I can see in Nietzsche's thought that are really fundamentally—for all his brilliance, for all his wit, for all the things that he did right, and so many things he did right—the core is, and I suppose it's because, after his pronouncement of the death of God, he was looking for a human replacement. That's what Eve looked for in the Garden of Eden, to put man, woman, at the center of existence and to take it upon

herself—himself in Adam's case—to define the moral order itself. It doesn't work. It's not wise.

**8.57** Piaget figured this out with kids. You have to negotiate. That means you discover, right? It's not like you impose. What would make you happy? Is there something we could do together? That's a discovery. It's not an imposition. Maybe I can make you an offer, but I have to see if the offer is acceptable or, more better, desirable. That would be better. There's a pattern to that. It's implicit in the nature of social being. That's not the imposition of your own standard of value.

**8.58** "Every very aristocratic morality is intolerant—in the education of youth, in their arrangement for women, in their marriage customs, in the relations of old and young, in their penal laws (which take into account deviance only)—they consider intolerance itself a virtue, calling it 'justice.'" So, he's conflating discipline with the nobility here, I would say.

**8.59** "In this way, a type with very few but strong traits, a species of severe, warlike, prudently taciturn men, close-mouthed and closely linked (and as such possessed of the subtlest feeling for the charms and nuances of such association), is fixed beyond the changing generations. The continual fight against ever constant unfavorable conditions is, as mentioned previously, the cause that fixes and hardens a type.

**8.60** "Eventually, however, a day arrives when conditions become more fortunate, and the tremendous tension decreases. Perhaps there are no longer any enemies among one's neighbors, and the means of life, even for the enjoyment of life, are superabundant. At one stroke, the bond and constraint of the old discipline are torn; it no longer seems necessary, a condition of existence—if it persisted, it would only be a form of luxury, an archaizing taste."

**8.61** There's wisdom in that, too. Nietzsche's comment there, essentially, is that it's difficult to maintain disciplined preparedness in the face of luxury and abundance. There are different moral conundrums that beset a society that's facing privation, and that beset a society that is luxuriating in abundance, which is certainly the condition in the West. How do you maintain your moral fiber in the face of plenty?

**8.62** I think it seems to me that the appropriate thing to do is to expand your purview of vision. If the immediate problems in your environment are solved, that doesn't mean all the problems for everyone, everywhere, are solved. There's still plenty to do. So, you have to, in the middle of that abundance, or even hedonistic abundance, you have to find the next level of responsibility. And then that's also the spirit on which that abundance depended to begin with, and it's also what allows for its continued expansion and distribution and the provision of more opportunity.

**8.63** This was William James' point: we need a moral equivalent to war. When there's no immediate enemy at the gates, let's say, including hunger or privation, that doesn't mean that there's no meaningful responsibility at hand. You just have to scale your

vision. If you put your house in order, there's always the town. And if the town is in order, there's always the state. There's always a frontier. There's always a place where the unknown is making itself manifest, always. You can search that out. There's always a frontier, always, everywhere.

- 8.64** "These acute observers and loiterers discover that the end is approaching fast, that everything around them is corrupted and corrupts, that nothing will stand the day after tomorrow, except one type of man, the incurably mediocre. The mediocre alone have a chance of continuing their type and propagating; they are the men of the future, the only survivors. 'Be like them! Become mediocre!' is now the only morality that still makes sense, that still gets a hearing."
- 8.65** That's the war against merit. "But this morality of mediocrity is hard to preach; after all, it may never admit what it is and what it wants. It must speak of measure and dignity and duty and neighbor love. It will find it difficult to conceal its irony." That's a great commentary on the culture war.
- 8.66** "There is an instinct for rank." That's actually an instinct for quality. It's an instinct for differentiating, discriminating between gradations of quality, which is something you definitely want, because if you're aiming at improving, you want to be able to discriminate between what's better and what's worse. And if you've accomplished the improvement, then you want to discriminate even more finally so the next improvement makes itself manifest.
- 8.67** This is also a problem with flattening, that the flatteners, the equality preachers, don't understand. If everything's equal—first of all, when everything's equal, everything's equal to zero. But when everything's equal, then what do you do? Because what you want to do is walk uphill. And if all the hills have been flattened out, there's no up. If there's no up, you might as well just lay in bed, because it's just as good to lay in bed as it is to not lay in bed, because everything's flat. So, the price you pay for the flattening of rank is the dissolution of meaning.
- 8.68** And so, Nietzsche's point here is, well, maybe you want to even exaggerate the difference in rank order because you want something worthwhile to pursue, and that means there's got to be a gradation of quality. And if there's a gradation of quality, there's judgment. Because what's of higher quality is better than what's of lower quality. But there's no polarity of meaning without that discrimination, which is a dirty word now, discrimination or judgment, for that matter.
- 8.69** And we know how your positive emotion systems work: if you're not pursuing a more valuable goal, there's no indication of progress forward. If there's no indication of progress forward, there's no positive emotion. Positive emotion marks progress forward and upward. Without a goal, which is without a gradation of rank, without discrimination of judgment, there's no positive emotion. Conversely, if your judgment is extremely discriminating, and the rank order is steep, then the journey becomes

extraordinarily worthwhile, because it's the ultimate treasure that's at the end of the pathway.

- 8.70** "The refinement, graciousness—there is a delight in the nuances of reverence that allows us to infer noble origin and habits. The refinement, graciousness, and height of a soul is tested dangerously when something of the first rank passes by without being, as of yet, protected by the shudders of authority against obtrusive efforts and ineptitudes—something that goes its way unmarked, undiscovered, tempting, perhaps capriciously concealed and disguised like a living touchstone.
- 8.71** "Anyone to whose task and practice it belongs to search out souls will employ this very art in many forms in order to determine the ultimate value of a soul and the unalterable, innate order of rank to which it belongs; he will test it for its instincts of reverence. The way in which reverence for the Bible has on the whole been maintained so far in Europe is perhaps the best bit of discipline and refinement of manners that Europe owes to Christianity; such books of profundity and ultimate significance require some external tyranny of authority for their protection in order to gain those millennia of persistence, which are necessary." Yeah, that turned out to be more true than Nietzsche thought.
- 8.72** "To understand one another, it is not enough that one use the same words; one also has to use the same words for the same species of inner experiences; in the end, one has to have one's experiences in common." That's very relevant to modern theories, let's say, of perceptual framing and shared identity. In the end, one has to have one's stories in common; that's more accurate. That's the foundation of a unified culture.
- 8.73** "Signs of nobility—never thinking of degrading our duties into duties for everybody; not wanting to delegate, to share, one's own responsibility; counting one's privileges and their exercise among one's duties. The greatest events and thoughts—but the greatest thoughts are the greatest events—are comprehended last; the generations that are contemporaneous with them do not experience such events; they live right past them.
- 8.74** "What happens is a little like what happens in the realm of stars. The light of the remotest stars comes last to men; and until it has arrived, man denies that there are stars there. 'How many centuries does a spirit require to be comprehended?' That is a standard, too; with that, too, one creates an order of rank and etiquette that is still needed, for spirit and star." And that's likely a good place to end. Let's end with this. "But what good is the pity of those who suffer? Or those who, worse, preach pity."
- 8.75** Nietzsche. *Beyond Good and Evil*, 1886. Part One: On the Prejudices of Philosophers. Part Two: The Free Spirit. Part Three: What Is Religious. Epigrams and Interludes, Part Four. Natural History of Morals, Part Five. Part Six: We Scholars. Part Seven: Our Virtues. Part Eight: People and Fatherlands, and Part Nine: What Is Noble. That's a walk-through part of one hell of a book. I don't know how much of it I read to you, but I don't imagine it was more than about a fifth.

- 8.76** I picked things that popped out at me, that I thought I had something to say about. But that doesn't mean that the rest of it isn't equally worthy of investigation. And I would say that's the case with pretty much everything he wrote.
- 8.77** So, what do we say about Nietzsche? It took me 40 years to understand what he got wrong. That's a long time. You have to be wrong in a very subtle and sophisticated way before the consequences of that error aren't made evident as a result of 40 years of contemplation.
- 8.78** I was very interested in his prognostications, the notion of the collapse of the ultimate unity, the death of God, the fact that that meant fractionation into hedonism, nihilism, ideological possession, this religion of pity, his prophecy about what was going to happen in the 20th century—which was dead on the money, just like Dostoevsky, all of that—his laying the groundwork for the psychoanalytic enterprise, his brilliant insight into perception and structure, and into the relationship between emotion and motivation and philosophical speculation, in his insistence that thought and emotion in action be unified in his romanticism, in his rejection of herd morality and that victimy slave morality that he detested so appropriately.
- 8.79** It took me a long time to understand why that slave-master morality distinction, because it seems like those are the two opposites. Could there be anything else that makes itself manifest? Certainly, the postmodernists, the Marxists, never had any conception whatsoever that that wasn't the entire universe: the oppressed and the oppressor, or the oppressor and the oppressed. Of course, the Marxists valorized the oppressed and called them moral, and Nietzsche took exactly the opposite tack, not least because he was so sick and tired of the pitying, bleating, faux morality of the envious, of the malicious envious, camouflaging their hatred for the successful in the guise of compassion.
- 8.80** He had every reason to be irritated, annoyed at that, to identify that with a certain kind of intellectual endeavor that he had contempt for. That's a lot to sort out. We're still sorting it out. We're still, really, at the dawn, I would say, of understanding, of any true understanding, of the resolution to the problems that Nietzsche put forward. Certainly Jung, Carl Jung, his school were possessed by that. Like, what's beyond good and evil?
- 8.81** The emergence of the unconscious, our belief that we can create our own values—that's what the humanists have done, that they can be human-centered, that we can self-actualize, that God has disappeared. And so, the human psyche now plays central role. Yeah, but the human psyche is full of devils; and God help us if they get the upper hand, which they did so frequently in the 20th century, always threatened to do and are threatening to do now. What's the alternative pathway forward?
- 8.82** The biggest, the most fruitful ground I found, the most fruitful pathway I found forward to answer those questions, was in the writings of people like Solzhenitsyn, who assessed the catastrophe of the Soviet Union, Dostoevsky, the school of Jung, and

those who analyzed the symbolic imagination and the religious enterprise, and who laid the groundwork for the realization of a third pathway forward that isn't slavery, that isn't tyranny, that's something completely different, that's associated with responsible conduct and voluntary confrontation with the terrors of death and hell.

- 8.83** So, that's where we're at, 25 years into the 21st century, and all the problems that Nietzsche laid out are still plaguing us, they're still with us, they're still unsolved. But we know more than we did 150 years ago. There's tremendous danger upon us and tremendous opportunity. And for me, a huge part of sorting that out was battling my way through this, through the thought of this man who philosophized with a hammer. Yeah. That's Beyond Good and Evil. Good. Thanks, everybody.
- 8.84** If one is cursed with having very high openness, what advice or lessons could one get from Nietzsche's teachings?
- 8.85** Well, Jung actually attempted to address that question in relationship to Nietzsche, and he was trying to account to some degree—and I don't know whether he was successful. We don't really know why Nietzsche became so ill and died so young. The same thing happened to his father. There's some speculation that maybe he had hereditary syphilis; we don't know. And there has been speculation that his own philosophy drove him to insanity. I don't buy that. I don't really see a pathology emerging in his philosophy that seemed to indicate some underlying psychiatric condition.
- 8.86** But Jung did say that if you're—and Jung wrestled with the same thing because he was insanely high in openness, visionary, like William Blake, powerful visual imagination. And he took refuge in a conventional form. And that's something that Nietzsche also really couldn't do, because he was so—his orientation was so antithetical to the conventional. It's like, there's not much difference between the conventional and the traditional. And there's not much difference between the traditional and the time-tested and the secure.
- 8.87** If you're open and you want to make something of it, maybe you can launch yourself out in an exploratory direction, or two or three exploratory directions. But there's things that you should—you should ground yourself, so that you don't drive yourself mad with your explorations. So, what does that mean? Marriage, family, friends, preoccupations or habits that are outside the creative domain so that you can step into something that's more conventional, if for no other reason than to have a rest.
- 8.88** And then I would also say, one of the real dangers of openness is that you fragment, because open people are interested in everything. Well, everything's too much, and so you have to apprentice. Nietzsche knew that. And I learned that in part from reading Beyond Good and Evil. Pick something. "What? I don't know what to pick." Pick something. Pick something. Guess. Guess. Pick that. And then pursue it and see. And maybe that's not the right thing, but if you pursued it for a while, a year, two years,

you'd know. You'd know why it wasn't the right thing, and then maybe your next guess would be better.

- 8.89** But the open people that I've mentored, for example, because I had a lot of open students, and some of them were also high in neuroticism, which is a rough combination, because open people have a very fluid identity. A lot of these people who talk about fluidity of identity, with the blue hair and the piercings, are all high in openness. I did a very early study at Harvard on pierced and tattooed people, when it was a new thing in the 19—it was like, circus people and criminals before that, and then the cool people started to have piercings and tattoos.
- 8.90** And we thought, is this a marker for psychopathology, or what's going on? So we assessed a bunch of early adopters. The only difference we could find between them was that the piercers and tattooers were really high in openness. It's the same with the green hair and all of that. It's no wonder they yell about fluidity of identity. They're open; of course, they think their identity is fluid. They're creative. And then if they're neurotic, that's even worse, because that's another kind of fluidity. It's instability on the emotional side. And so, if you're open and high in neuroticism, good luck to you, because you're constantly upsetting your apple cart with your creative thoughts, and you don't have the emotional resilience to tolerate the uncertainty. Brutal.
- 8.91** I had some open, relatively neurotic students, and the best thing for them—and this was seen in graduate students—is that they focused on something. Here's the task. Finish it. Well, that's that occasional will to stupidity that Nietzsche talks about. And the open person will think, "What about the opportunity cost? There's all these other things I could be doing." It's like, yeah, there's an infinite number of other things you could be doing, but you're not going to do all of them. So, what do you do? Do one of them. Get some discipline. Get some discipline. Get some discipline. Right, that'll stabilize you emotionally, because it starts to make things predictable. But then it also starts to—what? It starts to make your creativity into something actually productive, instead of just something potential. And so, pick something.
- 8.92** That's why Nietzsche says you have to obey something, and for a long time. We know that, because you have to be socialized if you're a human being. How deeply? I really believe that, at some point in your life, you should commit everything, for some time, to something. You say, "I'm going to try as hard as I can to make this relationship work." Maybe that's what you do if you're an agreeable person. Or you think, "Well, I've got this—"
- 8.93** It's funny because I've talked to a lot of young men about this. They come up to me, and they tell me this. Waiters have often told me this, because I'm in restaurants a lot. I remember one kid; he told me, in a restaurant in Toronto, he said he'd been—he was a smart kid, and he was kind of down on himself for working in a restaurant. He's a server, I think, the initial job was. Because he was down on himself, he was contemptuous of the job because it was sort of beneath him. And so, then he wasn't

really doing a very good job. And then he was in the enviable position of having a job that he had contempt for, that he was failing at. It's like, you want to make yourself miserable? There's a great strategy.

- 8.94** He had read 12 Rules, and he decided that he was going to work at this job. He was going to practice being grateful for the job. There are worse jobs than working in a restaurant. Working in a restaurant, you can think about that as simple, but you're an idiot if you think of it as simple, because it's not simple. You have to be hospitable, and the better you are, the better the restaurant. You have to get along with your coworkers. It's a high turnover environment. It's very variable in its workflow. You can be really good at it. And if you're really good at it, then everyone around you is a lot happier than they would otherwise be. The customers are satisfied, and the place starts to thrive.
- 8.95** So he started trying. He got three promotions in six months. He was a server for almost no time, because he started showing up to work, like, 20 minutes early. And if the people that ran the restaurant needed someone, he was there. If you're working in a place that's productive and intelligent, and you work, the person who's productive, intelligent, they're going to notice that real quick, and you'll have more work than you know what to do with real quick. Now, if you're in a dead-end job, the first thing you might ask is: Who's the dead end here? How hard are you trying? Now and then, people will get stuck somewhere where they work real hard, and all they get is punished for it. It's like, find another job. That's not a good place for you. If you're working, actually, and all you're getting is grief for it, you shouldn't be there. It's not a good place.
- 8.96** So, I don't think it matters where you are, what you commit to, really. It matters that you are somewhere and that you commit to it. And then you train yourself to do that. And then once you're trained, you can take that and do whatever. You can go to the next place with it.
- 8.97** I would also say we know the predictors for success in a complex society, basically. Openness is a predictor on the entrepreneurial side, but forget about that, because that's rare and difficult. Just forget about that for a minute. It helps to be smart. A lot of that's biological heritage. Sheer bloody effort. That's the next best predictor. Why? Obviously, the more time you spend at something, if you're working reasonably efficiently, the more of whatever it is you're doing comes your way. If you work 10% longer hours, you make 40% more money. There's a stat that's worth noting. And you can see why, too.
- 8.98** It's like this kid who was working at the restaurant. If he's there 10 minutes early and leaves 15 minutes late, it's not that much of an investment per day, and it just marks him out from everyone else. Then one day there's a crisis, and somebody doesn't show up for work that's in a higher position, and the boss is thinking, "Who the hell am I going to get? What about that kid who's always here?" It's like, bang. Then he does the

same thing there. People, most enterprises, you cannot believe how starving they are for competence. They're desperate for it. It's rare. They're desperate for it.

**8.99** This is true in political organizations, too. If you go join a political campaign and you work, you'll be terrified at how much responsibility you get quickly. You'll think, "Oh my god, they're asking me to do that?" Yeah, you're the best person they found. That's that Nietzschean phrase. He said, if someone falls in love with you, that should disenchant you with them. You go to a job, they offer you all this responsibility, and you think, "You're offering me this responsibility? That's how terrible the options are?"

**8.100** Discipline. It's hard if you're open, because you're fragmented. You're called everywhere. Focus. And the thing is, that works, too, for openness, because if you really focus on something, you find out it's way more complex than you thought. I'll give you an example of that, too. A lot of artists I talk to fail because they're contemptuous of marketing. They don't want to "sell out." First of all, who's asking you? It's like, "I wouldn't sell out." No one's asking you, actually.

**8.101** So, when someone comes along with \$20 million, and you say no, come and talk to me about not selling out. But when no one's knocking, you're not not selling out; you're failing. You can mask it with some idiot morality if you want, but it's not going to be helpful. "I don't like marketing." Well, you're not trying to do it creatively. You're not trying to sell junk to idiots. You're trying to communicate. Why couldn't you do that creatively? And why do you expect that your talent would be rewarded if no one knows it exists? No one's going to know if you don't communicate.

**8.102** "Marketing is lies told by used car salesmen." That's a good excuse for you never having to do it. Fine, fail. That'll be the consequence. You can take it even in a relatively constrained circumstance. If you really focus on it, you see possibilities there you wouldn't see otherwise.

**8.103** We know, too, from the literature on creativity, that creative production is enhanced by constraint; it's enhanced by constraint. There's this archive online. It's such a funny archive. I think MIT engineers conjured it up. It's the Spam haiku archive, and it's 50,000 poems written in haiku form about luncheon meat. And so, it's absurd, right? Because the haiku is an absurd poetic form. It's so constrained. And then to constrain it, even more ridiculously, to this glistening pork product that has no romanticism about it at all. It's very funny, and it's a very funny archive. But there's 50,000 poems there.

**8.104** It's a great illustration: throw some ridiculous rules in place, and all of a sudden, there's a whole universe for creative production that wouldn't have existed otherwise. It's a good way of thinking about limited jobs: Is this job limited, or is how I'm approaching it limited? If you've had ordinary jobs with great people, you can see that.

**8.105** I had jobs, like, I worked in a pizza restaurant at one point for a long time when I was a kid, with this, like, god, 30-year-old character. He had all his teeth knocked out from fights. He'd been an alcoholic for 10 years, and he was one of the wittiest and funniest

people I've ever met in my life. I loved working with him. He was a really good manager when he wasn't drunk. And when I saw him, he had quit drinking. I remember him very fondly. And was it an ordinary job? It was no more ordinary than any other situation. There's no ordinary situation. If you're bored by it and you think it's dull, maybe it's you. And if you're open, you could maybe transmute it a bit and see what's there. Next question.

- 8.106** Do you think that the reason that Nietzsche, so to speak, threw the baby out with the bathwater with Christianity is because he didn't fully experience it, in the fact that he didn't have a spiritual experience?
- 8.107** I think part of it is just sheer difficulty. Nietzsche was in the midst of the battle, you might say, between Enlightenment, humanism, the scientific method, and the apparent contradiction between those and the religious tradition. And he didn't know how to bridge the gap. So, some of it's just sheer difficulty. He obviously didn't have the kind of religious experience that tilted him in a Christian direction. And what's that?
- 8.108** Although it's so complicated because I've often thought that, in many ways, Nietzsche was the best friend Christianity had in the late 1800s, because he was its most astute critic, at least of the ways in which it had deviated; that's the way I would look at it. And so, I don't know. When something has become corrupt, its enemy might be the friend of its true spirit. And I would say, to the degree that Nietzsche was actually motivated by the pursuit of truth, it's hard to say exactly what side he was on.
- 8.109** If you read his work carefully, he's pretty positive about Christ. He's more negative about institutional religion, although he gives the devil his due there, too, because he talks about its disciplinary utility, and about the utility of the Judeo-Christian tradition. I don't think he— he's kind of like the modern atheists. People like Dawkins, Sam Harris, to a lesser degree, will say, "Wars are fought for religious reasons," and then when they look at it, they identify the religious with the totalitarian and the tyrannical. It's not a discriminating analysis.
- 8.110** First of all, chimpanzees go to war, so it's not about religion. That's the end of that. It might be about tribalism; and you could say that tribalism and the religious impulse are the same thing, but that's very careless thinking; it's very careless thinking, to just conflate those two things. You could say there are times during which the religious impulse, or its variants, feeds the pathology of tribalism. Fair enough. That's not the same as equating them. It's certainly not the same as equating the religious impulse with the totalitarian impulse. The atheists make that mistake.
- 8.111** Nietzsche wasn't differentiating enough in his judgment, and I don't think he separated the wheat from the chaff properly. There's a strain of progressivism that tainted Christianity, that he conflated with Christianity itself and its emphasis on the slave morality. And I think it was probably because he collapsed the moral universe too

simply. Tyrant: noble; slave: pathology. All the pathology isn't on the side of the slave, not all of it. Some of it, not all of it. And those aren't the only two categories.

- 8.112** And so, when he took a look at Christianity through that lens, he threw the Christians into the slave morality bin, and that wasn't a sufficiently differentiated analysis. It's funny because he wanders into territory where he gives the devil his due, but then he retreats to this, as we saw in the conclusion: master morality, slave morality. That's it. Where do the Christians belong? Well, they're not on the side of the masters; they must be on the side of the slaves. Those aren't the only options.
- 8.113** So, I guess I would also probably say he didn't take the biblical stories seriously enough in comparison to the philosophers, because there's not a lot of deep analysis of the stories themselves in the Nietzschean corpus. He credits the Jews with their philosophical insights, but he doesn't follow that through in the attempt to integrate those insights into the philosophical tradition. Maybe it's partly because it had become so secularized by that point, so divorced from the narrative foundation.
- 8.114** The other possibility, Nietzsche was a genius, and maybe he was a little more in love with his own intelligence than was—I don't know how much humility you have to have, when you're that brilliant, not to be arrogant. He might have been the smartest man who lived at his time. He might have been the smartest man who lived in the last 150 years. I mean, I've never read anyone who could generate as many high-quality ideas as Nietzsche. It's really something. So, keeping yourself on the ground when you have that gift, that's hard.
- 8.115** I have to contrast with the fact that he seemed to conduct himself in the public sphere without arrogance. People liked him, in the town he died in. And so, a little bit of arrogance, maybe. A tremendous amount of philosophical difficulty. Not enough concentration on the biblical stories themselves. And he didn't give the devil enough of a due. And maybe too early to make the realizations. There's only so much you can expect from one person. It was certainly people influenced by Nietzsche, the Jungian school, who laid out the alternative pathway, philosophically, to master and slave morality, or tyranny and slave.